Ascents

a piece to each week of the year

BOOK ONE

Bereshit

In the Beginning

Bereshit

Joseph and Judah in the Parasha

As is usual with all Torah portions, the name of the first is derived from the first word used in it: Bereshit, translated as "In the beginning." Much has been written about how the Torah begins with the letter Beit, the second letter, and not the first, the Alef. Beit signifies duality and multiplicity. The word that translate as beginning is Reishit, from the word Rosh, head. Therefore, despite Judaism's tremendous emphasis on the unity of G-d, and how the whole world is One, and we discussed in previous posts the importance of having only one leader, one head, the Torah itself begins with a word that can be easily understood as "Beit Reishit," two heads, two beginnings. The answer to why the Torah begins in simple: although G-d is absolutely One, by creating the world G-d introduced an element of duality and multiplicity.

Rashi's opening comment also appears to delve into this aspect of two beginnings by asking why the Torah does not actually begin in a different place, in the beginning of the discussion of G-d's commandments:

1. In the beginning of God's creation of the heavens and the earth.

RASHI - In the beginning: Said Rabbi Isaac: It was not necessary to begin the Torah except from "This month is to you," (Exod. 12:2) which is the first commandment that the Israelites were commanded, (for the main purpose of the Torah is its commandments, and although several commandments are found in Genesis, e.g., circumcision and the prohibition of eating the thigh sinew, they could have been included together with the other commandments). Now for what reason did He commence with "In the beginning?" Because of [the verse] "The strength of

His works He related to His people, to give them the inheritance of the nations" (Ps. 111:6). For if the nations of the world should say to Israel, "You are robbers, for you conquered by force the lands of the seven nations [of Canaan]," they will reply, "The entire earth belongs to the Holy One, blessed be He; He created it (this we learn from the story of the Creation) and gave it to whomever He deemed proper When He wished, He gave it to them, and when He wished, He took it away from them and gave it to us.

The beginning of Rashi's second comment on this verse again points to the theme of duality. G-d created the world for the sake of two "firsts:" the Torah and Israel.

In the beginning of God's creation of: Heb. בְּרֵאשִׁית בָּרָא. This verse calls for a midrashic interpretation as our Rabbis stated: [God created the world] for the sake of the Torah, which is called (Prov. 8:22): "the beginning of His way," and for the sake of Israel, who are called (Jer. 2:3) "the first of His grain."

The theme of duality is present in the Talmud (where there is a disagreement as to whether the world was created in Tishrei or Nissan) as well as in the Jewish calendar itself. While Rosh Hashanah is in Tishrei, the head of the months is actually Nissan. The source for Nissan being the head of the months is actually the verse quoted by Rashi:

2. This month [Nissan] shall be to you the head of the months; to you it shall be the first of the months of the year. (Exodus 12:2)

The duality between Tishrei and Nissan appears to relate to the contrast of the role of Hashem portrayed primarily as the One that creates us, judges and forgives us based on how we kept the Torah, and of Hashem as the One that redeems us, collectively and individually, and brings us to the Promised Land.

Rashi's first comment therefore can be understood as hinting to both beginnings, Tishrei and Rosh Hashanah.

Rashi's second comment is also related to this duality. While it is more common to place Israel ahead of even the Torah itself in terms of importance, Rashi first mentions the Torah, the blueprint of creation and the standard by which we are judged in Rosh Hashanah, and only then mentions Israel, which became a nation in Nissan at the time of the Exodus from Egypt.

This duality in the Jewish calendar is reflected in the Jewish people itself and in their two prototypical leaders: Judah and Joseph. Judah represents Nissan. Tishrei is

represented by Ephraim, the son of Joseph (his other son, Menashe represents the following month, Cheshvan). Judah is first and foremost a leader of the people, while Joseph's leadership is more detached, in a sense more connected to the Torah itself.

The tension, balance, and contrast between Judah and Joseph is very apparent in the way the Torah places the very parallel stories of Joseph and Judah side by side,[1] as well as in the depiction of their direct confrontation, in the Torah portion of Vayigash.[2] Even the names of these two tribes are similar, because Joseph sometimes is called "Yehosef," carrying the first three letters of G-d's name, Hashem, just like Judah.

This balance and tension has continued throughout our history, most notably with King David and King Shaul, the two kingdoms of Judah and Israel (also called Ephraim in the Torah), and even eventually with the coming of two Mashiachs, ben David and ben Yosef, also known as Mashiach ben Ephraim.

The following are excerpts from the Kabbalah of Time's appendix, further discussing this duality:

The Jewish calendar actually has two beginnings, one in Tishrei, on Rosh Hashanah, the head of the year, and the other in Nissan, on Rosh Chodesh Nissan, the head of "the head of the months." There is even a debate in the Mishnah regarding which of these days is linked to Creation (because, as mentioned above, Rosh Hashanah actually celebrates the creation of man, on the sixth day, the creation of the world would have been five days prior, either on the 25th of Elul (as is the final ruling) or the 25th of Adar). Both in the months of Nissan and Tishrei, Tachanun, supplication prayers, are not said.

There are also various important parallels and contrasts in both these sequences. For example, both Passover and Sukkot fall on the15th day of the 1st or 7th month, depending from which month the counting begins. Similarly, Tu B'Av and Tu B'Shvat fall on the 15th day of the 5th or 11th month, depending on which sequence is followed.

Interestingly, there is a custom to use the twelve days preceding Tishrei, from the eighteenth of Elul (Chai Elul) to Erev Rosh Hashanah to atone for the twelve months of the year, with Chai Elul representing Tishrei and Erev Rosh Hashanah representing Elul. In contrast, in the thirteen days from Rosh Chodesh Nissan to the thirteenth of Nissan, it is the custom to read the offerings brought by the princes of

the tribes during in honor of the inauguration of the Mishkan, the Tabernacle. Each tribe brought their sacrifices on a different day. As explained previously, each tribe represents a different month, and the sequence of tribes' offerings goes according to the months of the year, beginning with Judah (Nissan) and ending with Naftali (Adar I) and Levi (Adar II).

It is also fascinating that the Alter Rebbe's birthday is on Chai Elul, the first of the twelve days, representing Tishrei, while the birthday of the grandson he raised, the Tzemach Tzedek, is on Erev Rosh Hashanah, the last of the twelve days, representing Elul itself. Furthermore, the Tzemach Tzedek's yahrzeit is also on the last day of the reading of the princes, the thirteenth of Nissan. The yahrzeit of the Rebbe Rashab, the Tzemach Tzedek's own grandson, is on the second day of Nissan, at the very beginning of the reading of the princes.

In Kabbalah, another difference between Tishrei and the ensuring "winter months" and Nissan and the accompanying "summer months" (both of which have twenty six weeks) is that Tishrei represents the concept of Ohr Chozer (reflective light), while Nissan represents Ohr Yashar (direct light). On Tishrei, we initiate our return to G-d, and G-d responds accordingly – that is why the month is spelled with the last three letters of the Hebrew alphabet, in descending order, mirroring/reflecting the first three letters in ascending order. On Nissan, G-d is the one that initiates the relationship, taking us out of bondage, independently of (or even despite) whether or not we merit it. This contrast is connected to the kabbalistic concepts of Ita'aruta de L'tata (arousal from below) and Ita'aruta de L'Eila (arousal from above), and which of the two come first.

It is interesting to note that in the "winter months," from Tishrei to Adar, the animals in Perek Shirah comprise of birds, flying insects, and water animals, while those from Nissan to Elul are all land animals. From Tishrei on, we must first ascend to G-d, and in turn he descends to us. From Nissan on, Hashem first descends to us, and only then do we ascend to Him.

Rabbi Moshe Wolfsohn explains that this division is reflected even in the current differences between Chassidic and Lithuanian/non-Chassidic. Similar differences seem to exist between Ashkenazim and Sephardim, and baalei teshuvah (those who return to G-d, acknowledging their mistakes) and tzadikim gemurim (righteous one, who never sinned in the first place). Joseph is the prototype of the tzadik gamur,

while Judah of the baal teshuvah.

The prophet Ezekiel's vision of the Holy Chariot, Hashem's holy throne, has a lion on the right (the symbol of Judah) and an ox on the left (the symbol of Joseph). The same prophet Ezekiel, in the haftorah reading for Vayigash, is told by G-d to collect one stick for Judah and one for Ephraim, and to join them together, symbolizing that in future Yosef and Yehudah will become completely united.[3]

The Jewish calendar also contains another duality and synthesis: its days are counted in accordance with the cycles of the sun and the moon. While the West's calendar (based on the Roman one) is purely solar, and the Islamic calendar is purely lunar, the Jewish calendar has aspects of both. Each month in the Jewish calendar follows the moon, yet, as mentioned in Week 22, the Jewish year often contains two Adar months. This way, Passover always occurs in the spring, and all other months correspond to particular seasons accordingly. Here also, Joseph appears primarily associated with the year as a whole (countering Esau), while Judah appears to be primarily connected to the lunar months (countering Yishmael).

Noach

Miriam in the Parasha: Fixing Mankind

The Torah portion of Noah begins with a description of Noah's offspring, interjecting in mid-sentence, that Noah was righteous and wholesome in his generation and that he walked with G-d. It then states that Noah had three children: Shem, Cham, and Yaffeth.

Similarly, later in the portion (the beginning of the second aliyah), reads as follows:

1. And the Lord said to Noah, "Come into the ark, you and all your household, for it is you that I have seen as a righteous man before Me in this generation.

There appears to be an inherent contradiction in the second verse, which is also included in the first. If Noah was the only righteous man in the generation, why is his entire household saved? Wasn't the whole purpose of bringing about the Flood to cleanse mankind from all its corruption and start again out of the sole person that showed promise?

Was Noah's entire household righteous? Not only is that not implied in the above verses, but we also know that Cham acted extremely inappropriately once out of the ark (there's a debate as to what it was), which caused Noah not to have children. The Midrash states that Cham behaved inappropriately even while inside the ark as well.

We therefore see that the point of the Flood was not to rid the world of evil. We see that as well in Hashem's words to Noah after the Flood:

21. And the Lord smelled the pleasant aroma, and the Lord said to Himself, "I will no longer curse the earth because of man, for the imagination of man's heart is evil from his youth, and I will no longer smite all living things as I have done.

Rashi comments as follows:

from his youth: This is written מִנְּעָרָיו [i.e., without a "vav," implying that] from the time that he [the embryo] shakes himself [נִנְעָר] to emerge from his mother's womb, the evil inclination is placed in him. — [from Gen. Rabbah 34:10]

The Zohar comments that the verse, "Noah begot three sons," refers to three aspects of the soul, Nefesh, Ruach, and Neshamah.

Just as from the time a baby is born, he must struggle to fight his evil inclination, so too, humankind as a whole. Just as the qualities of a person are refined over time, so too the qualities of humankind itself.

Shem, Yaffet and Cham are three essential traits, which also parallel the three pillars that sustain the world stated in Pirkei Avot: Torah, Avodah (prayer), and Gemillut Chassadim (acts of kindness). They also parallel Avraham, Yitzchak, and Yaakov,[4] as well as Moshe, Aharon and Miriam.[5]

Shem means "name" in Hebrew. It therefore points to the aspect of truth in a person and parallels the Torah, as well as Yaakov, as in the phrase of our prayers, "Titen Emet L'Yaakov," "give truth to Yaakov." He also parallels Moshe, as in the statement of our sages, "Moshe Emet veToratoh Emet," "Moshe is truth and his Torah is truth."

Yaffet comes from the word "Yaffeh," beautiful, representing Avodah (prayer, Divine service) as well as Yitzchak (who represents self-sacrifice, prayer). He is also connected to Aharon, the High Priest;

Ham means "warm," representing Gemmilut Chassadim (acts of kindness), and parallels Avraham, known for his kindness and hospitality. He is also connected to Miriam, who was involved in delivering babies and saving them from Pharaoh's evil

intentions.

Miriam appears to have been a Tikkun (spiritual "fixing") for Cham. While Cham made it impossible for his father to have more children, Miriam saved children and helped deliver them. It was also Miriam's conversation with her father that led him to remarry her mother, which ultimately led Moshe's birth.

Yet, Miriam's Tikkun of Cham was not complete. Cham had also been guilty of slandering his father to his brothers. Miriam failed here, unfortunately speaking Lashon Harah (slander) about Moshe, even if with the best of intentions. Interestingly, the Torah relates that Miriam spoke about an "Isha Kushit," "a woman from Kush," who was a descendant of Ham. Perhaps the word Isha Kushit (repeated twice in the verse) is not only a reference to Tziporah, Moshe's wife, but also to Miriam herself.

Sha'ar HaGilgulim states that Moshe was a reincarnation of Shem, but also of Noah, who represents a combination of Shem, Yaffet, and Cham. The Shem M'Shmuel states that at the time of the sin of the golden calf, when G-d tells Moshe He will destroy the entire Jewish people and build a nation out of him, Moshe's response was a Tikkun for Noah, who failed to stand up for the rest of the people. Moshe responds, "Mcheni" (erase me [from your book]. which has the same letters as "Mei Noach," "waters of Noah," which is how the prophet calls the Flood (implying Noah's fault in the matter).

Lech Lecha

Efraim and Menashe in the Parasha: Underpromising, Overdelivering

The opening verses of the Torah portion of Lech Lecha is loaded with meaning. Rashi's comments elucidate their depth, but also raise interesting questions. Much has been written about the first verse, therefore this post will focus on verses two and three:

1. And the Lord said to Abram, "Go forth from your land and from your birthplace and from your father's house, to the land that I will show you.

2. And I will make you into a great nation, and I will bless you, and I will aggrandize your name, and [you shall] be a blessing.

3. And I will bless those who bless you, and the one who curses you I will curse, and all the families of the earth shall be blessed in you."

Below are a few of Rashi's comments:

And I will make you into a great nation: Since traveling (lit. "the way") causes three things: 1) it diminishes procreation, 2) it diminishes money, and 3) it diminishes fame (lit. name), therefore, he required these three blessings, namely that He blessed him concerning children, concerning money, and concerning fame.

and [you shall] be a blessing: The blessings are entrusted into your hand. Until now, they were in My hand; I blessed Adam and Noah. From now on, you may bless whomever you wish. (Gen. Rabbah) (ad loc.).

shall be blessed in you: There are many aggadoth, but this is its simple meaning: A man says to his son, May you be like Abraham. And so is every instance of [the words] "shall be blessed with you" in Scripture. And the following [text] proves this (below 48:20):"With you, Israel shall bless, saying: May God make you like Ephraim and like Manasseh." - [from Sifrei, Naso 18]

There are a few obvious questions here:

1) Rashi addresses three blessings that parallel three things that are diminished during travel. However, G-d gave four separate blessings, not three. Shouldn't Rashi list four concerns during travel as well, instead of three?

2) What is meant by G-d entrusting "the blessings" to Avraham? Which blessings? All blessings, or the particular ones mentioned in this verse?

3) What is the advantage of stating, "and the one who curses you I will curse?" Wouldn't it be better if no one cursed Avraham to begin with?

4) According to Rashi, G-d tells Avraham that "all the families of the earth" will say, "May you be like Avraham." Yet, we see that today we do not say, "May we you be like Avraham," but instead use the formula which Rashi uses in this very comment to prove his argument, "May G-d make you like Ephraim and like Menasheh." Based on this verse, people should also say, "May you be like Avraham!"

Perhaps we can arrive to an answer to these questions by examining a much later verse, found in the Torah portion of Ki Teitzei, in Chapter 23 of Devarim:

4. An Ammonite or Moabite shall not enter the assembly of the Lord; even the tenth generation shall never enter the assembly of the Lord.

5. Because they did not greet you with bread and water on the way, when you left Egypt, and because he [the people of Moab] hired Balaam the son of Beor from Pethor in Aram Naharaim against you, to curse you.

RASHI - Because: Heb. עַל-דְּבַר [lit., "because of the word," i.e.,] because of the [word of] advice they gave you (sic), to cause you to sin. — [Sifrei 23:114]

on the way: when you were in [a state of] extreme exhaustion. — [Sifrei 23:114]

6. But the Lord, your God, did not want to listen to Balaam. So the Lord, your God, transformed the curse into a blessing for you, because the Lord, your God, loves you.

The people of Ammon and Moab demonstrated qualities diametrically opposed to that of Avraham. While Avraham was known for his hospitality and kindness, serving his guests food and providing them with shelter (both physical and spiritual), Moab was cold, heartless, and selfish. Such people could not join "the assembly of the Lord."

Similarly, as also previously noted in this blog (http://www.kabbalahoftime.com/2014/07/words-in-desert-horrible-bosses-and.html), Balaam represented the exact opposite of Avraham. About Balaam, Balak states, "whomever you bless is blessed and whomever you curse is cursed." (Bamidbar 22:6) As also noted before in this blog, the contrast between Avraham and Balaam is explored in Pirkei Avot (5:19):

Whoever possesses the following three traits is of the disciples of our father Abraham; and whoever possesses the opposite three traits is of the disciples of the wicked Balaam. The disciples of our father Abraham have a good eye, a meek spirit and a humble soul. The disciples of the wicked Balaam have an evil eye, a haughty spirit and a gross soul.

What is the difference between the disciples of our father Abraham and the disciples of the wicked Balaam? The disciples of our father Abraham benefit in this world and inherit the World To Come, and as is stated, "To bequeath to those who love Me there is, and their treasures I shall fill" (Proverbs 8:21). The disciples of the wicked Balaam inherit purgatory and descent into the pit of destruction, as is stated, "And You, G-d, shall cast them into the pit of destruction; bloody and deceitful men, they shall not attain half their days. And I shall trust in you" (ibid., 55:24).

1) The above verses from Devarim do in fact point to a fourth danger of travelling (again, lit. "on the way"): the curse of an evil eye. A person becomes susceptible to it

if he/she sins. One becomes particularly susceptible to sin if he/she is exhausted.

2) Hashem's entrusting Avraham with the blessings points to the qualities instilled in him and his students/descendants that serve as a shield against Ammon and Moab in general, and Balaam in particular. A person's best defense against the evil eye is for the person him/herself not be envious or haughty, but instead have a "good eye, a meek spirit and a humble soul." Such qualities lead to the desire as well as the power to bless, to give.

3) G-d delivers much more than He promises. Not only would Hashem curse the one that wished to curse the Jewish people, but instead He did not even allow the curse to take place at all.

4) Similarly, Hashem's blessing of having all the families of the earth say, "May you be like Avraham," will certainly one day be fulfilled as well on a literal sense, in an even greater measure. In fact, the blessing given today already hints to this greater level of fulfillment. "May G-d make you like Ephraim and like Menasheh," is a reference to the blessing given by Jacob that the children of Efraim and Menasheh (who are in fact an extension of Avraham), "will multiply like fish over the land," "Veyidgu LaRov BeKerev Ha'Aretz."

The above blessing speaks to the growth and the numerous descendants promised to Avraham, yet also includes an additional blessing, possessed by fish and also by all the descendants of Joseph: protection against the evil eye (mentioned above). The Talmud (Berachot 55b) states:

"The fish in the waters are concealed by the water, and thus not susceptible to the Evil Eye. So too, the descendants of Joseph are not susceptible to the Evil Eye."

By blessing each Jewish child with a reference to Efraim and Menashe, we expand Yaakov's blessing to all the Jewish people, while at the same time more than fulfilling the original blessing with which Hashem blessed Avraham.

May we merit to see the fulfillment of all of the G-d's promises and blessings to the Jewish people (and much more), with the coming of Mashiach, speedily in our days!

We hereby complete a full cycle of comments on Torah portions. Baruch Hashem L'Olam, Amen veAmen.

Vayera

Uriel in the Parasha

I am sitting in the Beis Midrash of Young Israel of Tampa, Beis Menachem, jewishusf.com, after receiving tremendous Hachnassat Orchim (the commandment of hospitality) from Rabbi Uriel Rivkin and his family. By the way the address here is 52nd street. :)

The parallels with the Weekly Parasha are very powerful, and Hashem, out of His infinite mercy, enlightened me with an answer to a question I had earlier this week, before I had any idea I'd be coming here, or that the Rabbi's name is Uriel. The question is as follows:

We know that the three angels who visited Abraham and Sarah were Micha'el, Gavri'el and Refa'el. Each had a special mission to accomplish, as Rashi explains. However, we know there are not three, but four archangels. Why was Uri'el not present? Why did he not have a particular mission that would entitle him to be a guest as well?

The answer is simple. Uriel was there all along! Uriel, which means G-d is my light, could be found in Abraham and Sarah's tent, as we also know that Sarah's Shabat lights remained lit from week to week, just like the Eternal Light (the Ner Tamid) of the Temple.

Furthermore, Uriel is in fact mentioned in this week's Parasha, in the very first verse, in the very first words. The portion begins: "Vayera Elav Hashem... VeHu Yoshev Petach HaOhel." "Vayera El," spelled, Vav Yud Resh Alef Alef Lamed, has the same letters of "Uri'el." Where exactly is Uriel? "Hu Yoshe Petach Ha'Ohel," he was living at the entrance of the tent, with Avraham and Sarah. The portion states in different places that both Avraham and Sarah were "Petach Ha'Ohel." This actually explains why the Torah makes a point of stating right after the first verse that Avraham ran to meet the guests "MiPetach HaOhel," from the entrance of the tent. The first verse is referring to Uriel! Otherwise, if it were just referring to Abraham, it would have been superfluous.

The practical lesson is that by having guests, not only do you merit receiving angels for that particular meal or occasion, but also the light of Hashem resides with you contnuously. Your house embodies Hashem's archangel, whose job is to guide us,

to give us light, to enlighten us: the angel Uriel.

Chayei Sarah

The Four Exiles in the Parasha

The Torah Portion for this week describes Avraham's test and struggle to bury his wife, Sarah, in the Land of Israel. This was a particularly difficult test of faith given that Hashem had promised him the Land from the very beginning, and here he is having to negotiate purchasing a burial plot for his wife while her body is still before him, with people of very questionable morality and motivations.

Sarah is ultimately buried after a plot is purchased in Hebron, known also as Kiryat Arbah, which means the "City of Four." The "Four" is a reference to the four couples buried in there: Adam and Eve, Abraham and Sarah, Isaac and Rebeccah, Jacob and Leah. It is also a reference to the four giants that lived there: Sheshai, Achiman, Talmai, and their father.

The four giants of Kiryat Arbah appear to be clear references to the four main exiles. The first is Sheshai, a reference to Babylonia. Sheshai is a "surname for Babylonia" and also spells the word Bavel (Hebrew for Babylonia) in the numerical transposition known as "Atbash" (Jastrow Dictionary). The Midrash states that this giant had this name because he was made of marble (Shaish in Hebrew) – this appears related to the Nebuchadnezzar, the emperor of Babylonia, who had statues made in his honor.

The second giant, Achiman, appears to be a reference to Persia-Media. His name appears to be a contraction of the names Achashverosh and Haman, the main enemies of the Jewish people in the Purim story. It also appears to reference their action as "brothers" against us. This exile was also a dual one, as it is the combination of two empires, Persia and Media.

The third giant, Talmai is a clear reference to Greece, whose leader in the times of Greek exile was Talmai, Ptolomy in English.

The fourth giant is not given a name. He is referenced simply as the father of the other three. This is the exile of Edom (Rome), the "father" of the exiles, the longest and harshest by far. This exile also has characteristics of all the previous ones.

The four giants/exiles also appear to parallel the four couples. Sheshai/Babylonia (Bavel), is reminiscent of the Tower of Babel, a generation which Avraham had to confront directly - particularly its leader, Nimrod. Avraham is also known for destroying the statues of his father.

Achiman/Persia is an exile and the Purim story are characterized by extreme self-sacrifice, a characteristic of Isaac and the Akeidah, as we saw last week. The Torah also makes references to how Isaac and Rebecca prayed together for a child, and how much of what happened to Isaac and future generations were actually determined by Rebecca's actions, such as the blessing of Jacob over Eisau.

Talmai/Greece was primarily about an affront to the Torah, its Divine origin, and its lifestyle. Torah is mainly a characteristic of Jacob. Jacob, Ish Tam (a wholesome, "simple/straightforward" man) stands in contrast to the godless (or pantheistic) "sophistication" of the Greeks.

The father of the giants/Rome, involves all of humanity. Pax Romana reached the entire world, and in many ways we are still under it today. Edom is Eisav, who was red, also symbolic of Mars and of his military prowess. Adam and Eve represent all of humanity, yet Adam is also an acronym of three people: Adam (himself), David, and Mashiach. David was also red. He was a "kosher" version of Eisav and of the potential that he so badly missed. Mashiach son of David, will come and redeem the entire world, fixing the curse of the snake, and bringing the world back to its fullness and potential, like that of Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden.

Toldot

David in the Parasha

I once knew a lady that would always give very forceful advice to young girls that were trying to find a husband: "Don't marry potential," she would say. What that basically meant was, "Don't marry someone for what they can become. Marry them for what they are now." My father once also gave a similar kind of "pearl of wisdom": "When a couple gets married, the woman wants the man to change... and he doesn't. The man doesn't want the woman to change... and she does."

Are we able to change? If so, why not "marry potential?"

The Lubavitcher Rebbe has a very interesting explanation as to why Isaac seemed at first to love Esau more than Jacob. The Torah states that Isaac loved Esau because he was had "game/hunt in his mouth." Rashi states that he was able to "catch" Isaac with his mouth, pretending to be the utmost saint around him, to the extent that he would even ask Isaac how to tithe salt. Salt, by the way, does not need tithing according to Jewish law, but Esau wanted to show his father that he wished to go above and beyond the letter of the law.

The Rebbe explains that salt is symbolic of potential. By itself, it tastes bad and is basically inedible, but combined with other foods is can not only give taste, but even preserve them. (Remember, there were no refrigerators back then). Isaac saw Esau's tremendous potential. His soul was from even a higher source that Jacob's (Tohu versus Tikkun), and Isaac would love nothing more than to take all that vitality, all that fierceness and hunting prowess, and bring it to the side of holiness. Essentially, he wanted to elevate Esau.

Rebecca, on the other hand, knew that Jacob was the one that was to lead the Jewish people. She saw in her son Jacob, the tzadik, who embodied all that is true and holy and spent all his time in the tents of study, the power to be able to handle the physical challenges of the world as well, not just the spiritual. Ultimately, that is why in order to receive Isaac's blessings, Jacob had to be enclothed with the garments of Esau, and why Isaac himself, when he is about to bless Jacob, says "the voice is the voice of Jacob, and the hand is the hand of Esau."

That, in fact, appeared to be the ideal. To be able to have the knowledge and the spiritual sanctity of Jacob, along with the physical prowess and this-worldliness of Esau. Jacob would spend the rest of his life earning the blessing he receives from Isaac. When he wrestles the angel of Esau and wins, he then is so changed from his original stature, that he is given a new name, Israel. The name Jacob was related to the "heel" and, as Esau himself points out, the fact that he was able to outwit Esau twice. The letters of the name Israel stand also for Yashar-El, "the straight one of G-d," as well as Li-Rosh, "to me is the head." Jacob received the blessing through machinations of someone that was at the heel. He now deserved them straight out, as someone that was at the head.

How come then, was Rebecca right in trusting Jacob's potential, yet Isaac so wrong in trusting Esau's? Perhaps the answer is as follows: it was something intrinsic

to their nature. Our sages state that Esau was born "hairy," complete already, like a man. The Hebrew name Eisav can be read as Assui, finished, complete. He was not interested in changing. He was already complete. The commentaries state that he didn't value the right of the firstborn, and was really to exchange it for a bowl of red soup, because deep inside he realized that he couldn't live up to its physical and spiritual demands, and that he wasn't going to change in order to make himself worthy.

Jacob, on the other hand, had smooth skin, he was like a child, still able to fulfill his potential. He was also willing to go along with his mother's request to dress like Esau and "deceive" his father, even though he was completely devoted to truth, and that seemed to go against his very nature. He was willing to change.

Perhaps that is all the difference. Willingness to change, to be young. That it what Rebbe Nachman of Breslov teaches. The evil inclination is called an "Old Fool," because it fools you into thinking that you are old, when in truth it is all in your mind. There is no such thing. Every day is a new day, and never be afraid to start again. Right now.

That is the secret of King David's success. As we mentioned last week, David was a "kosher" version of Esau. He had the "clothes of Esau" - the outward appearance, as he was red like Esau and had the same military prowess - yet he was completely righteous as well. More than that, he had inherited his forefather Yehudah's quality of being able to admit one's mistakes and repent. He never let himself stay down. He was always ready to start anew. Like his forefather Jacob, he was always willing to change. He therefore was the ideal, and so will be our future and last redeemer, Mashiach Ben David, the Messiah son of David.

When Rebecca takes the clothes of Esau and gives them to Jacob, they are described as Chamudot. The part of the verse reads: "Rebbeca took the clothes of Esau, her big son, the Chamudot (desired, plural).

Rashi explains that Esau desired (Chamad) the clothes and took them from Nimrod [after he killed him]. The Sifsei Chachamim further states that the clothes had originally been from Adam, who wore them in the Garden of Eden. Rebecca was now elevating the clothes back to their proper place.

The gematria of David ben Yishai is 14+52+320=396.

The gematria of the words, "the clothes of Esau," Bigdei Eisav, is 19+376 (+1 kollel) = 396.

The "great" son of David was Daniel, his direct descendant, who is called Ish Chamudot, the desired man. The Talmud in Sanhedrin states that if the Messiah comes from the dead, he will be like Daniel. The Messiah will bring the world back to its proper state, that of the Garden of Eden before the sin of the snake.

Vayetzei

Jerusalem in the Parasha

This week's Torah portion begins with the description of Jacob's journey outside the Land of Israel. It also describes the tremendous revelation he had while on the way:

10. And Jacob left Beer Sheba, and he went to Haran.

11. And he arrived at the place and lodged there because the sun had set, and he took some of the stones of the place and placed [them] at his head, and he lay down in that place.

12. And he dreamed, and behold! a ladder set up on the ground and its top reached to heaven; and behold, angels of God were ascending and descending upon it.

13. And behold, the Lord was standing over him, and He said, "I am the Lord, the God of Abraham your father, and the God of Isaac; the land upon which you are lying to you I will give it and to your seed. (...)

17. And he was frightened, and he said, "How awesome is this place! This is none other than the house of God, and this is the gate of heaven."

18. And Jacob arose early in the morning, and he took the stone that he had placed at his head, and he set it up as a monument, and he poured oil on top of it.

19. And he named the place Beth El, but Luz was originally the name of the city.

There are many many questions regarding these verses, and incredible interpretations and commentaries, particularly from Rashi. For example, why do the verses state that Jacob gathered "some stones" to place on his head, but then state that "he took the [single] stone that he had placed at his head?" What exactly do the angels represent, and why are they ascending and descending?

One question that seems to particularly intriguing is perhaps the most basic of them all: where did Jacob have the dream? Was it in a town known as Beth-El (a city

in the area of the tribe of Benjamin)? Was it at Mount Moriah? Be'er Sheva itself? Opinions vary, with even one commentary stating that the place of the dream was actually Mount Sinai.

Furthermore, if the place of the dream is one of the above, why does Jacob give the place another name, "Beth El," the House of G-d, and why the Torah go through the trouble of telling us that the original name of this place is also none of the above, but is in fact "Luz?"

With so many questions, Rashi's commentary is probably the best starting point. He first states that "The Holy One, blessed be He, folded the entire Land of Israel under him." He later brings a Midrash that explains that the bottom of the ladder stood in Be'er Sheva, while its top stood in Beth-El, the boundary between the territory of Benjamin and that of the "sons of Joseph." The middle of its incline was opposite the Temple, on the boundary between Judah and Benjamin.

Rashi goes on to state that he believes that Mount Moriah was "uprooted from its place," and came to where Jacob was, in Luz. Additionally, he brings a statement that Jacob went all the way to Haran, and then regretted not praying where his father and grandfather had prayed. He therefore went back in the direction of Jerusalem, and that it was on his way there that Mount Moriah, came to him, in Beth-El, which is close to Jerusalem.

Rashi concludes with another statement from the Talmud (Pes.88a) [concerning the verse] (Micah 4:2):" 'Come, let us go up to the Mount of the Lord, to the House of God of Jacob.' [It is] not [called] as did Abraham, who called it a mountain, and not as did Isaac, who called it a field, but as did Jacob, who called it the House of God."

The first of Rashi's comments above makes clear that Jacob's physical location is not as crucial as his spiritual one, because the entire land was "under his head" while he was dreaming. It was as if he was in the entire land at the same time.

Rashi's other sources seem to be related to the spiritual qualities of Jerusalem as much as its physical ones. The first Midrash brought by Rashi shows Jerusalem's role as a unifying force among the Tribes. The ladder goes from the lower boundary of Judah (Be'er Shevah) all the way to the upper boundary of Benjamin (Beth-El), just like Temple itself was built on the boundary between these two tribes. The ladder ties together the different dimensions of the Jewish people, the descendants of Leah (Judah) and those of Rachel (Joseph and Benjamin)

Rashi's comment regarding the fact that Mount Moriah met Jacob on his way back to Jerusalem, points to the idea that as much as there is a physical Jerusalem, there is also the Jerusalem inside each one of us, and that a person is where his mind is. If a person's every desire is to be in Jerusalem, this is where he/she is. Where a person places their head, this is where the head of the ladder is as well. We can go by the physical Jerusalem and not feel it, but the spiritual one, we can feel even when we are not there physically.

Regarding the third part of Rashi's commentary, there is a clear progression (heard once from a rabbi at Yeshiva University). Abraham called the Temple Mount a mountain, Isaac called it a field, and Jacob called it a house. We go from a place of complete "wild" (mountain), to one in which nature is present in a more subdued form, tamed by mankind (field), to one that is completely "civilized" (home). By connecting back to previous generations, and by our own efforts, we make a greater and greater home for G-dliness in this world. And as stated in Midrash Tanchuma, and as often stated in Tanya and Chabad Chassidic philosophy, the whole purpose of this world is because G-d desired a dwelling in the lower realms.

We are told that Beit-El, the Home of G-d, was originally called Luz. Before we make a dwelling place for G-dliness, G-d's light is hidden. Hidden inside each one of us, and hidden inside each part of creation.

The Talmud teaches that when Hashem created the world, for the first 36 hours of Adam's life, he had clear vision in which he could see from one end of the world to the other end. This light, which was connected to the Sabbath, lasted from the time Adam was born (Friday at noon) until Saturday night. 36 in Hebrew is written Lamed Vav. The Sabbath, the 7th day, is connected to the 7th Hebrew letter Zayin. Lamed Vav Zayin spells Luz.

Because of Adam and Eve's mistake, the original 36-hour light had to be hidden, and death was introduced into the world. However, each of us has a Luz bone, an indestructible part of us from which we will be resurrected when Mashiach comes. This bone is nurtured solely from the food that we eat on Melaveh Malkah. Rav Dessler explains that because this bone did not derive any nurture from the forbidden fruit (eaten on Friday), it never tasted death, and that is why it is indestructible.

With the coming of Mashiach, Luz, the little hidden bone will be built into an everlasting body, our own personal temple. The original city of Luz, the hidden Divine light of creation, will be built into an everlasting House of G-d.

All of this is connected to the month that has just begun, Kislev. Kislev stands for Kis (Hidden) Lamed Vav (36). This is the month of Chanukah, in which we light 36 candles, deeply connected to the original 36 hours of Divine light. Chanukah means dedication, literally, the dedication of the Temple in the times of the Maccabees. It is on this month that we dedicate ourselves to the idea of the Temple and Jerusalem. We also dedicate ourselves to purifying our minds and bodies of all impurity, so that the light can be fully revealed.

Vayishlach

Korach in the Parasha

The Torah portion of Vayishlach speaks of the dramatic encounter between Jacob and Esau. In their exchange, much has been written between the different approaches to life of the two. Esau says, "Yesh Li Rav," usually translated as "I have a lot," while Jacob states, "Yesh Li Kol," "I have everything [I need]." It brings to mind the expression from Pirkei Avot, "Who is rich? He who is satisfied with his portion." Much has also been written about what "Kol" means. In Kabbalah, Kol is explained as a reference to the sefirah (attribute) of Yesod, foundation. Jacob is now able to stand firm against his murderous brother Esau.

Esau's use of the word "Rav" is also quite fascinating. It can mean "much," but can also mean "master" or "superior." Esau is intrinsically stating, probably without acknowledging it consciously, that Jacob is his superior. This seems to be supported by Rashi's comment on this verse:

9. But Esau said, "I have plenty, my brother; let what you have remain yours."

ט. וַיֹּאמֶר עֵשָׂו יֶשׁ לִי רָב אָחִי יְהִי לְךָ אֲשֶׁר לָךְ׃

let what you have remain yours: Here he acknowledged his (Jacob's) right to the blessings (Gen. Rabbah 78:11).

יהי לך אשר לך: כאן הודה לו על הברכות׃

The Hebrew translation of the whole verse could very well be: "But Esau said, "I have a superior - my brother. Let what is yours remain yours."

There are two other instances in which a similar expression is used. Moshe says to Korach and his fellow Levi rebels, "Rav Lecha Bnei Levi," this is [too] much for you sons of Levi. Later, when Moshe asks for 515 times to come to Israel, G-d also uses the same expression, "Rav Lecha," it is [too] much for you. Much has been written about the connection between these two statements as well. Both times, it may be understood that what is being said to both Moshe and the sons of Levi is that they have a superior, a Master. This also ties into one of the early themes of Pirkei Avot and of Rosh Hashanah: Ta'aseh Lecha Rav - make for yourself a Master. (see Book 1, Week 1)

We know that Esau did not do Teshuvah in his lifetime, but perhaps his potential for Teshuvah, and the spark of good in him can be found here is as well. In acknowledging his brother's superiority, and that the blessings his brother took from him, even if somewhat deceitfully, are nonetheless his to keep, Esau is getting closer to one day, one day acknowledging the ultimate truth: he too has One Master.

Vayeshev

Rachel in the Parasha

In honor of the birth of Levanah Rachel bat Shimon Yehezkel, may she grow up healthy and happy, to a life of Torah, Chuppah, and Maasim Tovim.

The Torah portion of this week introduces us to one of the most central figures in all of Torah: Joseph. His story begins with the tension that existed between him and his brothers, a tension that Joseph himself helps fuel by telling them of two of his dreams that portray him as superior and the center of attention. The first dream involved sheaves bowing down to him, and the second involved stars. In the second dream, not only do the brothers (the stars) bow to him, but even his father and mother (sun and moon).[6] Jacob reprimands Joseph for the dreams, yet keeps them in mind and awaits their fulfillment.

Jacob's reprimand is particularly harsh in that it makes reference to Rachel's passing (Joseph's mother), stating, "will I and your mother bow down to you," as if alluding to the fact that it could not be fulfilled. Here is the original text, with Rashi's commentary in grey:

9. And he again dreamed another dream, and he related it to his brothers, and he said, “Behold, I have dreamed another dream, and behold, the sun, the moon, and eleven stars were prostrating themselves to me.”

אֹתוֹ לְאֶחָיו וַיֹּאמֶר הִנֵּה חָלַמְתִּי חֲלוֹם עוֹד וְהִנֵּה הַשֶּׁמֶשׁ וְהַיָּרֵחַ וְאַחַד עָשָׂר כּוֹכָבִים מִשְׁתַּחֲוִים לִי׃
ט. וַיַּחֲלֹם עוֹד חֲלוֹם אַחֵר וַיְסַפֵּר

10. And he told [it] to his father and to his brothers, and his father rebuked him and said to him, “What is this dream that you have dreamed? Will we come I, your mother, and your brothers to prostrate ourselves to you to the ground?”

וַיֹּאמֶר לוֹ מָה הַחֲלוֹם הַזֶּה אֲשֶׁר חָלָמְתָּ n.הֲבוֹא נָבוֹא אֲנִי וְאִמְּךָ וְאַחֶיךָ לְהִשְׁתַּחֲוֹת לְךָ אָרְצָה׃
י. וַיְסַפֵּר אֶל אָבִיו וְאֶל אֶחָיו וַיִּגְעַר בּוֹ אָבִיו

And he told [it] to his father and to his brothers: After he told it to his brothers, he told it again to his father in their presence.

ויספר אל אביו ואל אחיו: לאחר שספר אותו לאחיו חזר וספרו לאביו בפניהם:

his father rebuked him: because he was bringing hatred upon himself.

ויגער בו: לפי שהיה מטיל שנאה עליו:

Will we come: Isn’t your mother (Rachel) already dead? But he (Jacob) did not know that the matters referred to Bilhah, who had raised him (Joseph) as [if she were] his mother (Gen. Rabbah 84:11). Our Rabbis, however, derived from here that there is no dream without meaningless components (Ber. 55a/b). Jacob, however, intended to make his sons forget the whole matter, so that they would not envy him (Joseph). Therefore, he said,“Will we come, etc.” Just as it is impossible for your mother, so is the rest meaningless.

בניו שלא יקנאוהו, לכך אמר לו הבוא נבוא וגו', כשם שאי אפשר באמך כך השאר הוא בטל: כאמו. ורבותינו למדו מכאן שאין חלום בלא דברים בטלים. ויעקב נתכוון להוציא הדבר מלב הבוא נבוא: והלא אמך כבר מתה. והוא לא היה יודע שהדברים מגיעין לבלהה, שגדלתו

11. So his brothers envied him, but his father awaited the matter.

יא. וַיְקַנְאוּ בוֹ אֶחָיו וְאָבִיו שָׁמַר אֶת הַדָּבָר׃

awaited the matter: Heb. שָׁמַר. He was waiting and looking forward in expectation of when it (the fulfillment) would come. Similarly,“awaiting (שׁוֹמֵר) the realization [of God’s promise]” (Isa. 26:2), [and]“You do not wait (תִּשְׁמוֹר) for my sin” (Job 14:16). You do not wait. [From Gen. Rabbah 84:12]

מתי יבא, וכן (ישעיה כו ב) שומר אמונים וכן (איוב יד טז) לא תשמור על חטאתי, לא תמתין: שמר את הדבר: היה ממתין ומצפה

Again, there are many questions here: Why does Joseph tell the dreams, knowing that they would probably incense his brothers further? If Jacob awaits the dreams' fulfillment, why would he want to negate it in any way, since it is well known that dreams are fulfilled according to their interpretation?

The first question is dealt extensively by many commentaries. There are many answers, the most prominent one perhaps is that these dreams were prophetic, and a prophet is not allowed to withhold prophecy under the penalty of death.

As noted above, Rashi addresses the second question, stating that Jacob spoke in this way to try to deflect some of the hatred that his brothers were feeling. Still, his answer seems particularly harsh, in light of how traumatic it must have been for Joseph to lose his mother at a young age, as well as how traumatic it must have been for Jacob himself.[7]

Certainly, Joseph was well aware about his mother's fate. Jacob did not need to emphasize that. Perhaps Jacob's question about whether Rachel would come with them to prostrate herself to the ground was not simply rhetorical, but was actually alluding to something much deeper.

Joseph's dreams portray him as a foundation for his brothers, but one dream is related to physical matters (sheaves), while the other, the one that includes his parents, is related to spiritual ones. Perhaps, on a deeper level, Jacob's question had to do with how Rachel would remain alive in this world on a spiritual level.[8]

Our sages state that Yaakov Avinu Lo Met, "Jacob our father did not die." Just as his offspring are alive, so is he. As long as his message is alive, he is still alive. If this was true of her husband, it certainly should be true about Rachel Immeinu as well. She also did not die. Spiritually, both Jacob and Rachel are alive today, because their children are alive, and so is their message. In general, we say that the righteous are even more alive after their death than before. (Tanya)

Rashi states that Bilhah brought Joseph up like his mother. Perhaps what is key here is not that she treated him like her own child, but that she behaved like Rachel, a true emissary of Rachel. Bilhah had been so influenced by Rachel that she kept her ways. (That would also help explain why Jacob did not move his bed to Leah's tent, even after Rachel's passing)

In Kabbalah, Rachel represents Malchut, which is also what the moon represents. The sun represents Chochmah, and Jacob is the sun.[9] Malchut is the ability to take

something powerful and abstract and reflect it in such a way that can be absorbed, that can be brought into the reality of this physical world.

However, in order for Malchut to be able to perform its task, it must first be subservient to Yesod. The sefirah of Yesod, is the foundation for all the other sefirot, including Malchut.

Perhaps, on a deeper level, Jacob now understood that through Joseph, who represents the sefirah of Yesod, all the other Divine attributes and all their spiritual work and legacy for the future, including Jacob's and Rachel's, would now be able to emanate and be brought down all the way down into the most physical aspects of this world (Artzah, to the ground) and elevate the world in its entirety.

To this, Jacob was very much looking forward.

Miketz

Daniel in the Parasha

This week's Torah portion describes Joseph's rise to power, after he had faced so much suffering and difficulties. His salvation comes through correctly interpreting Pharaoh's dream. Before giving his interpretation, Joseph famously states, "Bilada'y," the interpretation does not come from me, but from G-d. After years of hardship, Joseph saw very clearly that all that we have, including any successes along the way, comes from G-d, not us.

Joseph's power to interpret dreams brings to mind the prophet Daniel, who perhaps is more famously known for the fact that he was saved from the lion's den. Chapter 2 of the Book of Daniel depicts how, not only was Daniel able to interpret the emperor's dream, he actually had to tell the emperor the dream itself, because the latter had forgotten it. Daniel, like Joseph, attributes all of his success to G-d.

Just like Joseph received a new name from Pharaoh, Tzafnat Pa'aneach (revealer of hidden secrets), so too does Daniel receive a new name from the Babylonian emperor: Belteshazzar. Rashi explains that "Bel" is a name of a Babylonian god, and that "Teshazzar" is an Aramaic expression denoting wisdom. Perhaps one can also interpret the name to mean that wisdom come from being in the state of "Bli" (feeling devoid of something), as in Joseph's statement, "Bilada'y." Regarding "Bilada'y," Rashi comments: "בִּלְעָדָי. The wisdom is not mine, but God will answer."

These letters, Beit and Lamed, are the very first and the very last letters of the Torah. Much has been written about how, when inverted, they form the word Lev, heart, and how the letters have the numerical value of 32, of the "32 Paths of Wisdom," often mentioned in this blog). Perhaps equally important is the understanding that wisdom comes from Beit-Lamed, from Joseph's Bilada'y and Daniel's name, Belteshazzar, which also are contained respectively in the beginning and in the end, of the Tanach. (In Kabbalistic texts, it is explained that the Hebrew word for "wisdom," Chochmah, also stands for Koach Mah, the power that comes from knowing that we are Mah, "what/nothing.") This is in fact the beginning and the end of all of history, since, as we learn in Proverbs, wisdom was created before Creation itself, and the Talmud states that Mashiach, if he comes from the dead, will be like Daniel.

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Why does the Talmud (Sanhedrin 98b) state that if Mashiach comes from the living, then he is like Rabbeinu HaKadosh (Rabbi Yehudah HaNassi), and if he comes from the dead then he is like Daniel, Ish Chamudoth (the desired man)? In my humble opinion, this statement has to be understood in light of another Talmudic statement (Berachot 18a-b), that the righteous are called alive even after their death, while the wicked are called dead even while they are alive. (This was touched upon slightly in last week's parasha's blog post, here)

Rabbeinu HaKadosh is the quintessential Tzadik Gamur (completely righteous). He said about himself that he did not benefit even "a little finger" from this world. In line with the above, Sefer Chassidim states that even after his passing, he would come to his home on Friday evenings to make Kiddush for his family.

Daniel, like Rabbeinu HaKadosh, is a direct descendant from quintessential Ba'alei Teshuvah, King David and Judah. Daniel is also the Ba'al Teshuvah. He was punished by Heaven for a mistake he committed when advising the evil Nebuchadnezzar. He told the emperor to give tzedakah and thereby stave off Divine retribution. The Talmud (Bava Basra 4a) states that the character of Hatach in the Purim Megillah is none other than Daniel. Hatach means "cut off," a reference to how, according to one opinion, Daniel was demoted from this position. According to the other opinion, Hatach is a reference to how royal matters were "Nechtachin" (decided) through him. There are two opinions as to Daniel's punishment: either it

was that he was demoted from his position in government or that it was that he was thrown into the lion's den.

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Daniel's being thrown to the lion's den is also connected to the story of Joseph, who was thrown into a pit by his brothers. This brings us back to last week's Parashah, in which Torah states that, "the pit was empty, it had no water." Rashi asks, why does the Torah need to tell us that it had no water, if it already told us it was empty: "תלמוד לומר אין בו מים, מים אין בו אבל נחשים ועקרבים יש בו: [To inform us that] there was no water in it, but there were snakes and scorpions in it. [From Shab. 22a, Chag. 3a]"

Here again, like in last week's blog (here) there is an example of how the Torah is one long name of Hashem, and that the text's spacing can be read slightly differently in a way that includes Rashi's interpretation:

"And they took him and cast him into the pit; now the pit was empty there was no water in it. And they sat down to eat a meal." In Hebrew:

וַיִּקָּחֻהוּ וַיַּשְׁלִכוּ אֹתוֹ הַבֹּרָה וְהַבּוֹר רֵק אֵין בּוֹ מָיִם: וַיֵּשְׁבוּ לֶאֱכָל לָחֶם

It was pointed out to me recently, that וַיֵּשְׁבוּ, could be read as וַיֵּשׁ בּוֹ, "and there was in it," which the same terminology used by Rashi. It was noted to me that the following letter is a Lamed, which is shaped like a snake or a scorpion. I believe that perhaps a better interpretation is that וַיֵּשׁ בּוֹ לֶאֱכָל לָחֶם, should be read as, "and there was in it something that could eat [Joseph] as a meal" or could "make him hot" (leCham), like the venom of a snake.

Interestingly, when it comes to Joseph, not only is it not considered a miracle that Joseph was saved from the snakes and scorpions, but in fact, the Torah states that this was Reuben's plan to save Joseph, by taking him away from his brothers and out of the pit later.

(It is worth noting that the Torah does not make this miracle explicit like it does regarding Daniel. Similarly, Abraham's miracle regarding the fiery furnace is also not made explicit, while the Tanach states unequivocally that Daniel's colleagues, Mishael, Chananiah, and Azariah, were saved after being thrown into a fiery furnace as well).

There are many explanations regarding Reuven's actions, and how they could be considered by the Torah to be an act of saving Joseph. The Orach Chayim states,

based on the Zohar, that men have free choice while animals do not. Another explanation I heard from Rabbi Moshe Matts, is the principle of Netzach Yisrael Lo Yishaker, when it comes to issues of the eternity of the Jewish people (and in this case, the continuity of the Tribes of Joseph), the world does not have a say: our continuity is a given, and therefore the snakes and scorpions could not touch Joseph.

Perhaps a simpler answer is that both in the case of Daniel and Joseph there was not any doubt that they would be saved because from the time of Creation, G-d placed the fear of man upon the animal kingdom, because man has a Tzelem Elokim, the Divine image. Daniel did not lose this image, and therefore the animals feared him. (Zohar Shemot 125B) Similarly, Joseph had also not lost his Tzelem Elokim, and therefore the snakes and scorpions feared him as well.

Finally, it is also fascinating to see how that the animals related to the tests of Daniel and Joseph, lions and snakes and scorpions, respectively, are related to the two men. As mentioned before, Daniel is a descendant of King David and Judah, who were known in the Torah as "lions." Joseph says about himself, "Haloh Yedatem Ki Nachesh Yenachesh Ish Asher Kamoni." Nachash in Hebrew means snake. Joseph was particularly capable of fighting off the Primordial Snake, the yetzer harah, such as in the case of Potiphar's seduction.

Even the dreams which each of the two great men had to interpret were very much connected to their respective personal stories. Pharaoh's dreams had cows and ears of grain. Joseph is compared to an ox by Jacob and Moshe, and one of his own dreams described in the Torah contained sheaves of wheat. Pharaoh's dreams were about seven years of plenty followed by seven years of famine, and Joseph himself had experienced, more than once, how disaster can strike unexpectedly and one can go from the highest highs to the lowest lows.

Nebuchadnezzar's dream was about how his kingdom would decay and diminish in power over the generations, and Daniel himself had just experienced how the Davidic dynasty had decayed and become corrupted until ultimately conquered by Nebuchadnezzar himself.

Hashem has special ways of preparing us for the challenges we face. Life's tests are a preparation and a rectification, a tikkun, the purpose of which we often do not understand at the time. Sometimes we have to go through so much in order to be ready for what is to come. The Davidic dynasty was "cut off" only to rise again in

Messianic times. May it be soon, and may we merit to see with our own eyes all that for which we have been preparing so arduously and for so long.

Vayigash

Oded in the Parasha

In this week's Torah portion, Judah confronts Joseph, who he believes is the viceroy of Egypt. Judah tells him (again) about everything his father Jacob has been through: his loss of Joseph, how attached he is to Benjamin, etc. Almost immediately after that moment, Joseph reveals himself to his brothers. The words used by Joseph, however, are quite enigmatic. "Ani Yosef HaOd Avi Chai?" "I am Joseph, is my father still alive?"

After all the talk about Jacob, including Joseph's own questions about his father, how can Joseph possibly be asking them if their father is still alive? Perhaps the question is simply rhetorical, as in, "how could my father possibly still live after such suffering?" Perhaps the question is referring to Jacob's spiritual life (as discussed in the past weeks)? Or perhaps this is not a question at all.

One way of punctuating the sentence would be: Ani Yosef, HaOd Avi, Chai. I am Joseph, the "Od" (the "more, the extension, addition to") my father, is alive. This interpretation would be in line with the interpretation of the first verse of the Torah portion of Vayeshev: Eleh Toldot Yaakov: Yosef. "These are the generations of Jacob: Joseph. Joseph is the continuation of Jacob. Their lives parallel each other in many incredible ways. These parallels are explored extensively by the Midrash: both had brothers that wanted to kill them; both had to go into exile, etc.

Another way of punctuating the verse would be as follows: Ani Yosef: HaOd. Avi Chai. I am Joseph, the "Od." My father is alive [now]. Jacob had the confidence to face Eisav once Joseph was born. Joseph was fundamental to his confrontation of Eisav. Perhaps once Joseph was lost, Jacob felt lost not just because he lost his son, but because his son was so important in Jacob's ability to fight the forces of evil and death. That is why, now, Jacob would become alive again. That is exactly what happened. What Jacob heard the news, the Torah states: Vatechi Ruach Yaacov, the spirit of Jacob became alive. Next week's portion is called Vayechi, "and Jacob lived."

The words used by Jacob when hearing his son was alive are: “Rav, Od Yosef Bni Chai,” usually translated as “Enough! My son Joseph is still alive!” Rashi reads Rav and Od together, interpreting to mean, Rav Od Li, I have enough happiness and joy because my son Joseph is still alive. Interestingly, Jacob’s words include “Rav” (which is the word Eisav used to Jacob when acknowledging the birthright. See Korach in the Parasha, here). When Jacob’s children tell him the news they also state “Od Yosef Chai.”

The word Od is intrinsically connected to Joseph. It goes back all the way to his mother Rachel’s naming him. At the time, she states, “Yosef Li Ben Acher,” may [Hashem] and to me one more son. Joseph embodies the idea of “adding,” of expansiveness, of Od. Od also appears to be related to one of the names of Mashiach Ben Yosef, Oded. (See previous post about this here)

Rebbe Nachman of Breslov also gives great importance to the word and the concept of Od. In what is arguably the basis for all his other teachings (Torah Reish Peh Beis (#282)), Rebbe Nachman connects Od to the concept of finding good points in others and in ourselves. He takes this from a verse in the Book of Psalms: “Od Me’at v’Ein Rasha,” “a little more and there is no evil person.” If you find some little good in a person, you can change the scale of justice and bring that person to the side of merit, where they are no longer evil. Rebbe Nachman also interprets another verse from the Psalms, “Azamra L’Elokai b’Odi,” “I sing to my G-d with my Od,” to mean that through judging ourselves favorably we can come to sing to G-d.

Every Jew has this spark of good, this Od, this Yosef HaTzadik within us that can tip the scales of justice in our favor and bring us to life, true life, in which we are constantly increasing and growing. That is the message of Joseph, who is connected to the attribute of Yesod (today was Yesod shebeYesod shebeGevurah), and is also one of the fundamental guiding principles of the Lubavitcher Rebbe in his life: he was never satisfied with past accomplishments; he was always looking to grow, to “increase in holiness.” This is also the message of Chanukah, in which, every day, we add more light until one day, hopefully soon, we will light up the entire word and darkness will no longer prevail.

Chodesh Tov and Chanukah Sameach!!!

Vayechi

Shechem in the Parasha

This week's Torah portion describes Jacob's time in Egypt, particularly the blessings he gave to Joseph's two sons, Ephraim and Menashe, as well as those given to each of his twelve sons before Jacob's passing.

Jacob gives Joseph a double inheritance, making each of his sons, Ephraim and Menashe, one of the twelve tribes to inherit the Land of Israel. Interestingly, Jacob's statement giving Joseph the birthright has also been interpreted as Jacob giving Joseph the city of Shechem, where Joseph is ultimately buried:

22. And I have given you one portion [Shechem Achad] over your brothers, which I took from the hand of the Amorite with my sword and with my bow."

RASHI:

And I have given you: Since you are taking the trouble to occupy yourself with my burial, I have given you an inheritance where you will be buried. And which is this? This is Shechem, as it is said:"And Joseph's bones, which the children of Israel had brought up out of Egypt, they buried in Shechem" (Josh. 24:32).

one portion over your brothers: Heb. אַחַד עַל אַחֶיךָ שְׁכֶם, the actual [city of] Shechem, which will be for you one share over your brothers. [Accordingly, we render: Shechem, [which is] one [share] over your brothers.]- [from Gen. Rabbah 97:6] Another explanation:"One portion" refers to the birthright, and indicates that his (Joseph's) sons should take two shares. שְׁכֶם is a word meaning "a portion," as the Targum renders. There are many similar instances in Scripture:"For You shall place them as a portion (שְׁכֶם)" (Ps. 21:13), You shall place my enemies before me as portions;"I will divide a portion (שְׁכֶם)" (ibid. 60:8);"...murder on the way, שְׁכְמָה " (Hos. 6:9), [meaning:] each one his share;"to worship Him of one accord שְׁכֶם) (אֶחָד" (Zeph. 3:9), [meaning: in one group].

which I took from the hand of the Amorite: From the hand of Esau, who behaved like an Amorite (Gen. Rabbah 97:6). Another explanation [of why Esau is called אמֹרִי]: who deceived his father with the sayings (אִמְרֵי) of his mouth.

with my sword and with my bow: When Simeon and Levi slew the men of Shechem, all those [nations] around them (Jacob's sons) assembled to attack them, and Jacob girded weapons of war against them. — [from Gen. Rabbah 97:6, Targum

Jonathan ben Uzziel]

with my sword and with my bow: I.e., his cleverness and his prayer.

Rashi's comments point to the many distinct facets of the city Shechem, and the rich meaning of the place. First, Rashi mentions Shechem's role as a place of burial, given as a reward for performing this great mitzvah. Joseph performing this mitzvah leads to an incredible "chain of mitzvahs," performed by ever higher entities. The mitzvah of burying Jacob is charged to Joseph, whose burial is charged to Moses, whose burial, in turn, is performed by Hashem himself. (See Talmud Sotah) After Moshe passes, it is Joshua, a descendant of Joseph from the Tribe of Ephraim, who is charged with actually burying Joseph inside the Land of Israel. Interestingly, the passage quoted by Rashi is actually juxtaposed with Joshua's own passing. Even more fascinating is the fact that both Joshua and Joseph were 111 years old when they died. One could speculate about whether Joshua and Joseph were not in fact one and the same.

Rashi then explains how Shechem is associated with the extra portion of the firstborn. Shechem has many other associations with being the "first:" Shechem is the first place visited by Abraham, Jacob, as well as Joshua when entering the Land of Israel. Even in modern times, the first settlement established in Judea and Samaria after the Six Day War was Elon Moreh, which is another biblical name for the city Shechem. Shechem is the gateway to the Land of Israel.

Related to the above, Rashi then notes that Shechem was taken from Eisav, who behaved like an Amorite and lied to his father. Jacob is characterized by the fact that all of his children remained true to their Judaism and Jewish identity (Mitatoh Shleimah - "his bed was complete"). Furthermore, Jacob is associated, first and foremost, with the truth ("Titen Emeth L'Yaakov," "Give truth to Jacob"). The Torah also states that Shechem was acquired monetarily by Jacob (similar to how Jacob acquired the birthright), and that it is one of the places that Gentiles are unable to even claim that they were stolen by the Jews. (Genesis 33:18-19; Midrash Rabbah)

That said, Rashi mentions the radical actions of Shimon and Levi. It was also in Shechem that Joseph's brothers, led by the zealotry of Shimon and Levi, attacked Joseph and sold him as a slave. After Reuven's sin, Shimon and Levi were both in line to be the leaders of the rest of the tribes. However, their zealous violence prevented them from playing this role.

Finally, Rashi interprets the words used to describe weapons ("bow" and "sword") as a reference to cleverness (wisdom) as well as prayer. Often, much more can be accomplished through these two more peaceful means than through violence. The power of Jacob is his Torah and his prayer - "Koloh Kol Yaakov," "the voice is the voice of Jacob, while force is primarily the weapon of Eisav - "Yadoh Yad Eisav," "the hand is the hand of Eisav."

Shechem is Jacob's inheritance to Joseph. It is more than just a place. It is a way of being. It stands for all that was mentioned above and more: keeping the mitzvot, leadership, identity and continuity, truth, passionate moderation, Torah, wisdom, and prayer. Shechem in Hebrew, literally means "shoulders." It is as if Jacob is now passing the torch to Joseph, who is now literally "shouldering" the responsibility for keeping these values intact.

We see a hidden reference to the values of Shechem much later in history, with the appointment of Saul as King of Israel (I Samuel, Chapter 9):

1. Now there was a man of Benjamin, and his name was Kish, the son of Abiel, the son of Zeror, the son of Becorath, the son of Aphiah, the son of a Benjamite man, a mighty man of power. 2. And he had a son whose name was Saul. He was young and handsome, there being no one of the children of Israel handsomer than he; from his shoulders (Shichmoh) and upwards he was taller (Gavoah) than any of the people.

Just like Joseph received a Shechem (portion; shoulder) over his brethren, so too was Shaul taller than all his brethren, from his shoulders upwards. He was also young and handsome like Joseph.

Shaul also had another similarity to Joseph. Just as Joseph had experienced all his brothers attack and nearly kill him, so too had Shaul seen all the other tribes nearly extinguish his tribe, the Tribe of Benjamin, in a bloody civil war that followed the events of Pilegesh b'Givah, the concubine of Givah.

As recounted extensively in the end of the Book of Judges, men of Givah had raped and brutally murdered a concubine woman. The Tanach's account directly parallels the story of Sodom and Gomorrah. There are even opinions that these men of Givah were a reincarnation of those of these two infamous places. All the Tribes of Israel demand that the Tribe of Benjamin hand over the men that performed this outrageous act to be killed, but Benjamin refuses. This leads to civil war.

Herein lies also a parallel with Shechem. The man called Shechem (presumably for whom the city is named after) raped Dinah, the daughter of Jacob. Because the men of Shechem refused to bring the rapist to justice, Shimon and Levi decimated the entire city. Maimonides writes that the acts of Shimon and Levi were in fact justified under Jewish law.

Joseph is given Shechem. Shaul, who had the potential for becoming Mashiach Ben Yoseph, is from Givah. In fact, he even rules all of Israel for a short period from Givah itself. (I must admit that I am not 100% certain that Givah refers to the same city as the concubine of Givah, but I have no reason to believe otherwise). Both Shechem and Givah are places that suffered tremendous atrocities in response to lack of justice, and both become associated with the respective leaders of the generation.

Furthermore, the reason why Shaul does not become Mashiach Ben Yoseph is because of his failure to decimate Amalek, when explicitly told by the prophet Samuel to do so. Shaul has all the values and characteristics that Jacob passes Joseph, connected to Shechem, including passionate moderation, wisdom and prayer. He was also the first, the first King of Israel. However, he appears to be deficient in the most important of all values, the very first one listed by Rashi: the accurate performance of a mitzvah. That is Samuel's ultimate rebuke to Shaul after the debacle of not utterly destroying Agag and Amalek: "And Samuel said, "Has the Lord as great delight in burnt-offerings and sacrifices, as in hearkening to the voice of the Lord? Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice, and to hearken than the fat of rams..." (Samuel I, Chapter 5:22)

Mordechai and his generation, in their fight against Haman the Agagite, somewhat rectify Shaul's mistake by showing ultimate self-sacrifice in order to fulfill God's commandments. The introduction of Mordechai, the last of the male prophets, in the Megillah (Esther, 2), very much parallels the introduction of Shaul in the Book of Samuel:

5. There was a Judean man in Shushan the capital, whose name was Mordecai the son of Jair the son of Shimei the son of Kish, a Benjamite, 6. who had been exiled from Jerusalem with the exile that was exiled with Jeconiah, king of Judah, which Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, had exiled.

However, there is one radical difference between Mordechai and Shaul. Even though both are from Benjamin, while Shaul is primarily associated with Joseph and

Givah/Shechem, Mordechai is explicitly connected to Judah (particularly the King of Judah) and Jerusalem, which both represent total nullification and self-sacrifice.

Benjamin is a combination of Judah and Joseph. He represents the sefirah combination of Yesod shebeMalchut. As previously explained, Joseph represents Yesod and David, Malchut. Even geographically, the land of Benjamin connects the land of Judah and of Joseph. (See "Jerusalem in the Parasha," here) Benjamin connects these two facets of the Jewish people and of Jewish History.

Although Elijah (who, although from Benjamin, is clearly associated with the Tribe of Joseph, and Elijah even states explicitly that he is descended from Rachel) and Mashiach Ben Yoseph will pave the way of the redemption, ultimately, it all must be connected to Judah, to Mashiach Ben David. As we read in last week's Haftorah (Ezekiel 37):

19. Say to them, So says the Lord God: Behold I will take the stick of Joseph, which is in the hand of Ephraim and the tribes of Israel his companions, and I will place them with him with the stick of Judah, and I will make them into one stick, and they shall become one in My hand.

20. And the sticks upon which you shall write shall be in your hand before their eyes.

21. And say to them, So says the Lord God: Behold I will take the children of Israel from among the nations where they have gone, and I will gather them from every side, and I will bring them to their land.

22. And I will make them into one nation in the land upon the mountains of Israel, and one king shall be to them all as a king; and they shall no longer be two nations, neither shall they be divided into two kingdoms anymore.

23. And they shall no longer defile themselves with their idols, with their detestable things, or with all their transgressions, and I will save them from all their habitations in which they have sinned, and I will purify them, and they shall be to Me as a people, and I will be to them as a God.

24. And My servant David shall be king over them, and one shepherd shall be for them all, and they shall walk in My ordinances and observe My statutes and perform them.

25. And they shall dwell on the land that I have given to My servant, to Jacob, wherein your forefathers lived; and they shall dwell upon it, they and their children

and their children's children, forever; and My servant David shall be their prince forever.

26. And I will form a covenant of peace for them, an everlasting covenant shall be with them; and I will establish them and I will multiply them, and I will place My Sanctuary in their midst forever.

27. And My dwelling place shall be over them, and I will be to them for a God, and they shall be to Me as a people.

28. And the nations shall know that I am the Lord, Who sanctifies Israel, when My Sanctuary is in their midst forever.

May it be soon, may it be today, may it be now.

BOOK TWO

Shemot

Names

Shemot

Purposeless Work

This week, we start reading the Second Book of the Torah, the Book of Redemption, Exodus (Shemot, "Names" in Hebrew). It begins by listing the names of the Jewish people that descended to Egypt and then almost immediately describes how they were enslaved and how they suffered. The kind of labor the Jewish people were subjected to was called "Avodat Parech," commonly translated as "back-breaking labor," according to Rashi's explanation.

13. So the Egyptians enslaved the children of Israel with back breaking labor. 14. And they embittered their lives with hard labor, with clay and with bricks and with all kinds of labor in the fields, all their work that they worked with them with back breaking labor.

There are many explanations as to what is meant by Avodat Parech. According to Rashi, the work was simply physically hard, crushing the bodies of the Jews. According to other explanations, however, what made the labor so detrimental was that it "broke the spirit" of the Jews, in that it was often wasteful and unnecessary: men were made to do women's work and vice-versa; the cities that they built for the Egyptians were Arei Miskenot, "pitiful cities," purposefully built on sand so that they would collapse and need to be built again. This kind of work makes the slave feel that he has no purpose, that he is worthless.

Deep inside, each one of us has a yearning to feel that he or she is needed; that their task in life is worth something. If that feeling is taken away, one is left with nothing.

Why was it necessary for the Jewish people to feel this intense loss of purpose? Perhaps it would later serve as a reminder for them. Instead of being purposeless servants of the Egyptians, they would serve the ultimate purpose as servants of G-d. This brings to mind the prayer said at the time one leaves a Jewish House of Study (Beit Midrash):

What does he say when he leaves? "I am thankful to You, the Lord my God, that You have placed my lot among those who dwell in the beit midrash and not with those who hang around street corners. They arise early, and I arise early. I arise early for words of Torah, and they arise early for idle matters. I toil, and they toil. I toil and receive reward, and they toil and do not receive reward. I run, and they run. I run to the life of the world to come, and they run to the pit of destruction." (Talmud, Brachot 28b; vbm-torah.org)

Better to realize while still in this world that one's toil is without purpose, than to only come to that realization when it is too late to change.

More often than not, purpose is usually not contingent simply on the job itself, but also on who it is that you are serving. That is the difference between Torah and hanging around in the street corners. It is the choice between serving G-d and serving oneself.

Even the simplest job, when done with the right intention, can serve the highest of purposes. As Martin Luther King once said, "If a man is called to be a street sweeper, he should sweep streets even as a Michaelangelo painted, or Beethoven composed music or Shakespeare wrote poetry. He should sweep streets so well that all the hosts of heaven and earth will pause to say, 'Here lived a great street sweeper who did his job well." goodreads.com

The above also brings to mind, lehavdil, Rabbi Shlomo Carlebach's "Holy Hunchback," the Holocaust survivor who was a street-sweeper in Tel Aviv, and who lived the lesson he heard from his childhood Rebbe, Reb Klonymos Kalmon of Piasetzna: "Dear, sweet children, the greatest thing in the world... is to do somebody else a favor." (Listen to this very special story here: youtube.com)

The above also brings to mind Rebbe Nachman's story of the "Simpleton and the Sophisticate." While the "wise" man spent his days jumping from profession to profession because nothing was prestigious enough for him, the "simple" one was extremely happy and satisfied with much less:

The Simpleton learned how to make shoes, but because he was simple, it took him a long time before he grasped it. Indeed, he was not completely proficient in his craft, but he married and made a living from his work. … When he finished making a shoe, it would all too often turn out triangular as he was not fully proficient in his craft. But he would take the shoe in his hand and praise it greatly. He would take enormous delight in it, saying: "My wife, how beautiful and wonderful this shoe is. How sweet this shoe is. This shoe is pure honey and sugar!" … He was simply filled with joy and delight at all times. (http://www.azamra.org/Essential/sophist.htm)

At the end of the day, each of us has their "calling" and purpose, their shlichut, their mission as an emissary in this world. May we all merit to realize Who sent us here, discover the work that is right for us, and stick to it long enough to see its fruit, both in this world and the World to Come.

Vaera

Getting to Know G-d

Thus says the Lord: Let not the wise man boast of his wisdom, nor the strong man boast of his strength, nor the rich man boast of his riches. But let him that boasts exult in this, that he understands and knows me, for I am the Lord Who practices kindness, justice and righteousness on the earth; for in these things I delight, says the Lord. (Jeremiah, 9:22-23)

Our entire purpose in this world is to know G-d. That is our main task, the ultimate worth, and that is exactly what Pharaoh was missing. In last week's Torah Portion, when Moshe and Aharon approach Pharaoh as ambassadors of G-d and tell him to let His people go, Pharaoh responds: ""Who is the Lord that I should heed His voice to let Israel out? I do not know the Lord, neither will I let Israel out." (Exodus 5:2)

In this week's portion, Pharaoh and the Egyptians begin to learn the hard way Who is G-d. Each of the plagues shows G-d's dominion over a different aspect of His Creation. The lesson, however, is also for the Jewish People: "And I will take you to Myself as a People, and I will be your G-d. Then you will know that I am G-d, the One who took you out from the subjugation of Egypt." (Exodus 6:7) The Baal Shem Tov explains that the verse hints that the Jews themselves had to re-learn Who G-d

is, and What He is all about. (http://www.chabad.org/kabbalah/article_cdo/aid/379423/jewish/Losing-Awareness-of-G-d.htm)

The struggle to know G-d continues, and our final redemption is the ultimate fulfillment of our quest for His knowledge. About the Messianic times, Maimonides writes:

The sages and the prophets did not crave the era of Moshiach in order to rule over the world... or to eat, drink and rejoice, only so that they be free for Torah and its wisdom and be rid of any oppressor and disrupter... And at that time there will be no hunger or war, no jealousy or rivalry. For the good will be plentiful, and all delicacies available as dust. The entire occupation of the world will be only to know G-d... Israel will be of great wisdom; they will perceive the esoteric truths and comprehend their Creator's wisdom as is the capacity of man. As it is written: "For the earth shall be filed with the knowledge of G-d, as the waters cover the sea..." (Mishneh Torah, Laws of Kings 12:4-5).

May this era come soon, and when it comes, may we have the right priorities in place in order to be able to appreciate it.

Bo

The Importance of Acting as One

This week's Torah portion begins with Hashem telling Moshe, "Come [Boh] to Pharaoh..." Much has been written about how the verse states, "Come" instead of "Go," which implies that by going to Pharaoh, Moshe was actually coming closer to G-d Himself.

Another interesting aspect of the way the sentenced is phrased (which I have not seen discussed elsewhere) is the fact that the phrase is said in the singular. G-d does not tell Aharon to come, yet Aharon does come along with Moshe to face Pharaoh. This, in and of itself, can be explained, as G-d had said that Moshe would be a "master/god" over Pharaoh, while Aharon would serve as Moshe's "prophet," his spokesperson. (Exodus 7:1)

However, there is an additional element that makes the use of the singular verb conjugation somewhat more perplexing: the very sentence that describes Moshe and Aharon coming to speak to Pharaoh is also in the singular!

3. So Moses and Aaron came [sing.] to Pharaoh and said to him, "So said the Lord, the God of the Hebrews, How long will you refuse to humble yourself before Me? Let My people go, and they will worship Me.עַד מָתַי מֵאַנְתָּ לֵעָנֹת מִפָּנָי שַׁלַּח עַמִּי וְיַעַבְדֻנִי. ג. וַיָּבֹא מֹשֶׁה וְאַהֲרֹן אֶל פַּרְעֹה וַיֹּאמְרוּ אֵלָיו כֹּה אָמַר יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵי הָעִבְרִים:

The Hebrew word used is Vayavoh (he came) when it would appear that Vayavohu (they came) would have been the correct word choice. Also, immediately following the very moment that Hashem appointed Aharon as Moshe's prophet, there too, the words used are Vayavoh Moshe v'Aharon (Moshe and Aharaon came [sing.] to Pharaoh). (Exodus 7:10)

Prior to this, during the first time that Moshe and Aharon come before Pharaoh, the word used is in fact "Bahu," they came [plural]. (Exodus 5:1) Not only were they not successful on that occasion, but Pharaoh actually increased the burden of the Jewish people, which led Moshe to even complain to G-d and ask Him why He was doing this to His people.

The singular form had been used also at a previous occasion regarding Moshe and Aharon when they went to speak with the Jewish elders (Vayelech Moshe v'Aharon) (Exodus 4:29). At that time, they were successful in convincing the elders that the time for redemption had in fact come.

Vayavoh Moshe v'Aharon is used another time in the Torah, at the moment of the inauguration of the Tabernacle. (Leviticus 9:23) As Aharon is performing the inauguration sacrifices, Moshe and Aharon come to the Tent of Meeting and bless the people, and the Glory of Hashem appears to the entire people. Immediately after, the sons of Aharon, Nadab and Abihu, enter the Holy of Holies and improperly bring an incense offering. They are thereby both consumed. In direct contrast to Moshe and Aharon, when describing the actions of Nadab and Abihu, the Torah uses only plural verb conjugations.

We see a similar contrast of plural versus singular conjugations when it comes to the encampments of the Jewish people in the desert. The journeys and encampments are described in the plural, except for the encampment by Mount Sinai itself. There, Rashi explains, the Jews were like "one person with one heart." This great harmony among us was actually an essential requirement for acquiring the Torah itself.

The lesson appears to be a simple one. In order to be successful in doing G-d's will, the ultimate unity is extremely important. We have to seek it to such an extent

that we do not even wish to be accounted for as separate entities. Let us learn from Moshe and Aharon and reach out and help one another in brotherly love. Let us also be willing to be helped by others, and let those who know more than us lead us in the right direction. As stated in Pirkei Avot, make for yourself a master and acquire a friend. This way you will be infinitely closer to your true Master and Friend. The more we realize that we are all One, the closest we will be to the One, the Only One.

When I imagine the Jewish people leaving Egypt, I always imagine them holding hands...

It was because of baseless hatred that the Temple was destroyed, and it will be through baseless love that it will be rebuilt. May we soon merit to regain the harmony we achieved at Mount Sinai, and merit to see the Temple rebuilt. May the Alef and Mem of Aharon and Moshe, followed by the Alef and Mem of Esther and Mordechai, finally be followed by the Alef and Mem of Eliyahu and Mashiach, speedily, in our days.

Beshalach

Singing and Dancing

This week's Torah portion relates what is likely the culmination of the (physical) Exodus from Egypt: the splitting of the Sea of Reeds. In this miraculous series of events, not only are the Children of Israel saved and the Egyptians drowned, but also the entire people now fully "believed in G-d and in Moshe His servant." (Exodus 14:31) What follows then, is, if you think about it, is really quite surprising: the entire people break out in song! The song is so prophetic and beautiful that it is recorded in its entirety in the Torah itself. Moshe leads the entire people in song, while Miriam later leads the women in dance and timbrels (musical instruments).

Song and dance becomes the ultimate expression of freedom, but it is not that each person sings and dances randomly. It is all very much coordinated, following the leader (himself a servant), without ego. Singing and dancing is itself a way of serving G-d. This does not mean that there is no individual self-expression. On the contrary, each person finds their full individual expression as a part of this communal song.

It is worth noting that traditional Jewish dances are done in circles. Each person dances to their heart's content, but the focus is not on the individual, but rather on

the whole. (Yes, sometimes individuals enter the middle of the circle, but unless they are the bride and groom, or the bar/bat mitzvah girl or boy, or the parents, a people should check their own motivations to make sure they are dancing in the middle for the right reason, and not as part of an "ego trip").

A similar concept applies to the Passover Seder. Seder means order, and while every household follows the same exact pattern (the "sheet music," so to speak), each household as well as each of its members applies its own take on the "song," the Seder. Freedom without order is chaos. Freedom without self-expression is not freedom.

This lesson is reflected in all of the commandments, and a proper metaphor are the very strings of the Tzit-Tzit, attached to every four-cornered garment. The Tzit-Tzit represent all the other mitzvot: part of the length of the strings are tied in knots, while the rest is let loose (the word Tzit-Tzit adds up to 600, and there are 8 strings and 5 knots, for a total of 613). Without the knots, the strings would either fall off, get all jumbled together, or worse. They would probably end up knotted anyway, just not in the way that the Torah requires. On the other hand, if the strings were completely knotted together, they probably would not even be considered strings at all, just knots.

The opening Mishna in the Tractate of Pesachim (about Passover) begins as follows: "Ohr L'Arbah Asar Bodkim Et HaChametz L'Or HaNer." This is usually translated as, "On the eve (lit. the light) of the fourteenth, we check for any leavened bread, by the light of the candle."

Fourteen stands for redemption, as it has the numerical value of the word Yad, hand, a reference to the Strong Hand of G-d that took us out of Egypt. Leavened bread, Chametz, represents a person's ego. Light is a reference to Torah, and the candle, the mitzvot (the commandments), as in the verse in Proverbs: Ner Mitzvah veTorah Ohr," a mitzvah is a candle and the Torah is light.

Therefore, the Mishna can be understood on a deeper level as follows: When the light of redemption is approaching, we check ourselves for any misplaced ego, through the the light of Torah and the commandment(s). As we prepare ourselves for the final redemption and can already see the "light at the end of the tunnel," we must check ourselves for any egocentric thought, speech or deed we might have overlooked. We check ourselves by analyzing our own devotion to the Torah and to

how we perform its commandments.

This devotion mentioned above does not imply, G-d forbid, abolishing our own individuality. On the contrary, it is through the Torah and its commandments that we find our ultimate self-expression. As we see in the teaching of the Ethics of our Fathers (Pirkei Avot, 6:2), "there is no free individual, except for one who is occupied with the study of Torah. And whoever occupies themselves with the study of Torah is elevated."

When Mashiach comes, it is said that the righteous will be in a circle and that Hashem Himself will be in the middle. They will all be pointing in, and saying, "This is my G-d," very much like the Song of the Sea, when we all said together: "This is My G-d and I will glorify Him." Each one will have a different perspective from which they will be pointing, but they will all be pointing in the same direction.

May it be very soon, and may we all be part of this circle, knowing what to say and what to sing, how to dance and where to point.

Yitro

The Importance and the Danger of Foreign Influences

This week's Torah portion begins by reintroducing the figure of Yitro, Moshe's father-in-law. Yitro gives keen advice to his son-in-law as to how to properly judge the people. He tells him that if he continues the way he's doing things, he will soon burn out. Instead, he should appoint other judges to handle minor cases. Yitro's words are readily accepted, and this entire Torah portion, which includes the Ten Commandments, is named after him. He is said to be the very first convert, having experimented with every type of idol worship before coming to the conclusion that only Hashem is the true G-d.

An interesting question arises: How can it possibly be that Moshe, who spoke directly to G-d on a regular basis, could be open to, never mind accept, advice from someone who, until now, was a complete outsider? Furthermore, previously, Yitro's influence on Moshe's family had been less than ideal. The Midrash teaches that Moshe's own first-born son, Gershon, was brought up by his idolatrous grandfather. Even though Gershon himself did not serve idols, his son, Yehonatan, became a "high priest" for the idol worship known as Pesel Micha, the very first major deviation

from serving G-d after the Jews entered the land of Israel. (See more about this here) Imagine, Moshe's own grandson succumbing to idol worship. If it happened to him it could happen to anyone, G-d forbid.

In general, the question of how much to interact with the outside world is one of the most complex ones for Jews to handle. Just as in the post for last week's portion, the secret lies not in one extreme or the other, but rather in a proper balance. Too much exposure to foreign wisdom and culture is very likely to lead one astray. On the other hand, no exposure to the outside leads to inefficiencies and corruption from within.

The proper balance will be different for different people. Some may belong more in the "borders" of our culture, while others may require more insularity. As a people, the key is to have a leader that is humble and open-minded like Moshe. Someone that will know how to accept and utilize outside knowledge when necessary. Nevertheless, that person must also learn from the lesson of Moshe's own personal life, and value the importance of being free from too much outside intervention, especially regarding our children.

Again, just as in last week's portion, highlighting the importance of rules and order as well as the need for individuality and self-expression, the answers are not black and white. The challenges are ongoing. However, aren't these nuances exactly what make life interesting, colorful and beautiful? To overcome these challenges, there's only one true advice: prayer, and a lot of it. Hashem, out of his infinite mercy will show us the way of the Torah, the way of our ancestors, particularly that of our forefather Jacob: the way of Tiferet (beauty/balance).

Mishpatim

Trust versus Initiative

As I was getting ready to write the blog post for this week's portion, I found another Dvar Torah, which pretty much hit exactly on what I wished to address. This is the third post about the need for beauty and balance (Tiferet) in life. This week, I wished to discuss the importance of trusting in G-d versus being able to fend for ourselves, based on the verse of this week regarding permission to seek a doctor. The following is from Rabbi Chanan Morrisson, based on the writings of Rav Avraham Yitzchak Kook. (http://ravkooktorah.org/MISHPA62.htm)

Mishpatim: Trust in God vs. Self-Reliance

The Talmud (Berachot 10b) tells a puzzling story about the righteous king Hezekiah. It is related that the king secreted away the medical books of his day. Why? King Hezekiah felt that the people relied too heavily on the prescriptions described in those texts, and did not pray to God to heal them.

Surprisingly, the Sages approved of King Hezekiah's action. Such an approach would appear to contradict another Talmudic ruling. The Torah says one who injures his neighbor must "provide for his complete healing" (Ex. 21:19). The Talmud (Baba Kama 85a) deducts from here that the Torah granted doctors permission to heal. Even with natural diseases, we do not say, 'Since God made him ill, it is up to God to heal him,' but do our best to heal him.

Which is the correct attitude? Should we rely on doctors and medical books, or place our trust only in God and prayer?

There is in fact a larger question at stake. When are we expected to do our utmost to remedy the situation ourselves, and when should we rely on God's help?

Two Forms of Bitachon

Rav Kook explained that there are two forms ofbitachon, reliance on God. There is the normative level of trust, that God will assist us in our efforts to help ourselves. And there is the simple trust in God that He will perform a miracle, when appropriate.

Regarding the community as a whole, we find apparent contradictions in the Torah's expectations. Sometimes we are expected to make every possible effort to succeed, as in the battle of HaAi (Joshua 8). On other occasions, human effort was

considered a demonstration of lack of faith, as when God instructed Gideon not to send too many soldiers to fight, “Lest Israel should proudly say 'My own hand saved me'” (Judges 7:2). Why did God limit Gideon’s military efforts, but not Joshua’s in the capture of HaAi?

The answer is that the spiritual level of the people determines what level of bitachon is appropriate. When we are able to recognize God’s hand in the natural course of events, when we are aware that God is the source of our strength and skill — “Remember the Lord your God, for it is He Who gives you strength to succeed” (Deut. 8:18) — then God is more clearly revealed when He supplies our needs within the framework of the natural world. In this situation, we are expected to utilize all of our energy and knowledge and talents, and recognize divine assistance in our efforts. This reflects the spiritual level of the people in the time of Joshua.

On the other hand, there are times when the people are incapable of seeing God’s help in natural events, and they attribute any success solely to their own efforts and skills. They are likely to claim, 'My own hand saved me.' In this case, only miraculous intervention will enable the people to recognize God’s hand — especially when the Jewish nation was young, miracles were needed to bring them to this awareness.

Educating the People

Consider the methods by which parents provide for their children. When a child is young, the parent feeds the child directly. If the child is very small, the parent will even put the food right in his mouth. As the child grows older, he learns to become more independent and take care of his own needs. Parental care at this stage is more indirect, by supplying him with the wherewithal — the knowledge, skills, and training — to provide for himself. The grown child does not wish to be forever dependent on his parent. He wants to succeed by merit of his own talents and efforts, based on the training and tools that his parents provided him.

So too, when the Jewish people was in its infancy, miracles served to instill a fundamental recognition and trust in God. In the time of Gideon, the people’s faith had lapsed, and needed strengthening. Similarly, in the time of King Hezekiah, the king realized that the corrupt reign of Ahaz had caused the people to forget God and His Torah. He calculated that the spiritual gain through prayer outweighed the scientific loss due to hiding the medical texts.

But when faith and trust in God are strong, it is preferable that we utilize our own energies and talents, and recognize God's hand within the natural universe. The enlightened viewpoint calls out, "Lift up your eyes on high and see: Who created these?" (Isaiah 40:26). So it was when Joshua conquered the city of HaAi. After forty years of constant miracles in the desert, the people were already thoroughly imbued with trust in God. It was appropriate that they use their own resources of cunning and courage to ambush the fighters and destroy the city.

What about the future redemption of the Jewish people? It may occur with great miracles, like the redemption from Egypt; or it may begin with natural events, as implied by several statements of the Sages that the redemption will progress gradually. It all depends on the level of our faith in God. It is certainly integral to our national pride that we take an active role in rebuilding the House of Israel.

(Gold from the Land of Israel pp. 136-138. Adapted from Ein Eyah vol. I, p. 57)

Here is a second Dvar Torah from Rav Kook on the subject, discovered years later:

Medical Fees

Amongst the various laws in the parashah of Mishpatim — nearly all of which are of a societal or interpersonal nature — the Torah sets down the laws of compensation for physical damages. When one person injures another, he must compensate the other party with five payments. He must pay for (1) any permanent loss of income due to the injury, (2) embarrassment, (3) pain incurred, (4) loss of income while the victim was recovering, and (5) medical expenses.

This last payment, that he "provide for his complete healing" (Exod. 21:19), i.e., that he cover any medical fees incurred, is of particular interest. The word "to heal" appears 67 times in the Torah, almost always referring to God as the Healer. Only here, as an aside to the topic of damages, does the Torah indicate that we are expected to take active measures to heal ourselves, and not just leave the healing process to nature.

This detail did not escape the keen eyes of the Sages. "From here we see that the Torah gave permission to the doctor to heal" (Berachot 60a).

Yet we need to understand: why should the Torah need to explicitly grant such permission to doctors? If anything, we should expect all medical activity to be highly commended, as doctors ease pain and save lives.

Our Limited Medical Knowledge

The human being is an organic entity. The myriad functions of body and soul are intertwined and interdependent. Which person can claim that he thoroughly understands all of these functions, how they interrelate, and how they interact with the outside world? There is a danger that when we treat a medical problem in one part of the body, we may cause harm to another part. Sometimes the side effects of a particular medical treatment are relatively mild and acceptable. And sometimes the results of treatment may be catastrophic, causing problems far worse than the initial issue.1

One could thus conclude that there may be all sorts of hidden side effects, unknown to the doctor, which are far worse than the ailment we are seeking to cure. Therefore, it would be best to let the body heal on its own, relying on its natural powers of recuperation.

Relying on Available Knowledge

The Torah, however, rejects this view. Such an approach could easily be expanded to include all aspects of life. Any effort on our part to improve our lives, to use science and technology to advance the world, could be rebuffed on the grounds that we lack knowledge of all consequences of the change.

The Sages taught: "The judge can only base his decision on what he is able to see" (Baba Batra 131a). If the judge or doctor or engineer is a competent professional, we rely on his expertise and grasp of all available knowledge to reach the best decision possible. We do not allow concern for unknown factors hinder our efforts to better our lives.

"The progress of human knowledge, and all of the results of human inventions — is all the work of God. These advances make their appearance in the world according to mankind's needs, in their time and generation."

(Sapphire from the Land of Israel. Adapted from Olat Re'iyah vol. I, p. 390)

Illustration image: 'The Doctor' (Luke Fildes, 1891)

1 The tragic example of birth defects as a result of treating morning sickness in pregnancy with thalidomide comes to mind.

ravkooktorah.org

Terumah

"To Give or Not to Give"

This week's Torah portion begins with the description of how donations were supposed to be collected for the Temple. How much was each person supposed to give? As much as their heart would inspire them.

For the past few weeks, we have been discussing Tiferet (Balance/Beauty) in different aspects of life. In no area does this concept appear to be more pervasive than when it comes to giving Tzedakah. On the one hand, there appear to be certain limits regarding how much one should give. 10% is the minimum, but 20% is the maximum. Otherwise, the giver himself might end up being on the receiving end of someone else's Tzedakah. In Pirkei Avot, we are also told about being careful about keeping track of our tithes, apparently not to risk giving too little or too much. Another teaching in Pirkei Avot teaches, "If I am not for myself, who will be for me?" (Im Ein Ani Li, Mi Li?) A person must have boundaries, otherwise they risk being taken advantage by others, completely giving up their own needs and wants.

On the other hand, the same verse in Pirkei Avot continues, "If I am for myself, what am I?" ("Im Ani L'Atzmi, Mah Ani?") Yet another lesson in Pirkei Avot states that the pious are those that believe that, "What is mine is yours, and what is yours is yours." (As opposed to the wicked who state that "what is mine is mine, and what is yours is mine." Even the one who states, "what is mine is mine, and what is yours is yours," is compared to the people of Sodom and Gomorrah.

There are many other sources that seem to encourage giving in an unlimited fashion. It is well known that Tzadikim of previous generations would not go to sleep until they'd given out their every last cent. This was a sign of their trust in G-d. The Alter Rebbe also writes in the Tanya that the limits placed on giving do not apply when someone when it comes to giving Tzedakah in order to remedy past misdeeds. Just like there is no limit on spending money to save a life physically, the same holds true for saving a life spiritually through Tzedakah. There are also additional obligations when the person is physically before you, asking for Tzedakah, right here and now (which unfortunately happens quite often), Jewish law states that one is not allowed to leave the person empty-handed.

Nevertheless, it would seem that to give to a person who is known to be lying, faking poverty, using the money (self-)destructively, this would not even be considered Tzedakah at all. It would be considered enabling bad behavior, much along the lines of the Torah prohibition of placing a "stumbling block before the blind."

Finally, it is a well known principle that Hashem asks in a way of Middah-Keneged-Middah, which means that He acts towards you in the same manner that you act towards others (and yourself). Wouldn't it be better, then, to give without judging, in a way of unlimited Chesed, so that Hashem will do the same for us?

The answer, once again, does not appear to be simple. Furthermore, once again, the answer will indeed be different for different people and will change drastically depending on the circumstances.

Nevertheless, a closer look at the beginning of our Torah portion perhaps hints at the proper approach to answering this question. The name of this Torah portion, Terumah, means "offering" or "donation." It is mentioned twice in the portion's opening verse:

"Speak to the children of Israel, and have them take for Me an offering; from every person whose heart inspires him to generosity, you shall take My offering."

The term Terumah is mentioned in yet a different context altogether later in the Torah. Rashi picks up on this and comments as follows:

you shall take My offering: Our Rabbis said: [The word תְּרוּמָה, mentioned three times, denotes that] three offerings are mentioned here:

a) One is the offering of a beka [half-shekel] per head, from which they made the sockets...

b) Another is the offering of a beka per head for the [community] coffers, from which to purchase the communal sacrifices, and

c) another is the offering for the [construction of the] Mishkan [the Tabernacle], each one's [Israelite's] donation [to their heart's desire]. (Talmud Yerushalmi, Shekalim 1:1; Meg. 29b).

The Rebbe explains these three different kinds of Terumah in terms of the three pillars that sustain the world, Torah (the sockets, that holds everything else together), prayer (communal service), and acts of kindness/mitzvot (performed with

physical materials, such as gold, silver, and copper). The Rebbe explained that the Tabernacle was to be G-d's dwelling place in this world, and that it is the third type of Terumah, acts of kindness/mitzvot that physically achieve this (even though the other two are necessary elements) and that is why it is the third kind that is fully described in this Torah portion. (See a summary of this idea here)

Perhaps, one can also explain these three the kinds of Terumah as three aspects within Tzedakah itself. The Maharal explains that prayer is primarily about how we relate to G-d (as opposed to the cardinal sin of idol worship); Torah represents primarily how we relate to and improve ourselves (as opposed to the cardinal sin of immoral sexual behavior); deeds of kindness are about how we relate to others (as opposed to the cardinal sin of murder).

The first two donations have a set amount per person. When it comes to giving Tzedakah to fulfill our obligation to ourselves, that requires only a set amount. When it comes to giving Tzedakah to fulfill our obligations to G-d, that also requires only a set amount. G-d, after all, wants us to enjoy the wealth He gave us as well. However, when it comes to helping others and fixing the world, which is the most essential aspect of Tzedakah, there is no limit. We give as much as we can, yet without upsetting the two above-mentioned principles: our obligation to ourselves and our obligation to G-d.

Tetzaveh

Glory, Humility, Tiferet

This week we will explore what will likely be the last in a series of posts about Tiferet (Beauty/Balance). This week's Torah portion continues to describe the ornaments of the Tabernacle (Mishkan), as well as the holy garments of Aharon, the High Priest (Kohen Gadol). The opening verse regarding Aharon's clothes is as follows:

2. You shall make holy garments for your brother Aaron, for honor and glory.ב. וְעָשִׂיתָ בִגְדֵי קֹדֶשׁ לְאַהֲרֹן אָחִיךָ לְכָבוֹד וּלְתִפְאָרֶת׃

The word for glory here, Tiferet, is usually translated as beauty, balance. Clothes represent the quintessential aspect of Tiferet. They literally beautify the person, and yet they also do so much more. They affect a person's state of mind, and bring dignity and honor (Kavod), as mentioned above. The Talmud states that Rabbi

Yochanan would refer to his clothes as “those that honor me” (Mechabduti).

Clothes also represent the idea of Tiferet in the sense of balance, moderation. The Talmud (Chullin 84b) states: “A person should always eat and drink less than his means allow, clothe and cover himself according to his means, and honor his wife and children with more than his means allow.”

In the beginning of his magnum opus, the Mishnah Torah, the Rambam (Maimonides) explains that in life, we should always seek moderation, the “golden mean.”Yet, the Rambam mentions two qualities regarding which moderation does not apply: humility and anger. Anger is always bad, and one should have zero of it. Humility is always good, and the more humility the better. Moshe Rabbeinu, who’s birthday and yahrzeit (anniversary of passing) is today, was not praised for his wisdom, might and beauty. Instead, he is described as the “humblest of men.”

The question then arises, if we seek ultimate humility, why is the High Priest honored with such beautiful clothing? Shouldn’t he wear the simplest possible clothing instead? Similarly, why does the Talmud state above that we should dress according to our means. Why don’t we dress below our means, as to encourage greater humility?

Along the same lines, seeking honor is something strongly discouraged by our sages. Pirkei Avot states that honor, along with jealousy and lust, “take a person out of this world.” (4:21) The Talmud (Eruvim 31B) states that “One who runs after honor will have it run away from him; one who runs from honor will have it pursue him.”

Perhaps the answer to our question lies on the verse from this week’s Torah portion that follows the one quoted above:

3. And you shall speak to all the wise hearted, whom I have filled with the spirit of wisdom, and they shall make Aaron’s garments to sanctify him, [so] that he serve Me [as a kohen].אֶל כָּל חַכְמֵי לֵב אֲשֶׁר מִלֵּאתִיו רוּחַ חָכְמָה וְעָשׂוּ אֶת בִּגְדֵי אַהֲרֹן לְקַדְּשׁוֹ לְכַהֲנוֹ לִי. ג. וְאַתָּה תְּדַבֵּר: RASHI - to sanctify him, [so] that he serve Me [as a kohen]: Heb. לְקַדְּשׁוֹ לְכַהֲנוֹ-לִי, to sanctify him, to initiate him into the kehunah through these garments [so] that he would be a kohen to Me. The expression of kehunah means service, serjanterie [or serventrie] in Old French.

The beautiful and honorable clothes are actually what make Aharon into a Kohen! The clothes are what make him Kodesh, which means holy, but also distinguished. The clothes are not for Aharon’s personal glory. They are for G-d’s glory. They uplift

Aharon only to the extent they they bring him closer to his role as a servant of G-d.

The same goes for our own clothes. We must be true to our positions, our roles as servants, but also children of G-d. We are, after all, a reflection of Him, and the whole purpose of the entire world is to bring Him glory, as stated in the very last verse of Pirkei Avot: "Everything that G-d created in His world, He did not create but for His glory. As is stated (Isaiah 43:7): "All that is called by My name and for My glory, I created it, formed it, also I made it." And it says (Exodus 15:1): "G-d shall reign forever and ever."

G-d's glory does not impact His humility. It was the same Rabbi Yochanan, mentioned above, who states:

Wherever you find the greatness of the Holy One, blessed be He, there you find His humility. This is written in the Torah, repeated in the Prophets, and stated a third time in the Writings. It is written in the Torah: "For the L-rd your G-d is G-d of gods and Lord of lords, the great, mighty and awe-inspiring G-d, who shows no favoritism and accepts no bribe." Immediately afterwards it is written, "He upholds the cause of the orphan and widow, and loves the stranger, giving him food and clothing..." (Talmud, Megillah 31a)

Ki Tisa

Leaving Egypt (Ki Tissah): the Right Way and the Wrong Way to Connect to the Tzadik

In this series, we set aside studying about Tiferet for the time being, and now focus on the attribute of Netzach. This week's Torah portion describes a people in crisis. At first glance, the crisis seems to come about because of too close of a connection between the people and their leader, Moshe, to the extent that when Moshe is perceived to be late in descending from the mountain, the people (or at least a portion of the people) become so utterly despaired that they ask Aharon to make a god for them to worship:

1. When the people saw that Moses was late in coming down from the mountain, the people gathered against Aaron, and they said to him: "Come on! Make us gods that will go before us, because this man Moses, who brought us up from the land of Egypt we don't know what has become of him."

In a moment of weakness and vulnerability, on which Rashi says the Satan capitalized by showing the people an image of Moshe actually being dead, the people violate one of the fundamental principles of the Torah, the second of the Ten Commandments, which had just been given to it.

Implied above is an obvious contradiction. If the people were in fact so connected to Moshe, why did they not follow the commandments he transmitted to them? Even further, we see later that when Moshe does come down from the mountain, the same people that so desperately needed him do not come to his aid:

26. So Moses stood in the gate of the camp and said: "Whoever is for the Lord, [let him come] to me!" And all the sons of Levi gathered around him.

We see here that there is a correct way to connect to the leader, Moshe, and an incorrect way. The incorrect way appears to involve a reliance on the physical presence of Moshe. If Moshe is not there physically, then there is tremendous insecurity, and in order to restore a sense of security nothing is sacred or out-of-bounds.

The correct way to connect to Moshe appears to have much less to do with the leader's physical existence, but instead it focuses on what Moshe represents, as Moshe himself states, "Who is for the Lord, [let him come] to me." The focus is on Hashem, and what Moshe teaches us about how to connect to Hashem. The Tribe of Levi maintained that connection, as Rashi comments on the above:

all the sons of Levi: From here [we learn] that the entire tribe was righteous. -[from Yoma 66b]

This difference in how to connect to the Tzadik is at the very essence of the prohibition against idolatry. It is part of human nature to try to grab on to something you can see, that you can touch. However, these things are fleeting, and are a major obstacle in one's relationship with G-d.

The above is reflected in what Lubavitcher Rebbe wrote about the idea of Hiskashrus, the bond between Rebbe and Chassid:

So, too, my late revered father-in-law the Rebbe [Rayatz] explained in a letter that [a chassid] "is able to satisfy his strong desire for a bond [with his Rebbe] only by studying the maamarim [discourses] of Chassidus which the Rebbe delivers or writes; merely beholding his face is not enough." (emphasis added; sichosinenglish.org)

Moshe represents Netzach, victory, but also endurance, eternality. It is not a physical endurance, but a spiritual one. It is in this sense that the Talmud states (Sotah 13b), that Moshe Rabbeinu Lo Met, that he did not die.

The Rebbe continues the abovementioned letter and concludes as follows:

Another letter states explicitly: "You ask, what does your bond with me consist of, since I do not know you by face.... True hiskashrus is attained by the study of the Torah. If you study my maamarim of Chassidus, read the sichos, associate with my friends (the members of the chassidic brotherhood and the temimim) in their studies and in their farbrengens, and fulfill my request concerning the daily recital of Tehillim and the observance of fixed times for Torah study, -- in this lies hiskashrus."

When we will study the Torah teachings and the sichos [of the Rebbe Rayatz], and will walk in this "straight path which he has shown us," then " 'as in water, face [answers to face: so is the heart of man to man'], and 'spirit rouses spirit and brings forth spirit.' For his Ruach [spirit] remains truly in our midst...; that is, even in this world of action -- [of which it is written], 'This day: to do them' -- [the departed tzaddik] is found more [than in his lifetime]." And just as here he stood and dutifully served, there too he stands and dutifully serves.... (Ibid.)

We just came from reading a Torah portion (Tetzaveh) in which Moshe's name is not explicitly mentioned. A few days ago, the 7th of Adar, was Moshe's yahrzeit, the anniversary of his physical passing (as well as his birthday). For Moshe, and for the Moshe found in every generation, the physical passing is itself like a birthday. The leader's spiritual impact on the world is not diminished. It is actually increased.

Vayakhel

Shabat, Leadership and Community

What follows is an abridged version for this week's description of Netzach, Moshe's leadership qualities that unify [the other Sefirot] and leave an enduring impact. This week's Torah portion begins as follows:

1. Moses called the whole community of the children of Israel to assemble, and he said to them: "These are the things that the Lord commanded to make.

Moses called... to assemble: [He assembled them] on the day after Yom Kippur, when he came down from the mountain. This [word] is a [causative] expression [i.e.,

causing someone to do something], because one does not assemble people with [one's] hands [i.e., directly], but they are assembled through one's speech.

Rashi teaches us that a community is brought together through the words of its leader. He does not directly assemble them [with one's hands]. That's impossible. The people have to be assembled by themselves. Moshe's words is what causes them to be assembled.

It is very interesting that this idea of assembly is contrasted with the idea of Shabat. Historically, Shabat is also what has given the Jewish people a sense of community. It also brings Jews closer together physically, since Shabat observant do not have cars and must walk to shul.

This idea of unity and lack of divisiveness is reflected in the continuing verse:

3. You shall not kindle fire in any of your dwelling places on the Sabbath day."

The same is true for a leader. He is supposed to bring the people together in peace. Lehavdil, this is reflected in the words of American president Dwight Eisenhower: "Motivation is the art of getting people to do what you want them to do because they want to do it."

Pekudei

Humbly Focusing on Actions (not their Amazing Results)

This week, we complete the second Book of the Torah, Shemot (Exodus). The very last verse of the Book, contains a part which is particularly reminiscent of the last verse in Deutoronomy, the last verse in the entire Torah. Both verses contain the phrase, "before the eyes of all" of Israel, although the verse in Exodus contains the word Beit, house, before the eyes of all the house of Israel..

The verse in Exodus speaks about the Hashem resting in the newly constructed Tabernacle (the Mishkan). Rashi focuses on how each place of encampment is called a journey.

It is curious that when Rashi interprets the last verse in Deutoronomy, he does not make any reference to the Mishkan or to the cloud of Hashem's presence. Rashi, instead focuses on the giving of the Torah and generally to the "miracles and mighty deeds" in the desert. Specifically, regarding the meaning of "before the eyes of Israel," Rashi focuses on the breaking of the Tablets, and how this was a laudable action by

Moshe, of which Hashem approved.

EXODUS:

38. For the cloud of the Lord was upon the Mishkan by day, and there was fire within it at night, before the eyes of the entire house of Israel in all their journeys.

לח. כִּי עֲנַן יְהוָה עַל הַמִּשְׁכָּן יוֹמָם וְאֵשׁ תִּהְיֶה לַיְלָה בּוֹ לְעֵינֵי כָל בֵּית יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּכָל מַסְעֵיהֶם׃

before the eyes of the entire house of Israel in all their journeys: On every journey (מַסָּע) that they were traveling, the cloud would rest in that place where they encamped. The place of their encampment is also called a journey (מַסָּע). Likewise, "And he went to his stations (לְמַסָּעָיו) " (Gen. 13:3) [i.e., to the stops along his journey], and likewise, "These are the journeys (מַסְעֵי) " (Num. 33:1). Since from the place of their encampment they resumed their journeys, they are all called "journeys" (מַסָּעוֹת).

וכן (במדבר לג א) אלה מסעי לפי שממקום החנייה חזרו ונסעו, לכך נקראו כולן מסעות׃ שוכן במקום אשר יחנו שם. מקום חנייתן אף הוא קרוי מסע, וכן (בראשית יג ג) וילך למסעיו, לעיני כל בית ישראל בכל מסעיהם׃ בכל מסע שהיו נוסעים היה הענן

DEUTORONOMY:

12. and all the strong hand, and all the great awe, which Moses performed before the eyes of all Israel.

יב. וּלְכֹל הַיָּד הַחֲזָקָה וּלְכֹל הַמּוֹרָא הַגָּדוֹל אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה מֹשֶׁה לְעֵינֵי כָּל יִשְׂרָאֵל׃

and all the strong hand: [This refers to] his receiving the Torah on the Tablets with his hands.

ולכל היד החזקה׃ שקבל את התורה בלוחות בידיו׃

And all the great awe: [This refers to the] miracles and mighty deeds [that were performed for Israel] in the great and awesome wilderness. — [Sifrei 33:41]

ולכל המורא הגדול׃ נסים וגבורות שבמדבר הגדול והנורא׃

before the eyes of all Israel: [This expression alludes to the incident where] his heart stirred him up to smash the tablets before their eyes, as it is said, "and I shattered them before your eyes" (Deut. 9:17). - [Sifrei 33:41] And [regarding Moses shattering the Tablets,] the Holy One Blessed is He gave His approval, as Scripture states, "[the first Tablets] which you shattered" (Exod. 34:1); [God said to Moses:] "Well done for shattering them!" - [Shab. 87a]

והסכימה דעת הקב"ה לדעתו, שנאמר (שמות לד, א) אשר שברת, יישר כחך ששברת׃ לעיני כל ישראל׃ שנשאו לבו לשבור הלוחות לעיניהם, שנאמר (לעיל ט, יז) ואשברם לעיניכם,

Perhaps Rashi chooses not to mention the Mishkan and Hashem's Presence specifically, because the breaking of the Tablets (and Moshe's extensive prayers of repentance that followed), is in fact what ultimately permitted Hashem's presence to return to Israel's camp, "before the eyes of all of Israel." Rashi focuses on Moshe's actions, not on their consequences. This reminiscent of Moshe's own humility, related to the Sefirah of Netzach, who always focused on the job that needed to be done, and not on his own importance or the great results that followed from his actions. All greatness, and the credit for all the positive consequences of our choices ultimately belong to G-d Alone.

BOOK THREE

Vayikra

And He Called

Vayikra

Vayikra and the Fine (Humble) Line between the Holy and the Unholy

This week we begin a new Book of the Five Books of Moses, Vayikrah, Leviticus. The very first word, Vayikrah, (and [God] called [Moshe]) is written with a small Alef.

Chapter 1

1. And He called to Moses, and the Lord spoke to him from the Tent of Meeting, saying, א. וַיִּקְרָא אֶל מֹשֶׁה וַיְדַבֵּר יְהוָה אֵלָיו מֵאֹהֶל מוֹעֵד לֵאמֹר: And He called to Moses: ... [קְרִיאָה] is an expression of affection, the [same] expression employed by the ministering angels [when addressing each other], as it says, "And one called (וְקָרָא) to the other..." (Isa. 6:3). To the prophets of the nations of the world, however, He revealed Himself through expressions denoting coincidence and impurity, as the verse says, "and God happened to [meet] (וַיִּקָּר) Balaam" (Num. 23:4). - [Bemidbar Rabbah 52:5] [The expression וַיִּקָּר has the meaning of a coincidental happening, and also alludes to impurity. [See Deut. 23:11, regarding the expression מִקְרֵה לַיְלָה.]

Rashi does not explicitly mention the small Alef, but rather simply focuses on the difference between Vayikra and Vayikar, which is how the word would read without the Alef altogether. Much has been said about the fact that the small Alef would represent Moshe's humility, and that by making the Alef small, Moshe would be therefore giving less emphasis to the fact that G-d called out to him.

The fact that Alef is singled out and made smaller, however, suggests that Moshe is not at all trying to make himself appear more like Bilaam. On the contrary, he is emphasizing the difference between himself and Bilaam, which is exactly what Rashi picks up on. What is that difference? Humility.

19. Whoever possesses the following three traits is of the disciples of our father Abraham; and whoever possesses the opposite three traits is of the disciples of the wicked Balaam. The disciples of our father Abraham have a good eye (Ayin), a meek spirit (Ruach) and a humble soul (Nefesh). The disciples of the wicked Balaam have an evil eye, a haughty spirit and a gross soul. (Pirkei Avot, Chapter 5)

In Ecclesiastes (Kohelet), King Solomon states that the difference between a man and an animal is Ayin (nothing). It's not that there is no difference, but that the difference is the ability to be "nothing," a humble vessel.

19. For there is a happening for the children of men, and there is a happening for the beasts-and they have one happening-like the death of this one is the death of that one, and all have one spirit, and the superiority of man over beast is nought [Ayin, with an Alef], for all is vanity. זֶה וְרוּחַ אֶחָד לַכֹּל וּמוֹתַר הָאָדָם מִן הַבְּהֵמָה אָיִן כִּי הַכֹּל הָבֶל
יט. כִּי מִקְרֶה בְנֵי הָאָדָם וּמִקְרֶה הַבְּהֵמָה וּמִקְרֶה אֶחָד לָהֶם כְּמוֹת זֶה כֵּן מוֹת:

Our sages mention that in the most important prayer in Judaism, the Shemah, the difference between the words Echad (one) and Acher (other), is very slight:

Rav Zeira said: "Even parts of the Torah that seem like little slivers ("Kotzin") are actually tremendous mountains ("Tilei Tilim"). They can destroy the entire world if they are not preserved.... [For instance,] in the verse (Devarim 12:4), 'Hear O Israel, Hashem is our G-d, Hashem is *One* (Alef Chet Dalet),' if the Dalet of Echad is changed into a Reish by erasing the little sliver that distinguishes between the written form of the two letters, it can cause the destruction of the entire world (because the verse would read, "Hashem is *another*). In the verse (Shemot 34:14): "Do not bow down to a *another* (Alef Chet Reish) G-d ," if the Reish of Acher is changed into a Dalet by adding a little sliver, it can cause the destruction of the entire world (because the verse would then read, "Do not serve the *one* G-d"). (Vayikra Rabba, 19:2; "Parsha Page," Rav Kornfeld)

The difference between the Dalet and the Resh is simply a sliver, like the Hebrew letter Yud. The Yud represents spirituality. There is a very fine line between what is holy and unholy. Between truth and falsehood. This is related to the month of Adar:

Rabbi [Sholom] Gold pointed out that we celebrate Haman's downfall during the month of Adar (Alef, Dalet, Reish). At this time, we work on strengthening our perception of Hashem Echad and not bowing down to an El Acher. The mission of Adar is to learn to differentiate between the Dalet and the Reish, and through this,

to reveal the "Alef," (which, having a numerical value of one, represents the Creator) whose Oneness will finally be revealed to all when Amalek is completely destroyed. ("Parsha Page," Rav Kornfeld)

The letter Alef itself also has a very special humble/spiritual quality, shared in part by the Yud and the Ayin. This humility is also an essential aspect of the Sefirot of Netzach and Hod. The Alef is the first letter of the first word of the first of the Ten Commandments, Anochi Hashem Elokecha, "I am the Lord your G-d." This Alef is said to contain the entire Torah. Yet what is the sound of this letter? It is silent, humble. It serves simply as a vessel for the vowel. That is the true goal of spiritual service: to be a vessel. That is also the goal of the entire book of Vayikra.

Tzav

Elements of a Spiritual Work Out

The Torah portion of this week continue to speak about the different kinds of sacrifices to be brought in the Tabernacle (Mishkan), as well as the induction of Aharon and his children into the priestly service. Here too, we find a combination of the Sefirot of Netzach and Hod, represented by Moshe and Aharon.

1. And the Lord spoke to Moses, saying, 2. Take Aaron and his sons with him, and the garments, and the anointing oil, and the sin offering bull, and the two rams, and the basket of unleavened bread,

בָּנָיו אִתּוֹ וְאֵת הַבְּגָדִים וְאֵת שֶׁמֶן הַמִּשְׁחָה וְאֵת | פַּר הַחַטָּאת וְאֵת שְׁנֵי הָאֵילִים וְאֵת סַל הַמַּצּוֹת׃
ב. קַח אֶת אַהֲרֹן וְאֶת

Rashi - Take Aaron: Take him over with [persuasive] words and attract him. — [Torath Kohanim 8:165]

Again, we see how Moshe's use of words, his ability to inspire, was a key aspect of his leadership.

We also see from the above verse that one of the main aspects of the induction/inauguration is the anointing oil. This oil had several special ingredients (as described in Parashah Ki Tissah), and to understand the role of each ingredient would be a key lesson in and of itself. The way in which Moshe poured the oil on Aharon is also quite fascinating:

12. And he poured some of the anointing oil upon Aaron's head, and he anointed him to sanctify him.

יב. וַיִּצֹק מִשֶּׁמֶן הַמִּשְׁחָה עַל רֹאשׁ אַהֲרֹן וַיִּמְשַׁח אֹתוֹ לְקַדְּשׁוֹ׃

Rashi - And he poured...and anointed [him]: At first, he [Moses] poured [the oil] on his [Aaron's] head, and afterwards, he placed it between his eyelids, and drew it with his finger, from one [eyelid] to the other. — [Ker. 5b]

ויצק, וימשח: בתחלה יוצק על ראשו, ואחר כך נותן בין ריסי עיניו ומושך באצבעו מזה לזה׃

Why is the focus on Aharon's head and his eyelids?

Oil is very much connected to the Kohanim, as we see from the story of Chanukah. It well known that oil represents both wisdom as well as purity. Wisdom is symbolized by Aharon's head, while the eyelids represent purity. This is not very much emphasized in today's society, but one of the main ways (if not the main way) to attain to purity is to guard one's eyes.

Psalm 133 also describes the anointing of Aharon. There also it speaks of the oil being poured on Aharon's head, but then the focus changes from eyelids to Aharon's beard and the "mouth of his clothing" (lit. Middot).

1. A song of ascents of David. Behold how good and how pleasant it is for brothers also to dwell together! 2. As the good oil on the head runs down upon the beard, the beard of Aaron, which runs down on the mouth of his garments.

ב. כַּשֶּׁמֶן הַטּוֹב | עַל הָרֹאשׁ יֹרֵד עַל הַזָּקָן זְקַן אַהֲרֹן שֶׁיֹּרֵד עַל פִּי מִדּוֹתָיו׃

Rashi - As the good oil: with which Aaron the priest was anointed.

Zakan, beard, is spelled the same as Zaken (elder), which stands for Zeh She Kanah Chochmah, "one who has acquired wisdom." The beard also represents the Thirteen Attributes (Middot) of Mercy. Perhaps one can say that these attributes are expressed primarily through the mouth, both in our prayers to G-d as well as in how we address others - our use of words, as mentioned above regarding Moshe.

There also appears to be another aspect of oil, besides from wisdom, purity, and mercy, which is related to how oil is described in the Torah portion of Tetzaveh. Tetzaveh, which shares the same root as Tzav, is usually read exactly at this time of the year (when it is not a leap year), immediately before Purim. Additionally, in Rashi's commentary on Tzav, he makes various references back to his comments regarding Tetzaveh.

Tetzaveh's opening verse relates to the olive oil to be used for the Menorah:

20. And you shall command the children of Israel, and they shall take to you pure olive oil, crushed for lighting, to kindle the lamps continually.

כ. וְאַתָּה תְּצַוֶּה | אֶת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל וְיִקְחוּ אֵלֶיךָ שֶׁמֶן זַיִת זָךְ כָּתִית לַמָּאוֹר לְהַעֲלֹת נֵר תָּמִיד׃

The oil is a product of the olives' being "crushed for lighting." This is related to the idea of working hard with great self-sacrifice (Mesirat Nefesh), as explained by the Rebbe in the very last discourse he distributed.

Perhaps the idea of pouring oil on one's head is referring to what happens when we work so hard that we are physically (and mentally) crushed, exhausted: we sweat.

19. With the sweat of your face you shall eat bread...

יט. בְּזֵעַת אַפֶּיךָ תֹּאכַל לֶחֶם׃

Rashi - With the sweat of your face: After you toil with it very much. — [Mid. Tadshei, Otzar Midrashim]

This is a reference not just to material bread, but to spiritual bread as well.

I was once told the following guiding principle in life: "The Baal Shem Tov tells us what we need to know. The Letter of the Law tells us what we need to do. [All that is left is to] get wet in the head."

The Rebbe explains that there is a higher level of working hard and "feeling crushed," which is not as a result of an oppressor's decree, but rather when we have abundance, both physical and spiritual. We feel crushed simply because of the fact that we our still in exile; because of our thirst for G-dly revelation, which will come into fruition only with the coming of Mashiach and the rebuilding of the Temple. May it be soon, and may each of us do our part, in the same way as Moshe and Aharon, with much wisdom and purity, mercy and self-sacrifice.

Shemini

Knowing When to Be Quiet

This week's Torah portion, Shmini, describes the inauguration of the Temple on Rosh Chodesh Nissan, which is around the corner. The inauguration is marked by a major event: the death of two of the sons of Aharon, Nadav and Avihu. Aharon reacts to this occurrence with silence.

3. Then Moses said to Aaron, "This is what the Lord spoke, [when He said], 'I will be sanctified through those near to Me, and before all the people I will be glorified.' "

And Aaron was silent.

Rashi - And Aaron was silent: [and did not complain. Consequently,] he was rewarded for his silence. And what reward did he receive? That God addressed him exclusively in the [ensuing] passage regarding those who drink wine [as verse 8 says, "And the Lord spoke to Aaron, saying..."]. — [Vayikra Rabbah 12:2]

Wine represents the opposite of silence. The Talmud states that "when wine enters, secret emerges." It is well known that drunk people often speak more than they are supposed to. They lose their inhibitions and a secret side of them comes out. Sometimes this side can be quite ugly. People's feelings get hurt, others get slandered (Lashon Harah), etc. The worse part of it all is that what is said cannot be retracted. The words leave an indelible mark for all times. It is interesting that this year we read about this account almost immediately after Purim, when perhaps many of us would have been better off keeping a few of our drunken words to ourselves. Also, in the face of so many controversial issues facing our society, particularly in Israel today, we must be very careful with our words and avoid conflict as much as possible.

Aharon's silence represents his quintessential quality of "loving peace and pursuing peace," as mentioned in Pirkei Avot. It also represents the quintessential aspect of the Sefirah of Hod, associated with Aharon. Hod (glory, acknowledgement), shares the same root as the word Hoda'ah, thankfulness, as well as acquiescence. Reflecting on the words (above) told to him by Moshe, Aharon understood that ultimately Hashem had a plan, even if Aharon himself could not fully grasp it.

While Rashi's comment in and of itself is enough to show just the greatness of Aharon's silence, it is worth taking a closer look at the words of the ensuing passage directed solely to Aharon. It includes more than just an admonition against drinking wine in the Temple:

8. And the Lord spoke to Aaron, saying, 9. Do not drink wine that will lead to intoxication, neither you nor your sons with you, when you go into the Tent of Meeting, so that you shall not die. [This is] an eternal statute for your generations, 10. to distinguish between holy and profane and between unclean and clean, 11. and to instruct the children of Israel regarding all the statutes which the Lord has spoken to them through Moses.

The passage emphasizes the very special role of the Kohanim: to distinguish the holy from the profane, the pure from the impure, and to instruct the Jewish people for generations to come. In order to be successful in all of the above, there must be silence in the face of apparent tragedy. In order for there to be Hod, there must be Hoda'ah.

May we all internalize this quality of Aharon, so that we may be more at peace with one another, and make life a little easier for Mashiach when he comes.

Tazria

Life and Death

In honor of Anat bat Miriam on the birth of her baby boy. In memory of Miriam bat Messod, Sarah Channah Bat Mordechai, and Chanah Leah M., who passed away this week.

This week's Torah portion begins with a discussion of the ritual impurity a mother incurs when giving birth, and then turns to the spiritual impurity known as tzara'at. This impurity could affect a person's house, one's clothes, and even one's body. When the body was affected, it required a period of personal exile, until the person was deemed pure by the Kohen. The Kohen was also the one to determine whether the person was impure to begin with.

An obvious question arises as to the connection between the two topics mentioned: the birth of a baby and Tzara'at. While both topics relate to impurity, there appears to be a much deeper connection as well.

The Torah portion begins as follows:

1. And the Lord spoke to Moses, saying: 2. Speak to the children of Israel, saying: If a woman conceives and gives birth to a male, she shall be unclean for seven days; as [in] the days of her menstrual flow, she shall be unclean.

אֶל בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל לֵאמֹר אִשָּׁה כִּי תַזְרִיעַ וְיָלְדָה זָכָר וְטָמְאָה שִׁבְעַת יָמִים כִּימֵי נִדַּת דְּוֹתָהּ תִּטְמָא׃
א. וַיְדַבֵּר יְהוָה אֶל מֹשֶׁה לֵּאמֹר׃ ב. דַּבֵּר

Rashi: If a woman conceives: Rabbi Simlai said: "Just as in the Creation, man was created after all domestic animals, wild beasts, and birds, so too, the law [concerning the cleanness] of man is stated after the law [concerning the cleanness] of domestic animals, wild beasts, and birds."- [Vayikra Rabbah 14:1]

Rashi states that in Creation there were different levels of created beings, rising from level to level and culminating with the creation of man (woman, actually, since Eve was created even after Adam). The same applies to the laws of impurity: the different levels of creation are discussed separately in the Torah.

The whole idea of the Metzorah (someone who contracted Tzara'at) is about rising from level to level. As we will see in next week's portion, the ritual regarding the purification of the Metzorah is remarkably similar to that of the induction/inauguration of the Kohanim. Just like the priests were "upgraded" spiritually, so too, the Metzorah.

Perhaps that is one of the reasons why Mashiach is called a Metzorah. (Talmud, Sanhedrin 98B) He is constantly climbing from level to level. The Talmud states that one can idenfy him among the other Metzorayim because he wraps one wound at a time, healing himself, improving his predicament one step at a time...

The mother who just gave birth is impure for similar reasons. She is now going through a major transition. In the case of a first child, she goes from being responsible for herself only, to now being primarily responsible for a whole other life, another soul. With every new child, come new responsibilities, a new level of Divine service. This is true even before giving birth, but now it is only at birth this is internalized by the mother on a more conscious level; it is also when the Neshamah, the soul of the baby descends into the body.

Redemption itself and the coming of Mashiach is compared to the process of giving birth. The difficulties we now face are called the "birth-pangs" of Mashiach. The whole world is going through a transition, bringing upon us a temporary state of impurity.

Chassidic thought is famous for the idea of ascent in order to achieve a greater ascent (Yeridah LeTzorech Aliyah). One of the Chassidic masters that most emphasized this idea was Rebbe Nachman of Breslev. Not coincidentally, Rebbe Nachman was born on the week of the Torah portion of Tazria and his Brit-Milah was on the following Torah portion, Metzorah. Rebbe Nachman would say:

When the time comes for a person to rise from one level to the next, he must first experience a fall. The whole purpose of the fall is to prepare for the ascent. Try to understand this and you will realize how determined you must be in order to serve God. No matter how far you fall, never allow yourself to be discouraged. Remain

firm and resolute and pay no attention to the fall at all, because in the end it will be transformed into a great ascent. This is its whole purpose.

This applies to all the different ways one can fall. Each person always thinks that his own situation is so bad that this does not apply to him. People imagine it applies only to those on very exalted levels who are continually advancing from level to level. But you should realize that it holds true even for those on the lowest of levels, because God is good to all.

Likutey Moharan I, 22 ("Daily Dose of Rebbe Nachman")

When you're in the middle of the roller-coaster ride of life, it's tough. But when you look back, and see how far you've come, it will be all worth it.

Interestingly, the Talmud also notes that the Metzorah is one of the four kinds of people that are considered "dead." Death itself is a transition. It is the ultimate ascent from level to level, which continues for the soul after life as well.

Even for the body, its descent is only for the purpose of a greater ascent: the resurrection of the dead. Perhaps that is the deeper meaning behind the verse we touched upon at the end of last week:

19. With the sweat of your face you shall eat bread, until you return to the ground, for you were taken therefrom, for dust you are, and to dust you will return."עָפָר תָּשׁוּב
יט. בְּזֵעַת אַפֶּיךָ תֹּאכַל לֶחֶם עַד שׁוּבְךָ אֶל הָאֲדָמָה כִּי מִמֶּנָּה לֻקָּחְתָּ כִּי עָפָר אַתָּה וְאֶל:

El, used in the above verse as a preposition, is also one of G-d's names. The last part of the verse could possibly be read as follows: "until you return to El (G-d) of the earth, for you were taken from Her, for you are dust (body) and El (soul); you, the dust (body), will return."

May we all continue to rise, in the ongoing spiral that is life, history, and the Jewish calendar. May we all rise again, in the end of days, and finally be able to reconnect with all those that have already ascended to the higher realms, and who are so sorely missed.

Metzora

Life's Challenges

B"H

This week's Torah portion continues to focus on the ritual impurity known as Tzara'at, and how someone who becomes purified from it is brought back into the community. It also discusses other impurities, as well as how not only a person, but also one's clothes and one's house can become contaminated.

A question arises as to whether the impurity of Tzara'at is a curse or a blessing. Our sages teach us that only someone that is at an elevated spiritual level is even worthy of contracting this condition. This is the reason why today Tzara'at is not found. (As a side note, I think it is worth mentioning the Rebbe's question on this ponit. How could it be that Tzara'at only impacts people that are extremely elevated, if it is well known that the primary cause of Tzara'at is Lashon Harah, usually translated as slander? The answer is that the Lashon Harah mentioned here is not abusive speech such as slander, but rather an abuse of the faculty of speech, meaningless talk (See Rambam as to the two kinds of Lashon Harah)).

Back to the above question, is Tzara'at a curse or a blessing? In the middle of the Torah portion, there is a verse with a comment from Rashi that is particularly revealing, and which perhaps contains our answer:

34. When you come to the land of Canaan, which I am giving you as a possession, and I place a lesion of tzara'ath upon a house in the land of your possession,אֲחֻזַּתְכֶם
לד. כִּי תָבֹאוּ אֶל אֶרֶץ כְּנַעַן אֲשֶׁר אֲנִי נֹתֵן לָכֶם לַאֲחֻזָּה וְנָתַתִּי נֶגַע צָרַעַת בְּבֵית אֶרֶץ: and I place a lesion of tzara'ath: Heb. וְנָתַתִּי, lit. and I will give. This is [good] news for them that lesions of tzara'ath will come upon them, (Torath Kohanim 14:75), because the Amorites had hidden away treasures of gold inside the walls of their houses during the entire forty years that the Israelites were in the desert, and through the lesion, he will demolish the house (see verses 43-45) and find them. — [Vayikra Rabbah 17:6]

How can placing Tzara'at on a house be called "giving?" In fact, this begs a much bigger question. If we know that G-d runs the world, and that everything he does is the ultimate good, why is there pain and suffering? The answer is G-d wants us to grow. When challenges come our way, G-d wants us to dig deep within us, demolish our walls and self-imposed restrictions, and find the treasures that are inside.

Again, this is one of the fundamental teachings of Rebbe Nachman of Breslov, expressed so beautifully in the book, Garden of Emuna, by Rabbi Shalom Arush. We have so many deep hidden treasures within us, and there are always so many more ways to grow and become better people. Sometimes we just need a little pushing. We

can fill ourselves with more and more meaning, until we get to the point where there is no place for meaningless speech in our vocabulary - where every second counts - because it does. There are even levels above that, where words that may be considered meaningful today, could even be deemed "meaningless." Every day we learn more about G-d and can serve Him on a higher level. In fact, we need to do Teshuvah for not serving Him on such a level in the first place.

The above is also captured in the story called "The King's Son Made of Precious Stones," also from Rebbe Nachman, who as mentioned last week, was born on the Torah portion of Tazria and had his Brit-Milah on the Metzorah. (The story can be found here, pp. 83-88). Here are a few quotes from it, which serve as a kind of summary:

"[The Tzaddik] told [the King and the Queen] they would have a son who would be made completely of precious stones, and he would possess all of the qualities of all of the precious stones."

"The tzaddik then went home. The queen gave birth to a son, and the king rejoiced very greatly. The son that was born was not made of precious stones..."

"The prince became very leprous [Metzorah] He had leprosy [Tzara'at] on his nose, on his face and all over his body. The king engaged in doctors and sorcerers, but to no avail."

"The tzadik then came and said that the prince would be healed. And he was healed, and the leprosy dried up, and all of his skin pealed off, and he was made completely of precious stones and possessed all the qualities of all the precious stones (as the tzaddik had said)."

It is said that in this story Rebbe Nachman is making a reference to himself. It also appears to be a reference to Mashiach himself, who, as also mentioned last week, is called a Metzorah. May the Tzara'at of all of this world be peeled off, so that the true treasures within each one of us can finally be revealed. May it be soon, may it be now.

Acharei Mot

After Mourning

B"H

In this week's Torah portion, we switch from speaking about Tzara'at and return briefly to the subject of the death of Aharon's two eldest sons. The Torah portion then describes the service of Aharon, the High Priest, on Yom Kippur, and later discusses other laws purity.

As mentioned previously, Tzara'at and death have a lot in common. Both represent transitions, and the Metzorah himself is considered like someone who is "dead." We also spoke about how a mother who has just given birth is also in the midst of a great transition, and perhaps that is why her condition is discussed along with Tzara'at and she becomes impure for an extended amount of time. Another person in the midst of a transition is a mourner.

1. And the Lord spoke to Moses after the death of Aaron's two sons, when they drew near before the Lord, and they died.מוֹת שְׁנֵי בְּנֵי אַהֲרֹן בְּקָרְבָתָם לִפְנֵי יְהוָה וַיָּמֻתוּ. א. וַיְדַבֵּר יְהוָה אֶל משֶׁה אַחֲרֵי: And the Lord spoke to Moses after the death of Aaron's two sons:What does this teach us [when it specifies "after the death of Aaron's two sons"]? Rabbi Eleazar ben Azariah illustrated [the answer] with a parable of a patient, whom a physician came to visit. [The physician] said to him, "Do not eat cold foods, and do not lie down in a cold, damp place." Then, another [physician] visited him, and advised him, "Do not eat cold foods or lie down in a cold, damp place, so that you will not die the way so-and-so died." This one warned that patient more effectively than the former. Therefore, Scripture says, "after the death of Aaron's two sons" [i.e., God effectively said to Aaron, "Do not enter the Holy in a prohibited manner, so that you will not die as your sons died"]- [Torath Kohanim 16:3]בני אהרן תשכב בטחב שלא תמות כדרך שמת פלוני. זה זרזו יותר מן הראשון, לכך נאמר אחרי מות שני אצלו רופא. אמר לו אל תאכל צונן ואל תשכב בטחב. בא אחר ואמר לו אל תאכל צונן ואל מות שני בני אהרן וגו': מה תלמוד לומר, היה רבי אלעזר בן עזריה מושלו משל לחולה שנכנס וידבר ה' אל משה אחרי:

At first glance, Rashi's comment seems primarily about the effective of Hashem's choice of words. However, comparing Aharon to a patient perhaps also has a much deeper meaning. Aharon was like a patient, someone still carrying fresh wounds of the trauma of losing his two sons. He could not even grieve properly because he was serving in the Temple and could not display acts of mourning. He was a recovering patient, and did not need a reminder of his sons' passing in order to follow G-d's commandments. What Aharon needed, first and foremost, was encouragement,

moral support to fight depression and death. He needed meaning and purpose, and was therefore further told of his obligations as high priest.

Mourners are always at a risk of clinging too much to the dead and forgetting to keep living. After the set time for mourning, they must get up and get back to work. They must be told "not to eat cold foods" (continue to have thoughts of death and mourning) or "lie down in a cold damp place" (a cemetery). They must stand now, and need warmth and light. Once they are out of the transition period of mourning, they must consider themselves "purified," and realize that their Divine service, in the face of tragedy, is important and holy like that of the high priest himself.

Note: The statement quoted by Rashi is by Rabbi Eliezer Ben Azariah, one of the protagonists of the Passover Haggadah. He is the foremost example of how being assigned an important task can propel a person to new heights, to the point that they are physically transformed. In the Haggadah, Rabbi Eliezer states, "I am like someone aged 70." Even though he was in fact a teenager at the time, when he was appointed as Nassi he grew white hair and a white beard!

Kedoshim

Holiness, Sexuality

This week's Torah portion, as its name indicates, is about holiness. It is full of mitzvot that are essential for a person to be an upstanding ethical citizen, such as keeping the Sabbath, respecting one's parents, leaving part of one's harvest for the poor, not placing a stumbling block in front of the blind, and many others. All of these mitzvot, listed in rapid succession, present us with a general picture of what is expected of us, not only in terms of following the specific commandments, but also going beyond the letter of the law, and fulfilling, as we say in America, the "spirit of the law" as well.

Yet, despite the varied themes and wide range of mitzvot included in this Torah portion, Rashi's comment on its opening lines suggest a much narrower scope regarding what holiness is all about:

1. And the Lord spoke to Moses, saying,2 א. וַיְדַבֵּר יְהוָה אֶל משֶׁה לֵּאמֹר: Speak to the entire congregation of the children of Israel, and say to them, You shall be holy, for I, the Lord, your God, am holy.יִשְׂרָאֵל וְאָמַרְתָּ אֲלֵהֶם קְדשִׁים תִּהְיוּ כִּי קָדוֹשׁ אֲנִי יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵיכֶם

ב. דַּבֵּר אֶל כָּל עֲדַת בְּנֵי:

RASHI: You shall be holy: Separate yourselves from sexual immorality and from sin, for wherever one finds a barrier against sexual immorality, one finds holiness, [for example:], "[They (the kohanim) shall not take in marriage] a woman who is a prostitute or one who was profaned…I, the Lord, Who sanctifies you [am holy]" (Lev. 21:7-8); and, "he shall not profane his offspring…I am the Lord, Who sanctifies him" (Lev. 21:15); and, "They shall be holy…[They shall not take in marriage] a woman who is a prostitute or one who was profaned" (Lev. 21:6-7). - [Vayikra Rabbah 24:4-6; and see also Sefer Hazikkaron]

The end of last week's portion, Acharei, dealt almost exclusively with sexual sins. However, Kedoshim only discusses sexual sins until much much later, almost as a side note. We see that Rashi himself makes no reference to the previous portion, perhaps due to the very fact that the Torah does not to include these few verses as part of Acharei, but rather as the beginning of an entirely new parashah. (Incidentally, on non-leap years, the two portions are usually read together)

What is Rashi's reason for focusing in on the role of holiness vis-a-vis sexual sins? He is certainly not denying that all the other mitzvot mentioned lead a person to holiness. Rashi seems to be stating the following: "While it is true that all the other deeds depicted below lead to holiness, do not think that you can truly achieve it without separating yourself from sexual immorality and from sin."

Unfortunately, society today has completely distorted the role of sexuality. It is true that the Torah certainly does not see sexual relations as a sin, much less as the "original sin." Sex, within the proper parameters of a marriage, is a mitzvah, the very first mitzvah mentioned in the Torah ("be fruitful and multiply"). Yet, outside the context of marriage, sex is clearly prohibited, mainly because it lacks holiness. Because of various factors, ranging from Freud to marketing, society has greatly cheapened the concept of sexual relations in general, and the female body in particular, greatly cheapening ourselves in the process.

Again, the Torah does not advocate Victorian puritanism, burkas, or anything of the sort, yet we must understand that if we desire to have true holiness in our lives, we have to be in control of our sexual urges, and not the other way around, having them dictate our actions. This certainly applies to married couples, too, and applies not just to sex itself, but to everything we see, touch, hear, and (consciously) think

about. (Perhaps that is why Rashi mentions "sexual immorality" and "sin" as two separate concepts. The Ramban explains that one can be a Naval b'Reshut haTorah - a disgusting person, acting in ways that are technically permitted by the Torah).

It might sound a little radical, but as soon as we are in control of our animal side, our soul is free to soar. It is incredibly liberating, and allows for a much stronger and heartfelt connection to G-d. The beauty of Judaism is that it advocates that once our spiritual side is in control and the Torah's precepts are followed, then pleasure is not a sin at all - it is holy, and is itself a praise of the Almighty. Rabbi Chanan Morrison writes the following in the name of Rav Kook:

What is a brachah? When we recite a blessing, we are expressing our awareness of God as the ultimate source for this pleasure. But there is an enjoyment greater than the sensory pleasure that comes from eating food. Eating entitles us to recite a blessing and thus connect with our Creator. We experience an inner joy when we realize that every form of physical pleasure was created with the opportunity to refine the spirit and uplift the soul. (http://ravkooktorah.org/KDOSHIM59.htm)

Above, Rabbi Morrison writes about eating, but, as mentioned in Rashi's comments above, it all comes back to sexuality. This concept is reflected in the writings of many other great sages, such as Rebbe Nachman of Breslov and Rebbe Shlomo of Radomsk, on the topic of Shmirat Brit Kodesh ("guarding the holy covenant").

Emor

Speak Softly and Carry a Big Kohen (Kohen Gadol)

This week's Torah portion focuses on laws regarding the priestly class, the Kohanim. As an introduction, the parashah starts with the following somewhat repetitive words:

1. And the Lord said to Moses: Speak to the kohanim, the sons of Aaron, and say to them: Let none [of you] defile himself for a dead person among his people.

א. וַיֹּאמֶר יְהוָה אֶל מֹשֶׁה אֱמֹר אֶל הַכֹּהֲנִים בְּנֵי אַהֲרֹן וְאָמַרְתָּ אֲלֵהֶם לְנֶפֶשׁ לֹא יִטַּמָּא בְּעַמָּיו׃

Rashi picks up on the repetition of th word "speak" and comments as follows:

Rashi: Speak to the kohanim: Heb. אֱמֹר וְאָמַרְתָּ "Speak [to the Kohanim ...] and say [to them]," lit. "Say...and you shall say." [This double expression comes] to admonish

the adult Kohanim regarding the young ones.

Rashi is telling us that, first and foremost, the Torah portion is about education. The laws of the Kohanim are not just for one generation of children of Aharon, but for all future generations as well.

In what manner is this education to take place? In the way of Emor, a softer embracing type of speech, as explained in Rashi's comment to the the verse in Shemot (Exodus 19:3):

3. Moses ascended to God, and the Lord called to him from the mountain, saying, "So shall you say to the house of Jacob and tell the sons of Israel,

עָלָה אֶל הָאֱלֹהִים וַיִּקְרָא אֵלָיו יְהוָה מִן הָהָר לֵאמֹר כֹּה תֹאמַר לְבֵית יַעֲקֹב וְתַגֵּיד לִבְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל׃
ג. ומשֶׁה

Rashi: to the house of Jacob: These are the women. Say it to them [Tomar, from the verb Le'emor] in a gentle language. — [from Mechilta]

Parents and teachers sometimes have the illusion that if they scream enough, their point and/or their authority will come across and their children will learn how to behave. This is rarely effective in the short-term and even less effective longterm. Gentle language (along with consistent rules and discipline) leads to much better results.

Interestingly, if you look closely, the verb Le'emor ("to say") is not used twice, but actually three times in the verse: 1) from Hashem to Moshe; 2) from Moshe to the Kohanim regarding the Kohanim themselves; 3) from Moshe to the Kohanim regarding their children.

In great part, the world runs in a way of cause-and-effect and reciprocity. In education, the way you educate your children more like than not will be the way your own kids will educate theirs, and so on and so forth. So important was the principle of educating in a gentle manner that even Hashem Himself speaks to Moshe in a way of Le'emor as opposed to Ledaber or Lehagid (other less gentle words for speaking). Moshe in turn speaks in the same manner to the Kohanim; the Kohanim to their children; the children to their children, etc. No wonder the Kohen Gadol is called Ish Chassidecha (a man of Your kindness).

Furthermore, the way you speak to your kids (and the rest of the world for that manner) is the way they end up speaking to you. The world is a mirror. Even the way you treat Hashem and His commandments is the way you end up being treated by

Him as well. This is known as Middah Keneged Middah.

We probably all agree that we could each use a little more kindness and gentleness in our lives. There is a very easy way to achieve that: starting with ourselves. The ripple effects will be felt beyond your wildest dreams.

Behar

Working the Land, Working the Soul

This week's Torah portion is first and foremost about the Land. Like last week's Parashah, the opening words are somewhat different from the norm. The Torah specifically spells out that these particular words were said to Moshe "on Mount Sinai." As one would expect, Rashi immediately comments on this intriguing variation:

1. And the Lord spoke to Moses on Mount Sinai, saying,

First, Rashi asks:

What [special relevance] does the subject of Shemittah [the "release" of fields in the seventh year] have with Mount Sinai? Were not all the commandments stated from Sinai?

He answers by saying:

Rather, just as with Shemittah, its general principles and its finer details were all stated from Sinai, likewise, all of them were stated-their general principles [together with] their finer details-from Sinai. This is what is taught in Torath Kohanim (25:1).

Rashi then further explains the above answer:

It appears to me that its explanation is as follows: since we do not find the laws of Shemittah of land reiterated on the plains of Moab in Deuteronomy, we learn that its general principles, finer details, and explanatons were all stated at Sinai. Scripture states this [phrase] here to teach us that [just as in the case of Shemittah,] every statement [i.e., every commandment] that was conveyed to Moses came from Sinai, [including] their general principles and finer details, was repeated and reviewed on the plains of Moab.

Rashi suggests that the choice to specifically mention the laws of Shmittah here provides for two separate conclusions to be drawn: 1) All laws were given at Mt. Sinai in full detail, even if the Torah does not specifically mention this regarding each law.

2) All laws were repeated and reviewed on the plains of Moab (in Deuteronomy), even those not specifically mentioned there.

Another explanation given by our sages as to why the laws of Shmittah were mentioned here is that the applicability of these laws was for some time in the very distant future, at the time the Land would not only be conquered, but also settled. If even these laws were given at Mt. Sinai in full detail, certainly all the other one were as well.

Perhaps a related, more spritually-oriented answer can be given: Shemittah is about physical land, actual earth, the ultimate in materiality. If even land was discussed in the highest detail, then certainly more "spiritual" laws were discussed in full as well.

Rashi's further clarification of his initial comment comes to teach us also the opposite lesson: even when the Jews were not as spiritually oriented, 40 years after Mt. Sinai, and about to conquer the Land, here also every law was repeated and reviewed in full, from the most material to the most spiritual.

In truth, what is "more spiritual" or "more material" is a somewhat subjective definition, based on our limited human perspective. We are told in Pirkei Avot that we are not supposed to weigh the importance of the Mitzvot. Both are extremely important, in every phase of our lives, both the more spiritual times as well as the more material ones.

Also, if one looks at the actual laws of Shemittah and Yovel (Jubilee) discussed in the beginning of this week's portion, one cannot help but see a clear connection with the Mitzvah of Counting the Omer, the 49 days (seven weeks) from Passover to Shavuoth. The Omer count is very spiritual in nature - it's a time of the year when we all become Kabbalists, focusing on the Sefirah combination for that day (Chesed shebeChesed, Gevurah shebeChesed, Hod shebeHod, and so forth).

Ultimately, whether we are working on our souls and conquering our evil inclination, or conquering and working the Land, the objective is the same: getting closer and closer to G-d, by doing his will.

All of this is very connected to the month we're in Iyar, related to the Tribe of Issachar, and the coming month, Sivan, related to the Tribe of Zebulun. The men of Issachar spent their days fully immersed in Torah study, while the men of Zebulun were heavily involved in commerce and supported their sibling tribe.

It is also quite appropriate then that the Counting of the Omer takes place at this time of the year, as well as the holidays celebrating the recent conquest of the Land: Yom Ha'Atzma'ut and Yom Yerushalayim. It is also the time of extremely spiritual days: Lag Ba'omer and, very soon, Shavuot.

Bechukotai

Pursuit and Self-Persecution

This week's Torah portion describes the rewards and blessings bestowed upon us when we as a people are observing the Torah (specifically dedicating ourselves to its study), as well as the punishments and curses that come when we fail to do so. The descriptions bring to mind the events that took place during the Holocaust as well as those immediately after, at the time of the establishment of the State of Israel. By no means is one to infer that those events were in effect the reward and punishment of that particular generation - anyone with any experience or knowledge of those events should know that this could not possibly be the case.

One powerful contrast between the section of the blessings and the one of the curses has to do with the pursuit of the enemy. While regarding the curses, the verses repeatedly mention the fact that we would run away when no one was pursuing us, regarding the blessings, the Torah states:

8. Five of you will pursue a hundred, and a hundred of you will pursue ten thousand, and your enemies will fall by the sword before you.

RASHI: of you will pursue: [It will require only five] of your weakest [to pursue a hundred enemies], and not of your strongest [i.e., מִכֶּם means "the weakest (מֶ) of you."]- [Sifthei Chachamim; Torath Kohanim 26:10]

RASHI: Five... will pursue a hundred, and a hundred of you will pursue ten thousand: But is this calculation correct? [Since five will pursue a hundred, this means that each Jew will pursue twenty enemies;] therefore, should Scripture not have written here: "and a hundred of you will pursue two thousand"? But, [the Torah teaches us that] there is no comparison between a few who fulfill the Torah and many who fulfill the Torah [and thus, here, the larger the group of pursuers, the higher proportionately is the number pursued]. — [Torath Kohanim 26:10]

Rashi's mathematical calculation is certainly very interesting, and makes us appreciate the exponential value of the combined Torah observance and righteousness. What is perhaps equally as interesting is that Rashi does not even comment (even though his words make clear) on the fact that when it comes to our enemy (both external and internal - the evil inclination), there is no combined exponential growth at all. It is almost as if evil did not matter - that it was there almost only to play a "supporting role" to the good.

That is in fact the case. Evil has no real substance - it all depends on us. These are the famous words of the Fifth Lubavitcher Rebbe, before his last Ma'amar (Chassidic Discourse). Communist soldiers were searching house by house for "illegal" religious activity. They barged in to the home of the Rebbe and were planning on searching the entire house and making arrests. The Rebbe and his Chassidim were in a Farbrengen (speaking words of Torah, singing and drinking) and the Rebbe continued as if the soldiers weren't even there. He told all of his Chassidim to pay no attention to them."

"With great ecstasy he exclaimed: 'I will say another Maamar, so they will become completely [batul - nullified].' He then said the Maamar, 'Reishis Goyim Amalek', which explains that the forces that oppose G-dliness do not exist in the true sense." myshliach.com

This is the ultimate truth. However, when we are not steeped enough in Torah learning, or otherwise disconnected from the Source, then we feel constantly pursued, when in fact there is no one pursuing us at all - but ourselves.

BOOK FOUR

Bamidbar

In the Desert

Bamidbar

Being Dear to G-d

B"H

1. The Lord spoke to Moses in the Sinai Desert, in the Tent of Meeting on the first day of the second month, in the second year after the exodus from the land of Egypt, saying.

RASHI: The Lord spoke... in the Sinai Desert... on the first of the month :Because they were dear to Him, He counted them often. When they left Egypt, He counted them (Exod. 12:37); when [many] fell because [of the sin] of the golden calf, He counted them to know the number of the survivors (Exod. 32:28); when He came to cause His Divine Presence to rest among them, He counted them. On the first of Nissan, the Mishkan was erected, and on the first of Iyar, He counted them.

One of the most essential lessions from the opening verse for the Book of Bamidbar (Numbers) is that no matter what, in our ups and in our downs, Hashem we are always dear to Him.

Nasso

Brides

This week's Torah portion continues the counting of the Jewish people (specifically the Levites), and contains the laws of the Sotah (wayward wife) and the Nazir (the holy nazirite, who abstained from wine and from cutting his hair). It also describes the completion of the Mishkan (Tabernacle) and the offering of the princes of each one of the Twelve Tribes.

In the middle of the Torah portion, Rashi makes a fascinating comment on the following verse:

1. And it was that on the day that Moses finished erecting the Mishkan, he anointed it, sanctified it, and all its vessels, and the altar and all its vessels, and he anointed them and sanctified them.

א. וַיְהִי בְּיוֹם כַּלּוֹת מֹשֶׁה לְהָקִים אֶת הַמִּשְׁכָּן וַיִּמְשַׁח אֹתוֹ וַיְקַדֵּשׁ אֹתוֹ וְאֶת כָּל כֵּלָיו וְאֶת הַמִּזְבֵּחַ וְאֶת כָּל כֵּלָיו וַיִּמְשָׁחֵם וַיְקַדֵּשׁ אֹתָם׃

RASHI: And it was that on the day that Moses finished: Heb. כַּלּוֹת. On the day the Mishkan was erected, the Israelites were like a bride (כַּלָּה) entering the nuptial canopy.

The comparison of Israel as G-d's bride, entering the nuptial canopy, sounds familiar. The giving of the Torah at Mount Sinai is often compared to our wedding with G-d. Here, however, the Torah discusses a much later event, after the giving of the Torah, the sin of the golden calf, and the forgiveness we received on the following Yom Kippur.

In life, we have more than one opportunity to be like a bride entering the nuptial canopy. As Rebbe Nachman of Breslev teaches, every moment is an opportunity to start again, from the beginning, in a brand new relationship with G-d and with the world.

Perhaps that is why the Torah specifically used the word כַּלּוֹת in the plural instead of כַּלָּה in the singular. To be a Kalah does not need to be a one time thing. Each of us can be Kalot, starting anew again and again, just as we will receive the Torah again, just like the first time, on Shavuot.

Beha'alotcha

Inverted Situations

The Torah portion of Beha'alotcha contains a segment demarcated by two inverted nuns, the only such occurence in the Torah. Our sages remark that the nun stands for nefilah, fall, and that it is from this point on that the Jewish people begin to experience spiritual falls. Rashi's commentary on the verse follows a similar line of thinking, but it is not exactly the same:

35. So it was, whenever the ark set out, Moses would say, Arise, O Lord, may Your enemies be scattered and may those who hate You flee from You.

לה. וַיְהִי בִּנְסֹעַ הָאָרֹן וַיֹּאמֶר מֹשֶׁה קוּמָה | יְהוָה וְיָפֻצוּ אֹיְבֶיךָ וְיָנֻסוּ מְשַׂנְאֶיךָ מִפָּנֶיךָ׃

RASHI: So it was, whenever the ark set out: He made marks for it [this passage], before it and after it, as if to indicate that this is not its proper place [in Scripture]. So why was it written here? To make a break between one punishment and the next… as it is stated in [chapter 16 of Talmud Shabbath , commencing with the words] "All the Sacred Scriptures."

Rashi states that the nuns "make a break between one punishment and the next." There's only one tremendous difficulty with this statement: there is no evidence of any punishment immediately preceding the demarcation. Only after this line does the Torah mention that the Jewish people complained and that this was evil in Hashem's eyes, which caused a fire to burn in the camp. Before, there is no mention of punishment, neither in this portion or the one prior. It is even hard to remember the last time punishment was mentioned at all, except perhaps for the Torah portion of Bechukotai (in the Book of Leviticus!), which is discussing future punishments.

The answer to this question lies perhaps in the fact that we do not really understand what is meant by punishment and what is meant by a spiritual descent.

Immediately prior to the above verse, the Torah describes how Moshe tried to convince Yitro, his fahter-in-law, to come to the Land of Israel with them, but that (at least for now) he refused and returned to his home. This itself can be considered a punishment, because having Yitro with them was a tremendous honor. He after all, was someone who had tried every single idol worship and rejected all of them to accept G-d alone. His departure showed that the Children of Israel had failed to make a significant lasting impression on him that would have made him truly leave everything behind and fully join them, just as he had done initially. Yitro's excitement did not last, which was perhaps an indication that it was never fully there to begin with.

Similarly, the text indicates that the Jewish people themselves were not on such a high spiritual level as they imagined. Our sages teach us that when they departed from the "Mountain of G-d," they were actually willingly trying to escape from G-dliness. This also is the greatest punishment.

When a person sins and is punished, do not think that the sin appeared out of the blue. Rebbe Nachman teaches that the sin is a true indication of your actual level! You might have thought you were much higher than that, but the reality is that you were never so high. The proof is that you now sinned.

The positive side of this is that it leaves no reason to be sad because of sin. Now that you know your true level, you are free to restart your Divine service in a much more true and real way, without delusions of grandeur. Start again, fully trusting in Hashem's mercy and realizing that both the sin and the punishment are actually a FAVOR that G-d does for us, taking us out of our inverted sense of greatness and helping us land on our feet.

Shelach

Ants, Grasshoppers

Thank you to Daniel Najman for thinking of this question in Rashi.

The Torah portion for this week includes the disgraceful account of the spies. All but two of them (Calev and Yehoshuah) went about exploring the Land of Israel in the wrong way, coming back with a negative report. Their report, and the people's reaction to it, caused the Jewish people to wander an additional 40 years, and that entire generation did not enter the Land.

A particularly puzzling part of the spies' report is a comment about how they looked in the eyes of the former inhabitants:

33. There we saw the giants, the sons of Anak, descended from the giants. In our eyes, we seemed like grasshoppers, and so we were in their eyes.

It is one thing to state how they saw themselves compared to them (which is bad enough), but yet a whole other level of lack of emunah to think that the inhabitants themselves saw them in the same light. How could they know?

Rashi gives an answer to this inherent question by commenting as follows:

RASHI: and so we were in their eyes: We heard them telling each other,"There are ants in the vineyard who look like people." - [Sotah 35a]

Rashi answers the above question but raises another. Why does the description change from "grasshoppers" to "ants."

Perhaps the answer is as follows: Depending on the context, being seen like an ant can also be a very great compliment. In Proverbs, King Solomon states, "Go to the ant and become wise." (Proverbs 6:6; Perek Shirah 6:6 also!)

Grasshoppers are generally considered pests and not good for the land. Ants are generally considered good and compatible with working the land. The spies, who actually wished to stay in the desert living a completely spiritual existence, were trying to say that we did not belong in the Land of Israel.

Nothing could be further from the truth. The spies had said, "The land we passed through to explore is a land that consumes its inhabitants..." They were afraid of its physicality and did not wish to be consumed by it. They did not comprehend that this was Hashem's will. He wants us to engage with the physical and elevate it. That is how we know if our spirituality is real in the first place.

Korach

Human Calculations

This week's Torah portion depicts Korach's rebellion against Moshe and Aharon and the Divine retribution that followed. Rashi makes an extensive comment that explains the nature of the rebellion, quoted below in most relevant part:

1. Korah the son of Izhar, the son of Kohath, the son of Levi took [himself to one side] along with Dathan and Abiram, the sons of Eliab, and On the son of Peleth, descendants of Reuben.

RASHI - Dathan and Abiram: ... [Korach said] Who is entitled to receive the second [position]? Is it not I, who am the son of Izhar, who is the second brother to Amram? And yet, he [Moses] appointed to the chieftainship the son of his youngest brother! I hereby oppose him and will invalidate his word ... He dressed [250 men] with cloaks made entirely of blue wool. They came and stood before Moses and asked him, "Does a cloak made entirely of blue wool require fringes ['tzitzith'], or is it exempt?" He replied, " It does require [fringes]." They began laughing at him [saying], "Is it possible that a cloak of another [colored] material, one string of blue wool exempts it [from the obligation of techeleth], and this one, which is made entirely of blue wool, should not exempt itself?

Korach was very smart. His logic was flawless. There was only one slight problem: the G-d of Israel is not limited to human logic. The main issue with Korach's dispute is not that he was wrong; people make mistakes all the time. The problem was that by limiting the entire situation to logic, he was not only debasing Moshe, but also Israel, the Torah, and G-d Himself. After all, Moshe did not make any decisions on his own. G-d was the One that appointed Moshe and his brother! Moshe did not decide that a cloak of Techelet requires Tzit-Tzit any more than he decided his role as leader. Korach's challenges put him on par with Dathan and Abiram, who our sages teach us, time and again failed to see the G-d's hand in everything that took place since the first moments of redemption from Egypt. It is therefore not coincidental that Rashi's comments are placed next to both of their names.

We also must open our eyes and realize that the events of our lives are truly Divinely ordained, and not simply a product of human calculations.

Chukat

Miriam, the Red Heifer

B"H

This week's Torah portion begins with the description of the purification ritual of the "Red Heifer" followed by mentioning of the death of Miriam. Rashi notes the juxtaposition of these two subjects in verses regarding Miriam and states as follows:

1. The entire congregation of the children of Israel arrived at the desert of Zin in the first month, and the people settled in Kadesh. Miriam died there and was buried there.

RASHI - Miriam died there: Why is the passage relating Miriam's death juxtaposed with the passage of the Red Cow? To teach you that just as sacrifices bring atonement, so the death of the righteous secure atonement. — [M.K. 28a].

The parallels between Miriam and the Red Heifer appear to go beyond the idea of atonement for the Jewish people. The Red Heifer appears related to atonement for Miriam herself. The Red Heifer is said to be an atonement for the cardinal sin of idolatry, related to the Golden Calf (a young cow), but it also appears to be related to a sin that is equal to all three cardinal sins (idolatry, murder, and adultery): Lashon HaRah, evil speech. Miriam's words regarding Moshe, even though they were said

with the best of intentions, is the quintessential example of Lashon HaRah. Below are two verses that recount the occurence and Miriam's punishment. The opening verse of the story and the last one:

1. Miriam and Aaron spoke against Moses regarding the Cushite woman he had married (lit. "taken"), for he had married (lit. "taken") a Cushite woman.

...

15. So Miriam was confined outside the camp for seven days, and the people did not travel until Miriam had entered.

Regarding the Red Heifer, the first verses of our Torah portion contain very similar language to the above:

1. The Lord spoke to Moses and Aaron, saying:

2. This is the statute of the Torah which the Lord commanded, saying, Speak to the children of Israel and have them take for you a perfectly red unblemished cow, upon which no yoke was laid.

3. And you shall give it to Eleazar the kohen, and he shall take it outside the camp and slaughter it in his presence.

4. Eleazar the kohen shall take from its blood with his finger and sprinkle it toward the front of the Tent of Meeting seven times.

Rashi's comments also parallel Miriam and her actions towards Moshe:

RASHI - This is the statute of the Torah: Because Satan and the nations of the world taunt Israel, saying, " What is this commandment, and what purpose does it have?" Therefore, the Torah uses the term "statute." I have decreed it; You have no right to challenge it. — [Yoma 67b]

and have them take for you: It will always be called on your name; 'the cow which Moses prepared in the desert.'- [Mid. Tanchuma Chukath 8, see Etz Yosef]

perfectly red: lit., red, perfect. It shall be perfect in redness, so that two black hairs disqualify it. — [Sifrei Chukath 5]

1) Just as Miriam was told by Hashem that she has no right to challenge Moshe's separation from his wife, so too, the Satan and the nations are told that they have no right to challenge the mitzvah of the Red Heifer.

2) Just as Miriam is introduced in the Torah as Miriam's sister, so to the Red Heifer will always be called by Moshe's name.

3) Just as Miriam attempted to disqualify Moshe's actions regarding his marriage to a "Cushite" (black) woman, which is repeated twice, so too, even just two black hairs disqualify a Red Heifer.

There are other parallels between Miriam and the Red Heifer. Miriam is the ancestor of King David, who is described in the Torah as being red. She merited to have the line of David descend from her because she acted with pure unblemished faith before Pharaoh, when she did not obey his command to kill the newborn children of the Jewish people.

Miriam was also from the Tribe of Levi, which did not have to serve as slaves in Egypt. She therefore had no yoke placed upon her.

It is interesting to note that in Book I of The Kabbalah of Time, Week 27, the week of the Cow, is very close to Miriam's yahrzeit. That week is also a week connected to purification through the Red Heifer, as it comes immediately prior to Passover.

Moshe's actions following the description of the Red Heifer and Miriam's death, appear to be a further attempt to spiritually fix what Miriam had done. After Miriam speaks to Aharon, Hashem appears and tells them:

6. He said, "Please listen [SHIMU NAH] to My words. If there be prophets among you, [I] the Lord will make Myself known to him in a vision; I will speak to him in a dream.

In this week's Torah portion, right after Miriam's death, there is no water for the people:

2. The congregation had no water; so they assembled against Moses and Aaron.

RASHI - had no water: From here [we learn that] all forty years they had the well in Miriam's merit. — [Ta'anith 9a]

(...)

10. Moses and Aaron assembled the congregation in front of the rock, and he said to them, "Now listen, [SHIMU NAH] you rebels, can we draw water for you from this rock?"

Moshe was trying, once and for all, to make the people stop doubting their leadership: "Please listen, understand!" The problem was that this time it was Moshe that did not properly understand - Hashem had said to use the staff to gather the people, but not to hit the rock... Miriam, whose merit the water had been provided

until now, was known to speak (not hit) to crying children in the gentlest of manners:

15. Now the king of Egypt spoke to the Hebrew midwives, one who was named Shifrah, and the second, who was named Puah.

RASHI - Puah: This was Miriam, [called Puah] because she cried (פּוֹעָה) and talked and cooed to the newborn infant in the manner of women who soothe a crying infant. פּוֹעָה is an expression of crying out, similar to "Like a travailing woman will I cry (אֶפְעֶה) " (Isa. 42:14).

After all, knowing the power of words is the main lesson of the entire Book of Bamidbar.

Balak

Horrible Bosses

B"H

This week's Torah portion is about the greatest prophet among the gentiles, Bilaam, and the evil king Balak, that hired him to curse the Jewish people. Instead of a curse, Bilaam delivers one of the most beautiful blessings ever delivered to our people.

The Shem M'Shmuel states that Balak and Bilaam were trying hard to nullify everything that Avraham, Itzchak and Yaakov accomplished, and prevent the Jewish people from entering our Promised Land.

The parallels between Avraham and Bilaam are quite extraordinary. Avraham is told that whoever blesses him will be blessed and whoever curses him will be cursed. About Bilaam it states, whoever he curses will be cursed and whoever he blesses will be blessed.

When embarking on a mission, the Torah states that Avraham arose early in the mourning and saddled his donkey. Almost the same words are used in describing Bilaam's preparations:

21. In the morning Balaam arose, saddled his she-donkey and went with the Moabite dignitaries.

Rashi picks up on this parallel and comments on the above verse:

saddled his she-donkey: From here [we learn] that hate causes a disregard for the standard [of dignified conduct], for he saddled it himself. The Holy One, blessed is He, said, "Wicked one, their father Abraham has already preceded you, as it says, 'Abraham arose in the morning and saddled his donkey'" (Gen. 22:3). - [Mid. Tanchuma Balak 8, Num. Rabbah 20:12]

Another striking parallel is that both men took with them two young men to accompany them in their mission. Rashi's comments in both passages regarding this are very similar, but far from identical. Regarding Abraham, it states:

3. And Abraham arose early in the morning, and he saddled his donkey, and he took his two young men with him and Isaac his son; and he split wood for a burnt offering, and he arose and went to the place of which God had told him.

RASHI - his two young men: Ishmael and Eliezer, for a person of esteem is not permitted to go out on the road without two men, so that if one must ease himself ["go to the bathroom"] and move to a distance, the second one will remain with him.

Regarding Bilaam:

22. God's wrath flared because he was going, and an angel of the Lord stationed himself on the road to thwart him, and he was riding on his she-donkey, and his two servants were with him.

RASHI - and his two servants were with him: From here we learn that a distinguished person who embarks on a journey should take two people with him to attend to him, and then they can attend to each other.

Why does Rashi change the wording, regarding Bilaam. Why is it necessary to state that the servants of Avraham will need to distance themselves and go to the bathroom, while regarding Bilaam it says that they will attend to each other. Wouldn't one expect the more "respectful" (non-bathroom) language to be used regarding Avraham and not Bilaam?

The answer is that Avraham's encampment, like that of the Jewish people, was holy. One of the laws regarding a holy encampment is that one may not defecate among it. One must distance oneself and cover the excrement. The servants of Avraham would have to distance themselves when going to the bathroom. Although Bilaam praises the Jewish encampment for being holy, his own encampment was not. Quite the contrary, it was of the utmost impurity, and there was no need whatsoever to distance it from filth.

Similarly, Avraham's servants had a gracious and generous master, someone who knew their limits and would not overwhelm them. When one had to leave, the other would be able to attend to him. Bilaam was self-centered egotistical and the servants needed each other just to be able to cope with their master's vain demands, which most likely were anything but realistic, as we see regarding his interaction with his mule.

As Pirkei Avot makes clear, we must always strive to be students of Avraham, staying holy and pure, and deserving of the highest blessings, that had to be brought down through the impure mouth of the unholy Bilaam.

Pinchas

Earning One's Place

B"H

This week's Torah portion begins with the description of the great reward given to Pinchas for his dramatic act of killing the prince of the tribe of Shimon and the Midianite princess with whom he was openly having relations. In doing so, he stopped the plague that had engulfed the Jewish people. The plague had resulted also from the worshipping of the Midianite idol known as Baal Peor. The reward that Pinchas receives is nothing less than Kehunah, the priesthood.

There is, however, somewhat of mystery to the reward given. One would think that Pinchas, son of Elazar, the Kohen Gadol, would already be considered a Kohen. Rashi explains:

10. The Lord spoke to Moses, saying: 11. Phinehas the son of Eleazar the son of Aaron the kohen has turned My anger away from the children of Israel by his zealously avenging Me among them, so that I did not destroy the children of Israel because of My zeal. 12. Therefore, say, "I hereby give him My covenant of peace. 13. It shall be for him and for his descendants after him [as] an eternal covenant of kehunah, because he was zealous for his God and atoned for the children of Israel."

RASHI: an eternal covenant of kehunah: Although the kehunah had already been given to Aaron's descendants, it had been given only to Aaron and his sons who were anointed with him, and to their children whom they would beget after their anointment. Phinehas, however, who was born before that and had never been

anointed, had not been included in the kehunah until now. And so, we learn in [Tractate] Zevachim [101b],"Phinehas was not made a kohen until he killed Zimri."

Why is it that Aaron's sons, as well as future generations, received the priesthood automatically, while Pinchas had to earn it?

We know that in spirituality, certain positions and even character traits are inherited. Judaism itself is something inherited from our forefathers, Avraham, Yitzchak and Yaakov. Those that wish to join our people (converts), must earn that right through what is often a long and cumbersome process.

The Torah states that the priesthood was given to Yocheved for her bravery in saving the Jewish newborn babies and ignoring Pharaoh's orders. This reward materialized with Aharon, her eldest son, who showed great initiative in meeting his brother Moshe and being an essential part of the redemption process. As we learn in Pirkei Avot, Aharon himself embodied the ideals of the covenant of peace: He "loves peace and pursues peace, loves the creations and brings them closer to the Torah."

Why then was Pinchas left out? One can certainly assume that he had already inherited the same qualities (from Yocheved and Aharon) that Elazar and the other Kohanim had inherited.

Perhaps the answer is that Hashem wanted to give Pinchas an additional reward and connection to the Kehunah. To earn something, as opposed to getting it as an inheritance, is certainly a lot more special. Yes, the qualities were there all along. However, because Pinchas was able to specifically do something to become a Kohen, it was that much more special.

The same is true regarding converts, as well as our final redemption. Yes, converts have the qualities necessary to become Jewish all along (their souls too were at Sinai), but when they become Jewish through their own efforts, it's that much more special. Yes, Hashem has the ability to redeem us at any moment, but when we put in our own efforts, and share in its coming into being, we will value it that much more. And so will He.

Matot

Verbal Agreements

This week's Torah portion contains a striking parallel between how it begins and how it ends. The portion begins as follows:

2. Moses spoke to the heads of the tribes of the children of Israel, saying: This is the thing the Lord has commanded. 3. If a man makes a vow to the Lord or makes an oath to prohibit himself, he shall not violate his word; according to whatever proceeded from his mouth, he shall do.

ב. וַיְדַבֵּר מֹשֶׁה אֶל רָאשֵׁי הַמַּטּוֹת לִבְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל לֵאמֹר זֶה הַדָּבָר אֲשֶׁר צִוָּה יְהוָה
כִּי יִדֹּר נֶדֶר לַיהוָה אוֹ הִשָּׁבַע שְׁבֻעָה לֶאְסֹר אִסָּר עַל נַפְשׁוֹ לֹא יַחֵל דְּבָרוֹ כְּכָל הַיֹּצֵא מִפִּיו יַעֲשֶׂה׃
ג. אִישׁ

Towards the end of the Torah portion, the tribes of Gad, Reuven, and half of Menashe ask Moshe to dwell on the other side of the Jordan, not in the Land of Israel proper. They promise to join the rest of the people in conquering the land, and "build sheepfolds for our livestock here and cities for our children." Moshe responds:

24. So build yourselves cities for your children and enclosures for your sheep, and what has proceeded from your mouth you shall do."

כד. בְּנוּ לָכֶם עָרִים לְטַפְּכֶם וּגְדֵרֹת לְצֹנַאֲכֶם וְהַיֹּצֵא מִפִּיכֶם תַּעֲשׂוּ׃

Rashi famously comments on how Moshe changes the order of the Tribes' promise. He states as follows:

We shall build sheepfolds for our livestock here: They were more concerned about their possessions than about their sons and daughters, since they mentioned their livestock before [mentioning] their children. Moses said to them, "Not so! Treat the fundamental as a fundamental, and the matter of secondary importance as a matter of secondary importance. First 'build cities for your children,' and afterwards 'enclosures for your sheep'" (verse 24) - [Mid. Tanchuma Mattoth 7]

Another comment made by Rashi, perhaps not as famous, is on the phrase that links the beginning of the Parasha to its end:

and what has proceeded from your mouth you shall do: for the sake of the Most High [God], for you have undertaken to cross over for battle until [the completion of] conquest and the apportionment [of the Land]. Moses had asked of them only "and... will be conquered before the Lord, afterwards you may return," (verse 22), but

they undertook,"until... has taken possession" (verse 18). Thus, they added that they would remain seven years while it was divided, and indeed they did so (see Josh. 22).

Moshe is holding the Tribes accountable for an additional condition, which Moshe himself had not asked of them. Moshe asked that they stay until the Land be conquered, but they vowed to stay until the Land had been properly apportioned, which required that they stay an additional seven years.

The question is: how could Moshe hold them to this requirement if in fact they did not pledge to this in the form of a vow. All they said was, "We shall not return to our homes until each of the children of Israel has taken possession of his inheritance." One could even argue that they were still "negotiating" with Moshe.

From here we learn again, what is the main theme of the Book of Bamidbar: the tremendous power of words. (Midbar means desert, but has at its root Davar, word). One has to be so very careful about what one says, certainly involving the bad, but regarding the good as well. In Jewish law, any expression of willingness to perform a mitzvah or good deed brings upon an obligation.

Moshe is therefore able to take something that seemed abstract and perhaps even out-of-place in the outset of the parashah, and drive it home in the most practical of ways: a few added words led to a commitment to stay seven more years away from their families and livestock, and as Rashi concludes, "indeed they did so."

Massei

The Journey as the Cure

This week's Torah portion speaks of the 42 journeys of the Jewish people in the desert. The second Rashi's opening comments make a parallel between Hashem and the Jewish people and a king that is taking his son back from a journey to find a cure for him:

1. These are the journeys of the children of Israel who left the land of Egypt in their legions, under the charge of Moses and Aaron.

RASHI: ... It is analogous to a king whose son became sick, so he took him to a far away place to have him healed. On the way back, the father began citing all the stages of their journey, saying to him, "This is where we sat, here we were cold, here you had a headache etc." - [Mid. Tanchuma Massei 3, Num. Rabbah 23:3]

What is the cure and what is the illness? The Jewish people had not entered the Land yet. They were now at its border, ready to enter. Wouldn't it be more appropriate for Rashi to speak about an upcoming cure? And why are they on their way back?

The answer is that coming to Israel is the way back. The cure was the exile itself. Rebbe Nosson of Breslov speaks of how the exile took place because of a lack of faith. The exile and the wondering in the desert made it possible for that faith to be restored.

Similarly, the Counting of the Omer represents a period in which we cure ourselves. The Lubavitcher Rebbe points out that 49 is the gematria of Choleh, sick. Only after we are cured can we receive the Torah.

49 also equals the number of journeys (42) plus the number of Cana'anite nations to be conquered (7). The first 42 days of the omer, as well as the 42 journeys, are about internal rectification, the sefirot of Chesed through Yesod. From 43 to 49, we tackle our outwardly behavior, in dealing with the reality of the world around. That reality must be conquered, and that requires "curing" the Sefirah of Malchut, kingship. Don't be afraid to show the world who's Boss.

Observation: It is well known that G-d's seal is truth, Emet, in Hebrew. There is also a well known explanation that the word Emet itself represents truth because its gematria is 441, and 4+4+1 = 9. 9 is a number very much connected to truth because any multiple of 9, if you sum up their digits, is a multiple of 9. For example, 18 is 1+8=9, 27 is 2+7=9, 36, 45, and so on.

In addition to the above well known concept, there also appears to be a another reason 441 is chosen. 441, for the reasons explained above, is also a multiple of the number 9. But not just any multiple: 441 is 49 x 9.

BOOK FIVE

Devarim

Words

Devarim

"All of Israel"

This past week we began a new Book of the Torah: Devarim ("Words") in Hebrew. In keeping with the month of Av, and Tisha B'Av, which is upon us, the words that open the Book are actually words of rebuke. Rashi points out that the rebuke, however, is said quite indirectly.

אֶל כָּל יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּעֵבֶר הַיַּרְדֵּן בַּמִּדְבָּר בָּעֲרָבָה מוֹל סוּף בֵּין פָּארָן וּבֵין תֹּפֶל וְלָבָן וַחֲצֵרֹת וְדִי זָהָב׃
א. אֵלֶּה הַדְּבָרִים אֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר מֹשֶׁה

1. These are the words which Moses spoke to all Israel on the side of the Jordan in the desert, in the plain opposite the Red Sea, between Paran and Tofel and Lavan and Hazeroth and Di Zahav.

Rashi: These are the words: Since these are words of rebuke and he [Moses] enumerates here all the places where they angered the Omnipresent, therefore it makes no explicit mention of the incidents [in which they transgressed], but rather merely alludes to them, [by mentioning the names of the places] out of respect for Israel (cf. Sifrei)

Rashi also notes that these words were said to every single person of Israel:

Rashi: to all Israel: If he had rebuked only some of them, those who were in the marketplace [i.e., absent] might have said, "You heard from [Moses] the son of Amram, and did not answer a single word regarding this and that; had we been there, we would have answered him!" Therefore, he assembled all of them, and said to them, "See, you are all here; if anyone has an answer, let him answer!" - [from Sifrei]

Rashi then starts listing each of the places mentioned in the above verse and relating it to each of the major sins of the Jews in the desert. There is, however, one

apparent gap in Rashi's analysis. Rashi begins by mentioning "in the desert," as the first place, related to the sin of having angered Hashem in the desert. In the above verse, though, "in the desert," is not the first place mentioned. Rather, the first geographic position noted is, "on the side of the Jordan," in Hebrew, "בְּעֵבֶר הַיַּרְדֵּן (B'Ever HaYarden)."

Why did Rashi not link this place to one of the sins of the Jewish people. The answer perhaps is that this one is a reference not to any particular, but to the whole. It appears to be connected to the previous part of the verse, "to all Israel," as B'Ever HaYarden is reminiscent of the first partriarch of the Jewish people, Avraham Ha'Ivri (the Hebrew). Avraham is called Ha'Ivri because he stood on one side (believing in One G-d), while the entire world stood on the other. It may well also be a reference to the other side of the Jordan as well. The Jordan itself also symbolizes the all-encompassing whole. It runs from the Sea of Galilee, in the north of Israel all the way to its south, down to the Dead Sea.

There is however, also a hint to concept of the sins of Israel as a whole. The Hebrew word for Jordan, Yarden, is composed of the word Yarad (descended) and the final Nun, Nun-Sofit. The Nun is often associated with the word Nephilah, fall. However, the Nun is also associated with the redeemer, Moshe, and the final Nun with the final redeemer, Mashiach. (See Book 6, on the current, 14th cycle of 22 days of the year, here)

Every descent is only for the sake of a greater ascent. In order to learn how to walk, sometimes it is necessary to fall first. The main thing is to remain united, connected to the whole. If we do so, we are certain to merit

Va'etchanan

"Giving it All You've Got" and the Parashah of Va'etchanan

This week's Torah portion speaks of how Hashem pleaded with G-d to let him into the Land of Israel, so much so that Hashem had to tell him to stop asking. It also describes the Exodus from Egypt and the giving of the Torah, and concludes with the first paragraph of the Shemah:

4. Hear, O Israel: The Lord is our God; the Lord is one.

5. And you shall love the Lord, your God, with all your heart and with all your soul, and with all your means.

6. And these words, which I command you this day, shall be upon your heart. 7. And you shall teach them to your sons and speak of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk on the way, and when you lie down and when you rise up. 8. And you shall bind them for a sign upon your hand, and they shall be for ornaments between your eyes.

9. And you shall inscribe them upon the doorposts of your house and upon your gates.

(Deuteronomy, Chapter 6)

Rashi's comments on these verses are quite incisive. However, there is one in particular comment that stands out: "and with all your means: with all your possessions. There are people whose possessions are more precious to them than their own bodies. Therefore, it says, 'and with all your means.'"

Rashi's comments are almost always a response to an inherent simple question that would bother a sharp five-year-old. The question here seems to be, "Why mention 'with all your means' at all? Wouldn't 'with all your heart and with all your soul' also imply with 'all your means' as well?" Especially since Rashi had just stated regardgin "with all your soul," that it means, "Even if He takes your soul." Rashi therefore answers that this is not necessarily the case because there are people whose possessions are more precious to them than their own bodies.

Interestingly, Rashi does not say that there are people whose possessions are more precious to them than their souls. That would appear to have been a more direct correlation with the previous verse. Why then does Rashi particularly state, "their bodies?"

Perhaps the answer is that what was bothering Rashi was a different question altogether. The verses of the Shemah appear related to three different dimensions of a person: intellectual/spiritual ("soul," which rests is in the mind"), emotional (heart) and physical ("means," action).

Rashi's inherent question then would have been: "Regarding the physical realm/dimension, why does the Torah state "your means," instead of "your body." Rashi than answers that a person can (and should) reach a level of involvement in the world in which their possessions are literally their "means" in which to affect the

world, and become more precious to them than their own body.

This second way of understanding Rashi's inherent question would be a more positive way of interpreting Rashi's comment, and would appear to be in line with the Talmud's own statement in Chullin 91a regarding our forefather Jacob's going back across the river Jabok to pick up some small vessels he left behind. The Talmud states there that, "From here [we may infer] that the money of righteous people (Tzadikim) is more precious to them than their bodies." Jacob had crossed the river alone at night, when he encountered Esau's angel, who attacked him.

Encountering Esau's angel appears to have been a good thing to have happened to Jacob, because his victory over him is ultimately what gave him the confidence to face down Esau himself the following day. The Kli Yakar, however, disagrees, and sees Jacob's behavior as overly materialistic and Esau's angel attack as a punishment. The statement of the Talmud would then need to be interpreted as "even the money of Tzadikim can become more precious than their bodies." (http://vbm-torah.org/archive/salt-bereishit/08-15vayishlach.htm)

Regarding Rashi, the question remains. Is his statement regarding certain people viewing money being more precious than their bodies ultimately positive or negative? Is it talking about somebody who is overly materialistic or of someone who is so righteous that they see a higher purpose in their money? The fact that Rashi slightly changed the words of the Talmud and does not use the term "righteous" (Tzadik) but simply "Adam," man/person, suggests that he is in fact referring to both scenarios. This is also hinted at by the second part of this explanation to this verse:

Another explanation of וּבְכָל-מְאֹדֶךָ [and with all your means"] is: You shall love God with whatever measure (מִדָּה) He metes out to you, whether it be the measure of good or the measure of retribution. Thus also did David say: "I will lift up the cup of salvations [and I will call upon the name of the Lord]" (Ps. 116:12-13); "I found trouble and grief [and I called out in the name of the Lord]" (Ps. 116:3-4).

In both cases, whether you are a righteous individual and you "lift up the cup" (elevating your posessions to holiness and bringing the world closer to G-d), or if instead you are still over materialistic and that causes you to be encountered by "trouble and grief"), either way you must love G-d. Love him with everything you've got.

Ekev

G-d's Committment to the Land

One of the main themes of this week's Torah portion is primarily about reward for following G-d's commandments. Last week's sixth Aliyah (reading) contained the first paragraph of the Shemah, and this week's portion contains the Shemah's second paragraph. It also contains a somewhat puzzling comment by Rashi.

The sixth aliyah has a few additional verses before reaching the part contained in the Shemah:

10. For the land to which you are coming to possess is not like the land of Egypt, out of which you came, where you sowed your seed and which you watered by foot, like a vegetable garden.

11. But the land, to which you pass to possess, is a land of mountains and valleys and absorbs water from the rains of heaven,

12. a land the Lord, your God, looks after; the eyes of Lord your God are always upon it, from the beginning of the year to the end of the year.

13. And it will be, if you hearken to My commandments that I command you this day to love the Lord, your God, and to serve Him with all your heart and with all your soul...

Rashi - And it will be, if you hearken: וְהָיָה (Vehayah) is referring to what is said above (verse 11):"and absorbs water from the rains of heaven"

Why does Rashi feel that it is necessary to note that Vehayah is referring back to verse 11 (describing rain) and not a continuation of the previous verse, about how Hashem's eyes are always upon the Land "from the beginning of the year to the end of the year?"

The answer, perhaps, is a simple one. As mentioned previously, much of this Torah portion is about a certain quid pro quo, reward and punishment. Rashi's comment serves to emphasize that G-d's eyes will always upon the Land. Unlike the rain, harvests, etc., this is not subject to change. G-d will always look after the Land in a very special way, no matter what.

Re'eh

Destroying by Failing to Destroy

This week's Torah portion begins by Hashem laying out two paths before us: the path of blessing if we follow Hashem's commandments, and the opposite if we do not. The Torah then begins to enumerate some of those statutes, and contains a very puzzling statement:

1. These are the statutes and ordinances that you shall keep to perform in the land which the Lord God of your fathers gives you to possess all the days that you live on the earth.

2. You shall utterly destroy from all the places where the nations, that you shall possess, worshipped their gods, upon the lofty mountains and upon the hills, and under every lush tree.

3. And you shall tear down their altars, smash their monuments, burn their asherim with fire, cut down the graven images of their gods, and destroy their name from that place.

4. You shall not do so to the Lord, your God.

How could we possibly thinking of doing so to Hashem? Rashi picks up on this, and addresses it in a long comment:

RASHI - "You shall not do so [to the Lord your God]: to burn sacrifices to God in any place you choose, but rather at the place that He will choose. Another explanation is: "And you shall tear down their altars... and destroy their name... [but] do not do so [to the Lord your God]"; this is an admonition [addressed] to one who would erase the Name [of God from any writing] or remove a stone from the altar or from the courtyard (Mak. 22a). Rabbi Ishmael said: Would it enter your mind that the Israelites would tear down the altars [of God]? Rather, [the meaning of "You shall not do so" is that] you should not do like the deeds of the nations so that your sins would cause the sanctuary of [i.e., built by] your fathers to be destroyed. — [Sifrei]"

Obviously, no one of the Jewish people would intentionally try to destroy Hashem's altar or His name. However, what the Torah is trying to tell us is that by allowing the worship of other gods, one would be in fact hurting Hashem's presence in the world. The utter destruction mandated by the Torah here parallels the total destruction of Amalek. Failure to destroy Amalek has a similar impact on Hashem's

name: “And he said, For there is a hand on the throne of the Eternal, [that there shall be] a war for the Lord against Amalek from generation to generation.” (Exodus 17:16)

RASHI - For there is a hand on the throne of the Eternal: The hand of the Holy One, blessed be He, was raised to swear by His throne, to have a war and [bear] hatred against Amalek for eternity. Now what is the meaning of כֵּס [as opposed to כִּסֵּא and also [why is] the Divine Name divided in half? [I.e., why is the Name יָ-ה used instead of י-ה-ו-ה ?] [The answer is that] the Holy One, blessed be He, swore that His Name will not be complete and His throne will not be complete until the name of Amalek is completely obliterated. And when his name is obliterated, the Divine Name will be complete, and the throne will be complete, as it is said: “The enemy has been destroyed; swords exist forever (לָנֶצַח)” (Ps. 9:7); this [who they are referring to] is Amalek, about whom it is written: “and kept their fury forever (נָצַח)” (Amos 1:11). “And You have uprooted the cities-their remembrance is lost” (Ps. 9:7) [i.e., Amalek’s obliteration]. What does it say afterwards? “And the Lord (וַיהוה) shall sit forever” (Ps. 9:8); thus [after Amalek is obliterated] the Name is complete. “He has established His throne (כִּסְאוֹ) for judgment” (Ps. 9:8). Thus the throne is complete [i.e., thus the throne, here spelled with an “aleph,” is now complete]. — [from Midrash Tanchuma, end of Ki Theitzei]

Amalek affects not only Hashem’s name, but also his throne. Perhaps that is also why this week’s Torah portion complements the discussion of the need to destroy altars and images of alien gods with a discussion of the ultimate place of G-d’s throne, Jerusalem:

5. But only to the place which the Lord your God shall choose from all your tribes, to set His Name there; you shall inquire after His dwelling and come there.

6. And there you shall bring your burnt offerings, and your sacrifices, and your tithes, and the separation by your hand, and your vows and your donations, and the firstborn of your cattle and of your sheep.

7. And there you shall eat before the Lord, your God, and you shall rejoice in all your endeavors you and your households, as the Lord, your God, has blessed you.

We find a similar parallel in Maimonides’ ruling regarding who is Mashiach, the messiah (Laws of Kings and Wars 1:4):

If a king will arise from the House of David who diligently contemplates the Torah and observes its mitzvot as prescribed by the Written Law and the Oral Law

as David, his ancestor, will compel all of Israel to walk in (the way of the Torah) and rectify the breaches in its observance, and fight the wars of God, we may, with assurance, consider him Mashiach.

If he succeeds in the above, builds the Temple in its place, and gathers the dispersed of Israel, he is definitely the Mashiach.

It is only after there is proper observance of Torah and the wars of G-d have been successfully fought, only can the Temple be built in its place. Then, as we say in the end of the Aleinu prayer, which concludes each of our daily services, "One that day, He will be One and His Name, One."

Shoftim

Justice as a Communal Obligation

The Torah portion of Shoftim begins with a discussion of the appointment of judges. Below are a few of Rashi's comments on this subject:

18. You shall set up judges and law enforcement officials for yourself in all your cities that the Lord, your God, is giving you, for your tribes, and they shall judge the people [with] righteous judgment.

Judges and law-enforcement officials: Heb. שֹׁפְטִים וְשֹׁטְרִים. שֹׁפְטִים are judges who decide the verdict, and שֹׁטְרִים are those who chastise the people in compliance with their order, (who strike and bind [not found in early editions]) with rods and straps, until he [the guilty party] accepts the judge's verdict.

and they shall judge the people [with] righteous judgment: Appoint judges who are expert and righteous so that they will judge justly. — [from Sifrei]

19. You shall not pervert justice; you shall not show favoritism, and you shall not take a bribe, for bribery blinds the eyes of the wise and perverts just words.

You shall not pervert justice: [This is to be understood] according to its apparent meaning.

you shall not show favoritism: Even during the statement of pleas [by the litigants]. This is an admonition addressed to the judge, that he should not be lenient with one litigant and harsh with the other, [e.g., ordering] one to stand [while allowing] the other to sit, because as soon as one notices that the judge is showing more respect toward his opponent, he cannot plead his case any longer [because he

thinks that it will be of no use].

20. Justice, justice shall you pursue, that you may live and possess the land the Lord, your God, is giving you.

Justice, justice shall you pursue: Seek out a good court. (Sifrei; San. 32b)

that you may live, and you possess [the land]: The appointment of fitting judges is sufficient merit to keep Israel alive and settled in their land. — [from Sifrei]

It's very interesting to note that Rashi establishes obligations not only on those in the government in charge of appointing judges, not only on the judges themselves, but also on the law-enforcement officers as well as on the guilty parties. Last but not least, is the obligation of every litigant in seeking out a good court.

The pursuit of justice is truly a communal mitzvah, applicable to every single person and to the nation as a whole. It therefore comes as no surprise that the reward for appointing fitting judges is also a national one: "sufficient merit to keep Israel alive and settled in their land."

Ki Tetzeh

Tackling the "Evil" Inclination

This week's Torah portion begins with speaking about going to war and finding a captive. Our sages teach us that even though the Torah seems to be speaking about a physical war against an enemy nation, the verses are also applicable to our own internal spiritual war, against the Yetzer HaRah, the evil inclination.

In fact, Rashi states as much quite explicitly, even though, his statement is usually read in a different way:

10. If you go out to war against your enemies, and the Lord, your God, will deliver him into your hands, and you take his captives, 11. and you see among the captives a beautiful woman and you desire her, you may take [her] for yourself as a wife.

RASHI:

ולקחת לך לאשה: לא דברה תורה אלא כנגד יצר הרע

you may take [her] for yourself as a wife: Scripture is speaking only against the evil inclination. For if the Holy One, blessed is He, would not permit her to him, he would take her illicitly. [The Torah teaches us, however, that] if he marries her, he will ultimately come to despise her, as it says after this, "If a man has [two wives-one

beloved and the other despised]" (verse 15); [moreover] he will ultimately father through her a wayward and rebellious son (see verse 18). For this reason, these passages are juxtaposed. — [Tanchuma 1]

The traditional reading of this Rashi is that, in permitting this marriage, the Torah is allowing the soldier to do, what he would likely do anyway because of his evil inclination. His desire for this woman would be so strong, that it's better to allow him to take her in a permissible way.

Perhaps an equally valid reading of Rashi would be simply to interpret Rashi to mean that this captive from your enemy's land is itself the evil inclination. All three segments mentioned by Rashi can be read in this way: the "beautiful captive" is the evil inclination, also the "despised wife," as well as the "wayward and rebellious son."

The evil inclination is not really "evil." It's is our natural, self-centered, animal instinct, which is base, yet nevertheless important for survival. In Kabbalah and Chassidut, instead of good and evil inclinations, the terms used are G-dly soul and animal soul.

The animal soul attracts us, on a base level because of the physical pleasures it can bring us, but on a higher level, for the mitzvoth we can accomplish with it. After all, most mitzvoth are physical in nature, so the physical drives of the animal soul are important to get the mitzvoth done in the best possible way. However, before being able to use the animal soul for mitzvoth, it has to be somewhat disarmed or "defanged:"

12. You shall bring her into your home, and she shall shave her head and let her nails grow. 13. And she shall remove the garment of her captivity from upon herself, and stay in your house, and weep for her father and her mother for a full month. After that, you may be intimate with her and possess her, and she will be a wife for you.

In Judaism, there are proper ways to perform physical acts that constitute mitzvoth. The most common are probably eating and having marital relations in a kosher way, but there are others as well, such as proper commercial dealings, proper speech, etc.

Not everyone in the Jewish people is necessarily required or up for the task of constantly engaging the animal soul to perform mitzvoth.

14. And it will be, if you do not desire her, then you shall send her away wherever she wishes, but you shall not sell her for money. You shall not keep her as a servant, because you have afflicted her.

There is room in Judaism for those that want to lead a more spiritual existence, such as those that wish to lead a life of Torah study. However, the Torah warns that one should not do so "for money." Pirkei Avot states, "Do not make the Torah into a crown with which to aggrandize yourself or a spade with which to dig."

Judaism does not believe in complete ascetism. Some level of physicality will always be present. Still, those that have "afflicted" their animal soul, and chosen not to use it for mitzvoth, will not be able to "keep her as a servant." For these people, the animal soul will not be a very strong tool or aid in their G-dly service.

Similarly, when it comes to the son of the beloved wife (the G-dly soul) and the son of the despised wife (the animal soul), a person must realize that the animal soul is actually the firstborn. The animal soul comes to a person first, much before the G-dly soul. One should not underestimate its importance.

17. Rather, he must acknowledge the firstborn, the son of the despised [wife] and give him a double share in all that he possesses, because he [this firstborn son] is the first of his strength, then he has the birthright entitlement.

Yet, there are aspects of the Yetzer HaRah that have no positive characteristics whatsoever. There are parts of the animal soul that are like Amalek: wayward and rebellious to the extreme, a "glutton and a guzzler." These parts have to be destroyed altogether:

21. And all the men of his city shall pelt him to death with stones, and he shall die. So shall you clear out the evil from among you, and all Israel will listen and fear.

The words in Hebrew for "listen and fear" are Yishme'u veYira'u, יִשְׁמְעוּ וְיִרָאוּ - containing the roots for Reiyah (sight) and Shmiyah (hearing). These in turn are the roots for the names Reuven and Shimon, the first two sons of Jacob.

A question arises as to how the above applies to our patriarch Jacob on a simple level. There is a tradition that our patriarchs were so spiritually sensitive that they kept the Torah much before it was given at Mount Sinai. If so, how is it that Jacob gave the right of firstborn to Joseph, the son of Rachel, the wife he most loved, instead of Reuben, the firstborn, son of Leah?

Comes the Torah and joins the segment regarding the sons of the two wives to the segment regarding the wayward and rebellious son. A son that is deserving of death certainly would not be entitled to anything. There are differences of opinions as to what exactly were the sins of Reuven, Shimon and Levi, but there is one sin that all the older brothers of Joseph committed, which is in fact punishable by death. This sin is also addressed in this week's Torah portion (Ch. 24):

7. If a man is discovered kidnapping any person from among his brothers, of the children of Israel, and treats him as a slave and sells him that thief shall die, so that you shall clear out the evil from among you.

The brothers kidnapped Yoseph HaTzadik (Joseph the Righteous) and sold him as a slave. Rashi explains that there are other requirements for the death penalty, which were not met by Joseph's brothers, such as witnesses and a warning, and treating the person as a slave. Nevertheless, the verse appears to be direct reference to Joseph's situation. By kidnapping Joseph, the older brothers appear to have forfeited their firstborn right. As the Torah itself shows, it was exactly by kidnapping Joseph that the brothers brought upon themselves the very thing they were trying to avoid: Joseph's rule over them.

In fact, we read about this verse on Yom Kippur, in the context of the death of the Asarah Harugei Malchut, the Ten Martyrs (including tzadikim such as Rabbi Yishmael and Rabbi Akiva) who were viciously killed by the Romans. The Roman emperor used this exact verse to justify killing the ten sages. He stated that their death was necessary to atone for the sin of the ten brothers of Joseph.

Let us not wait until Yom Kippur to remember the lessons of repentance and atonement. Let us start today, right now, to tackle our animal inclination, treat our brothers properly, and to attach ourselves to Tzadikim Amiti'im, the true sages, of our generation and of the past. May we then merit to see the true and complete redemption of our people and of the world at large.

Ki Tavo

Seeing the Whole Picture

This week's Torah portion, Ki Tavoh, begins with the description of the offering of the first fruits in the Temple and contains a long series of "curses" if the Jewish people do not follow Hashem's commandments.

In the ritual of bringing the first fruit, there is a fascinating recitation that each individual makes, in which he retells the story of the Jewish people. Its beginning, and particularly the choice of words used, is the subject of much commentary and debate:

5. And you shall call out and say before the Lord, your God, "An Aramean [sought to] destroy my forefather, and he went down to Egypt and sojourned there with a small number of people, and there, he became a great, mighty, and numerous nation.

RASHI - An Aramean [sought to] destroy my forefather: [The declarer] mentions [here] the kind deeds of the Omnipresent [by stating]: "An Aramean [sought to] destroy my forefather." That is, Laban, when he pursued Jacob, sought to uproot [i.e., annihilate] all [the Jews], and since he intended to do so, the Omnipresent considered it as though he had actually done it (Sifrei 26:5)...

who then went down to Egypt: And [apart from Laban,] still others came upon us to annihilate us, for after this, Jacob went down to Egypt ["and the Egyptians treated us cruelly..."].

with a small number of people: [Namely,] seventy persons. — [Sifrei 26: 5; see Gen. 46:27

The following verses go on to speak of how the Jews were miraculously saved by G-d's mighty hand and outstretched arm, and how they were brought now brought to the Land of Milk and Honey, and to the Temple.

Not only is the verse about the "Aramean" puzzling, but Rashi's comment, as well as its placement, is even more so. How is a description of the suffering of our forefather Jacob, as well as continued the suffering in Egypt and beyond, part of the description of the "kind deeds of the Omnipresent?" Yet, that is exactly the case. Rashi is coming to teach us that the end of the story is dependent on its beginning. The suffering in the hands of the Aramean is what helped transform Jacob into Israel. The suffering the Jewish people as a whole is what made possible for them to

have such a close and deep bond with G-d, to the point that they merited the revelation of G-d Himself and His miraculous redemption.

When one is in the middle of the suffering, one cannot hope to see how the present struggle will ultimately lead to positive and even miraculous outcome. When one plants a seed, that seed is stuffed into the ground and even decomposes. It is hard to see how this could lead to something good. Yet, when one has the first fruit in hand, and merits to bring it as an offering to G-d in the Temple itself, then it becomes clear that all that suffering was not in vain, but rather was fundamental in developing a closer relationship with G-d and in the success that followed.

This message is equally applicable to the curses that come towards the end of the Torah portion. The suffering described is also not for naught. It is part and parcel of the ultimate, highest blessings that are still to come. In fact these blessings are included in the very words used for the curses, albeit in a hidden fashion. It is simply a matter of interpretation.

Similarly, in a sense, Laban the Aramean did "destroy" Jacob, since Jacob was no longer the same after his experience living with such an evil and deceiving individual. The suffering and "destruction" that Jacob underwent made a him a better and stronger person, both spiritually and physically. This is true for Jacob as well as for all of his descendants. This was seen clearly in the times of the Tabernacle and of the first two Temples, and will be seen clearly again soon, with the building of the final Third Temple, speedily in our days.

Nitzavim · Vayelech

Being Strong and Courageous and Connected to the Head. (Nitzavim-Vayelech)

B"H

We're playing a bit of catch-up here, due to the high holidays and the entire month of Tishrei. Let's begin by addressing a theme that appears in Nitzavim as well as Vayelech.

The Torah portion of Nitzavim begins with the following verse:

You are all standing this day before the Lord, your God the leaders of your tribes, your elders and your officers, every man of Israel, (Devarim 29:9):

In Hebrew, the exact wording is רָאשֵׁיכֶם שִׁבְטֵיכֶם, [lit., "your leaders, your tribes,"], which leads Rashi to comment as follows: "The leaders of your tribes." Some suggest that Rashi's comments are necessary given that the leaders themselves are obviously part of their respective tribe. While that may be true, perhaps there is also a deeper point Rashi is trying to make, which is that when it comes to the "head," it makes little sense to speak of more than one. There is only one head. That head is the tribe, as Rashi notes in a different place, "HaNassi Hu HaKol," the head of the tribe is everything.

We see this in Rashi's discussion of apparently repetitive verses found in Vayelech, which are also repeated in the Book of Joshua. In Vayelech, Moshe urges the Jewish people as follows:

Be strong and courageous! Neither fear, nor be dismayed of them, for the Lord, your God He is the One Who goes with you. He will neither fail you, nor forsake you." (Devarim 31:6)

He then immediately urges Joshua in a similar manner:

7. And Moses called Joshua and said to him in the presence of all Israel, "Be strong and courageous! For you shall come with this people to the land which the Lord swore to their forefathers to give them. And you shall apportion it to them as an inheritance. (Devarim 31:6)

Towards the end of the Torah portion, he again urges Joshua:

And He commanded Joshua the son of Nun, and said: "Be strong and courageous! For you shall bring the children of Israel to the land that I have sworn to them, and I will be with you." (Devarim 31:23)

Rashi compares the two times that Moshe addresses Joshua, and draws a contrast between the two:

for you shall come with this people: Heb. כִּי אַתָּה תָּבוֹא אֶת-הָעָם הַזֶּה [as the Targum renders:]"For you shall come with this people," [hence, the אֶת here means "with." Accordingly, Moses' statement of leadership role to Joshua can be understood as follows]: Moses said to Joshua, "The elders of the generation will be with you, [for] everything should be done according to their opinion and counsel."

Rashi continues:

In contrast, however, the Holy One, Blessed is He, said to Joshua,"For you shall bring (תָּבִיא) the children of Israel to the land which I have sworn to them" (verse 23).

[God's statement of leadership role to Joshua here means:] "You shall bring them [even if it is] against their will! Everything depends [only] upon you; [if necessary,] you must take a rod and beat them over their heads! There can be [only] one leader for a generation, not two leaders for a generation."- [Sanh. . 8a]

While Joshua is told to take advice from the elders as a whole and to follow their opinions and counsel, he must also understand that he is the one in charge and the one that is ultimately going to be held accountable.

[As an aside, it is interesting that Rashi goes as far as stating that if necessary, Joshua is to take a rod and beat [the Jewish people] over their heads, because Moshe himself was punished for apparently much less than that, taking a staff and hitting a rock, instead of speaking to it. It comes to teach us that Moshe was not necessarily wrong in principle by hitting the rock, it's just that this was not what G-d had commanded.]

In the Book of Joshua, the repetition of the verse "be strong and courageous" is said to represent two different aspects of life altogether:

Be strong and have courage; for you will cause this nation to inherit the land that I have sworn to their ancestors to give to them. (Joshua, 1:6)

RASHI - Be strong and have courage: in worldly pursuits, as the Scripture states: "For you will cause this nation to inherit the land."

Just be strong and very courageous to observe and do in accordance with all of the Torah that Moses My servant has commanded you. Do not stray therefrom right or left, in order that you succeed wherever you go. (Joshua, 1:7)

RASHI - Just be strong and very courageous: in Torah, as the Scripture states: "To observe and to do in accordance with all of the Torah."

We also see that Joshua strength and courage as the head of the Jewish people is ultimately for the purpose of being connected to his head, Moses.

There is a very important application of the above in our daily lives, especially as the Torah portion of Nitzavim (as usually Vayelech as well) always comes before Rosh Hashanah. There is something to be learned from all the sages, all the Tzadikim, and there is certainly a way to do everything according to their will. Yet, at the same time, there must be one ultimate head of the generation, just as we observe only one head of the year. We also cannot choose to have one leader and apply a set of standards for "religious" considerations and another for worldly

matters. Ultimately, they both stem from the same place, and we must have a single leader (and set of principles) to guide us in both areas of life.

Again, that is not to say that we are not supposed to learn from all the sages (and from every individual, as stated in Pirkei Avot). Similarly, this is also not to say that there is not a hierarchy in leadership, just as each tribe had a leader, who in turn was ultimately subservient to their leader, the head of the entire generation. Ultimately even the head of generation is but simple and completely nullified and subservient slave in the hands of the One and Only. The King of kings, the Holy One, Blessed be He.

Haazinu

"Eclipse" in Leadership

In the Torah portion of Haazinu, we come across a very interesting verse:

And Moses came and spoke all the words of this song into the ears of the people he and Hoshea the son of Nun. (Devarim 31:44)

There appears to be an obvious contradiction/question within the verse itself: Who actually spoke the words of the song? Was it Moshe or was it Moshe and Yehoshuah together?

In order to answer this question, it is important to look into the previous Torah portion, Vayelech, which serves as an introduction to the song Haazinu itself. G-d's commandment regarding the song was not just to Moshe, but to Moshe and Yehoshuah together (Devarim 31:16-30):

14. And the Lord said to Moses, "Behold, your days are approaching [for you] to die. Call Joshua and stand in the Tent of Meeting, and I will inspire him. So Moses and Joshua went, and stood in the Tent of Meeting. (...)

19. And now, write for yourselves (plural) this song, and teach it to the Children of Israel. Place it into their mouths, in order that this song will be for Me as a witness for the children of Israel.

Rashi - this song: [This refers to the passage beginning with] הַאֲזִינוּ הַשָּׁמַיִם [until] וְכַפֶּר אַדְמָתוֹ עַמּוֹ (Deut. 32:1-43).

Yet, we see that it was not Yehoshua who wrote down the song, but Moshe:

22. And Moses wrote this song on that day, and taught it to the children of Israel.

23. And He [Rashi states that this refers to G-d] commanded Joshua the son of Nun, and said: "Be strong and courageous! For you shall bring the children of Israel to the land that I have sworn to them, and I will be with you."

24. And it was, when Moses finished writing the words of this Torah in a scroll, until their very completion,

Moshe, in the conclusion to the Torah portion of Vayelech, further states:

28. Assemble to me all the elders of your tribes and your officers, and I will speak these words into their ears, and I will call upon the heaven and the earth as witnesses against them.

29. For I know that after my death, you will surely become corrupted, and deviate from the way which I had commanded you. Consequently, the evil will befall you at the end of days, because you did evil in the eyes of the Lord, to provoke Him to anger through the work of your hands.

30. Then, Moses spoke into the ears of the entire assembly of Israel the words of the following song, until their completion.

We are left with at least a couple more questions. If Moshe is still the leader and the one that ultimately performs Hashem's commandment, why is Yehoshuah included at all in the commandment, as why does verse 31:44 imply that he was also the one that spoke the song to the Jewish people? And if Yehoshuah is also the one commanded to act, why doesn't he do so?

Now let us examine Rashi's comments to our initial verse:

And Moses came and spoke all the words of this song into the ears of the people he and Hoshea the son of Nun. (Devarim 31:44)

He and Hoshea the son of Nun: It was the Sabbath upon which there were two leaders, authority was taken from one and given to the other. — [Sotah 13b]

Rashi continues:

Moses appointed a meturgeman [literally, an interpreter, here a spokesman] for Joshua, [to relay to the public what Joshua said,] so that Joshua could expound [on the Torah] in Moses' lifetime, so that Israel would not say [to Joshua], "During your teacher's lifetime you did not dare to raise your head!" - [Sifrei 31:1]

Rashi further notes, still under the same verse:

And why does Scripture here call him Hoshea [for his name had long since been changed to Joshua (see Numb. 13:16)]. To imply [lit., to say] that Joshua did not

become haughty, for although he was given high status, he humbled himself as he was at the beginning [when he was still called Hoshea]. — [Sifrei 32:44]

Even though (as we mentioned in the last post) there can only be one leader, Rashi states that for this "Sabbath" there were actually two. The word Sabbath is particularly appropriate here, because just as the Sabbath is the culmination of the previous week and the foundation of the next, so too here, it was the culmination of Moshe's leadership and the foundation of Yehoshua's.

Rashi does nevertheless state that Moshe was the one that spoke the words of the song. It appears that, out of awe and reverence for his teacher, Yehoshua could not bring himself to act in any way that could make him comparable to Moshe. Yehoshua's reluctance is so strong, to the point that Hashem Himself, exclaims (as cited above) ""Be strong and courageous! For you shall bring the children of Israel to the land that I have sworn to them, and I will be with you." (Devarim 31:23) Moshe therefore appointed someone to amplify Yehoshua's words so that he could expound on the words of song and that all could hear him, further empowering Yehoshua as the new leader.

It would seem odd that Rashi comments that Moshe made Yehoshua speak in public in order to counter those that would say, "During your teacher's lifetime you did not dare to raise your head!" After all, that is exactly what a person is supposed to do when one is before his teacher! Not only that, we actually learn this particular lesson from Joshua himself, who previously answered a single question in front of Moses, ultimately causing him to remain childless. Here however, the situation is quite different because Yehoshua is no longer only the disciple of Moshe, but actually already the leader himself. For this brief moment, Moshe and Yehoshua's leadership eclipsed (literally, given that Moshe is compared to the sun and Yehoshua to the moon).

Finally, Rashi notes that despite this empowerment, Yehoshua humbled himself, just as he was at the beginning of his tutelage. It is not just that Yehoshua had become the leader and humbled himself, but that he was made to play a leadership role while Moshe, the greatest prophet of all time, was still alive and well. Despite the potential for Yehoshua, even if for a split second, to see himself as higher than Moshe, he nevertheless saw himself simply as Hoshea, which was his name before Moshe's blessing, which changed his name to Yehoshua. Yehoshua knew that he owed

everything to Moshe: not only his name, but also the very essence of who he had now become as the leader of the Jewish people.

VeZot HaBracha

Yosef, Mashiach Ben Yosef, Bittersweetness

B"H

When reading Moshe's blessing for the tribe of Yosef, there is one word that immediately stands out: Meged. It is repeated five times in a blessing that is itself only five verses long. Meged means "sweet," or "sweet fruits." It appears in Tanach also in Shir HaShirim, and Rashi states that it's used a metaphor for the sweet reward of keeping Hashem's commandments.

Looking at Moshe's blessing alone it is hard to understand the need for such repetition. However, in the context of Yaakov's blessing to Yosef (as well as to Yosef's sons Efraim and Menashe) it becomes easier to understand why Meged is indeed repeated so often.

As with the other tribes as well, there are incredible parallels between Moshe's blessing and Yaakov's. In addition, Moshe's blessing is also related to Yaakov's blessing for Ephraim and Menashe. We could spend pages and pages drawing parallels between these blessings, and how they in fact complement one another. Below, the verses for both Yaakov and Moshe's blessings (five verses each) are laid out, and then each verse is paired up to show just how similar the blesssings are.

Returning to the importance of the repetition of the word Meged in Moshe's blessing, there is also one aspect of Yaakov's blessing that truly stands out. Every verse in Yaakov's blessing is extremely positive, but there is one verse that recounts Joseph's suffering:

23. They heaped bitterness upon him and became quarrelsome; yea, archers despised him.

Rashi notes, in relevant part: "His brothers heaped bitterness upon him (Joseph), [and] Potiphar and his wife heaped bitterness upon him by having him imprisoned."

Despite the other amazing blessings that Joseph received, one cannot but remain with a certain "bitter taste" about Joseph's life and legacy. Embittered by his own brother, and then by the masters of the household he had served so loyally and

exceptionally.

Moshe comes to take away this bitterness by blessing Joseph with sweetness - five times, one for each verse of Yaakov's blessing (and his own).

Also, there appears to be a reference to the cause of Joseph's "bitter" encounters: his two dreams. The first one was agricultural, in which he saw his brother's sheaves bowing to his. The second, astrological, where not only his brothers' stars bowed to him, but even the sun and the moon as well. After the dreams, Jacob sends his son to Hebron, which is described as a deep valley, even though it was in fact a mountain. (Bereshit 37:14, See Rashi)

Moshe now endows these moments with sweetness. He speaks of the sweetness of the heavens as well as the "deep," the sweetness of the sun and the moon's yield, of the crops of mountains, hills, and of the land as a whole.

Moshe, who is from the tribe of Levi, originally one of the main instigators against Joseph, now comes to fix the past and sweeten it.

At the same time, Moshe's blessings may actually also be a reference to the future, concerning the progeny of Joseph and the times of Mashiach. In Zechariah, we find the following passage:

10. And I will pour out upon the house of David and upon the inhabitants of Jerusalem a spirit of grace and supplications. And they shall look to me because of those who have been thrust through [with swords], and they shall mourn over it as one mourns over an only son and shall be in bitterness, therefore, as one is embittered over a firstborn son.

11. On that day there shall be great mourning in Jerusalem, like the mourning of Hadadrimmon in the Valley of Megiddon.

Rashi - as one mourns over an only son: As a man mourns over his only son. And our Sages expounded this in tractate Sukkah (52a) as referring to the Messiah, son of Joseph, who was slain.

Moshe's blessings and emphasis on the word Megged may in fact be a prayer on behalf of Mashiach Ben Yosef, one that may mitigate the circumstance surrounding his death and even spare him of his fate altogether:

R. Isaac Luria (Ari-zal) notes that the descendant of Joseph, by being the precursor of the ultimate Mashiach, is in effect kissey David, the "seat" or "throne" of David, i.e., of Mashiach. Thus when praying in the daily Amidah, "speedily establish

the throne of Your servant David," one should consider that this refers to Mashiach ben Yossef and beseech G-d that he should not die in the Messianic struggle.16 As all prayers, this one, too, will have its effect.[10]

May we all do our part, and may we all merit to truly live in the times of Mashiach, immediately, in our days.

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Here are Yaakov's blessings regarding Ephraim and Menashe:

15. And he blessed Joseph and said, "God, before Whom my fathers, Abraham and Isaac, walked, God Who sustained me as long as I am alive, until this day,

הָאֱלֹהִים אֲשֶׁר הִתְהַלְּכוּ אֲבֹתַי לְפָנָיו אַבְרָהָם וְיִצְחָק הָאֱלֹהִים הָרֹעֶה אֹתִי מֵעוֹדִי עַד הַיּוֹם הַזֶּה׃
טו. וַיְבָרֶךְ אֶת יוֹסֵף וַיֹּאמַר

16. may the angel who redeemed me from all harm bless the youths, and may they be called by my name and the name of my fathers, Abraham and Isaac, and may they multiply abundantly like fish, in the midst of the land."

מַלְאָךְ הַגֹּאֵל אֹתִי מִכָּל רָע יְבָרֵךְ אֶת הַנְּעָרִים וְיִקָּרֵא בָהֶם שְׁמִי וְשֵׁם אֲבֹתַי אַבְרָהָם וְיִצְחָק וְיִדְגּוּ לָרֹב בְּקֶרֶב הָאָרֶץ׃
טז. הַמַּלְאָךְ הַגֹּאֵל אֹתִי

Yaakov's blessing to Joseph is as follows:

22. A charming son is Joseph, a son charming to the eye; [of the] women, [each one] strode along to see him.

כב. בֵּן פֹּרָת יוֹסֵף בֵּן פֹּרָת עֲלֵי עָיִן בָּנוֹת צָעֲדָה עֲלֵי שׁוּר׃

23. They heaped bitterness upon him and became quarrelsome; yea, archers despised him.

כג. וַיְמָרְרֻהוּ וָרֹבּוּ וַיִּשְׂטְמֻהוּ בַּעֲלֵי חִצִּים׃

24. But his bow was strongly established, and his arms were gilded from the hands of the Mighty One of Jacob; from there he sustained the rock of Israel,

כד. וַתֵּשֶׁב בְּאֵיתָן קַשְׁתּוֹ וַיָּפֹזוּ זְרֹעֵי יָדָיו מִידֵי אֲבִיר יַעֲקֹב מִשָּׁם רֹעֶה אֶבֶן יִשְׂרָאֵל׃

25. from the God of your father, and He will help you, and with the Almighty, and He will bless you [with] the blessings of the heavens above, the blessings of the deep, lying below, the blessings of father and mother.

אָבִיךָ וְיַעְזְרֶךָּ וְאֵת שַׁדַּי וִיבָרְכֶךָּ בִּרְכֹת שָׁמַיִם מֵעָל בִּרְכֹת תְּהוֹם רֹבֶצֶת תָּחַת בִּרְכֹת שָׁדַיִם וָרָחַם׃
כה. מֵאֵל

26. The blessings of your father surpassed the blessings of my parents, the ends of the everlasting hills. May they come to Joseph's head and to the crown (of the head)

of the one who was separated from his brothers.

בִּרְכַּת אָבִיךָ גָּבְרוּ עַל בִּרְכֹת הוֹרַי עַד תַּאֲוַת גִּבְעֹת עוֹלָם תִּהְיֶיךָ לְרֹאשׁ יוֹסֵף וּלְקָדְקֹד נְזִיר אֶחָיו׃
כו.

Now, Moshe's blessing (Devarim33):

13. And of Joseph he said: "His land shall be blessed by the Lord, with the sweetness of the heavens with dew, and with the deep that lies below,

יג. וּלְיוֹסֵף אָמַר מְבֹרֶכֶת יְהוָה אַרְצוֹ מִמֶּגֶד שָׁמַיִם מִטָּל וּמִתְּהוֹם רֹבֶצֶת תָּחַת׃

14. and with the sweetness of the produce of the sun, and with the sweetness of the moon's yield,

יד. וּמִמֶּגֶד תְּבוּאֹת שָׁמֶשׁ וּמִמֶּגֶד גֶּרֶשׁ יְרָחִים׃

15. and with the crops of early mountains, and with the sweetness of perennial hills,

טו. וּמֵרֹאשׁ הָרְרֵי קֶדֶם וּמִמֶּגֶד גִּבְעוֹת עוֹלָם׃

16. and with the sweetness of the land and its fullness, and through the contentment of the One Who dwells in the thornbush. May it come upon Joseph's head and upon the crown of the one separated from his brothers.

טז. וּמִמֶּגֶד אֶרֶץ וּמְלֹאָהּ וּרְצוֹן שֹׁכְנִי סְנֶה תָּבוֹאתָה לְרֹאשׁ יוֹסֵף וּלְקָדְקֹד נְזִיר אֶחָיו׃

17. To his firstborn ox is [given] glory. His horns are the horns of a re'em. With them, he will gore peoples together [throughout all] the ends of the earth these are the myriads of Ephraim, and these are the thousands of Manasseh."

לוֹ וְקַרְנֵי רְאֵם קַרְנָיו בָּהֶם עַמִּים יְנַגַּח יַחְדָּו אַפְסֵי אָרֶץ וְהֵם רִבְבוֹת אֶפְרַיִם וְהֵם אַלְפֵי מְנַשֶּׁה׃
יז. בְּכוֹר שׁוֹרוֹ הָדָר

Looking at the similarities between the verses of the two blessings, one could pair up each verse as follows:

22. A charming son is Joseph, a son charming to the eye; [of the] women, [each one] strode

along to see [Shur] him. בֵּן פֹּרָת יוֹסֵף בֵּן פֹּרָת עֲלֵי עָיִן בָּנוֹת צָעֲדָה עָלֵי שׁוּר׃ כב.

17. To his firstborn ox [Shor] is [given] glory. His horns are the horns of a re'em. With them,

he will gore peoples together [throughout all] the ends of the earth these are the myriads

of Ephraim, and these are the thousands of Manasseh." לוֹ וְקַרְנֵי רְאֵם קַרְנָיו בָּהֶם עַמִּים
יז. בְּכוֹר שׁוֹרוֹ הָדָר

יְנַגַּח יַחְדָּו אַפְסֵי אָרֶץ וְהֵם רִבְבוֹת אֶפְרַיִם וְהֵם אַלְפֵי מְנַשֶּׁה׃

[The references to Ephraim and Mannasseh parallels also the blessings previously made to them by Yaakov: “may they multiply abundantly like fish, in the midst of the land.”]

23. They heaped bitterness upon him and became quarrelsome; yea, archers despised him.

כג. וַיְמָרְרֻהוּ וָרֹבּוּ וַיִּשְׂטְמֻהוּ בַּעֲלֵי חִצִּים׃

14. and with the sweetness of the produce of the sun, and with the sweetness of the moon’s

yield, יד. וּמִמֶּגֶד תְּבוּאֹת שָׁמֶשׁ וּמִמֶּגֶד גֶּרֶשׁ יְרָחִים׃

24. But his bow was strongly established, and his arms were gilded from the hands of the

Mighty One of Jacob; from there he sustained the rock of Israel, כד. וַתֵּשֶׁב בְּאֵיתָן

קַשְׁתּוֹ וַיָּפֹזּוּ זְרֹעֵי יָדָיו מִידֵי אֲבִיר יַעֲקֹב מִשָּׁם רֹעֶה אֶבֶן יִשְׂרָאֵל׃

16. and with the sweetness of the land and its fullness, and through the contentment of

the One Who dwells in the thornbush. טז. וּמִמֶּגֶד אֶרֶץ וּמְלֹאָהּ וּרְצוֹן שֹׁכְנִי סְנֶה

25. from the God of your father, and He will help you, and with the Almighty, and He will

bless you [with] the blessings of the heavens above, the blessings of the deep, lying

below, the blessings of father and mother. וְאֵת שַׁדַּי וִיבָרֲכֶךָּ בִּרְכֹת שָׁמַיִם מֵעָל בִּרְכֹת כה. מֵאֵל אָבִיךָ וְיַעְזְרֶךָּ

תְּהוֹם רֹבֶצֶת תָּחַת בִּרְכֹת שַׁדַּיִם וָרָחַם׃

13. And of Joseph he said: “His land shall be blessed by the Lord, with the sweetness of

the heavens with dew, and with the deep that lies below, אָמַר מְבֹרָכֶת יְהוָה אַרְצוֹ יג. וּלְיוֹסֵף

מִמֶּגֶד שָׁמַיִם מִטָּל וּמִתְּהוֹם רֹבֶצֶת תָּחַת׃

26. The blessings of your father surpassed the blessings of my parents, the ends of the

everlasting hills. כו. בִּרְכֹת אָבִיךָ גָּבְרוּ עַל בִּרְכֹת הוֹרַי עַד תַּאֲוַת גִּבְעֹת עוֹלָם

15. and with the crops of early mountains, and with the sweetness of perennial hills,

טו. וּמֵרֹאשׁ הָרְרֵי קֶדֶם וּמִמֶּגֶד גִּבְעוֹת עוֹלָם׃

26 (b) May they come to Joseph's head and to the crown (of the head) of the one who was

separated from his brothers. תִּהְיֶיךָ לְרֹאשׁ יוֹסֵף וּלְקָדְקֹד נְזִיר אֶחָיו׃

16(B) May it come upon Joseph's head and upon the crown of the one separated from his

brothers. תָּבוֹאתָה לְרֹאשׁ יוֹסֵף וּלְקָדְקֹד נְזִיר אֶחָיו׃

NOTES

[1] Genesis, Ch. 37 - 39

[2] Genesis, 44:18

[3] Ezekiel 37:15; See Rabbi Matis Weinberg, Patterns in Time, on Chanukah

[4] The descendants of Yaakov numbered 70, paralleling the descendants of Noah, also 70, as stated in the Torah portion of Vayelech.

[5] Other "threes" in the Torah are the three mother letters in Kabbalah: Shin (Shem), Alef (Yaffet), Mem (Cham). There also seems to be parallels with the elements in nature that Moshe, Aharon, and Miriam represent water (Miriam's well), air/fire (clouds of glory/pillars of fire, in the merit of Aharon), and earth (the manna, in the merit of Moshe). After Miriam and Aharon's passing, all elements resumed in Moshe's merit alone (the well as well as the clouds of glory and the pillars of fire, as well as the mannah).

[6] The connection between the sons of Jacob, the Tribes, and the constellations is quite strong, as each constellation represents one of the Tribes, and the Jewish people are promised to be as numerous as the stars.

[7] It was fairly recently pointed out to me that Rashi's commentary is alluded to in the actual words said by Jacob, read in slightly different way (because the Torah has no punctuation, and is considered to be one long name of Hashem): אֲשֶׁר חָלָמְתָּ, contains the words רחֵל מֵתָה, Rachel is dead.

[8] The statement taken from אֲשֶׁר חָלָמְתָּ, would then use all letters, and be the one to be asked rhetorically: ? אֵשׁ רחֵל מֵתָה, "Has the fire of Rachel died? [Of course not]." The fire of the person stays long after the person is gone, just like Rebbe Nachman stated about himself, "my fire will burn until the coming of Mashiach."

[9] Likutei Moharan, Chapter 1; although Jacob is also connected to Tiferet.

[10] J. Immanuel Schochet, "Mashiach in Jewish Law," Appendix II, citing (Pri Eitz Chayim, Sha'ar Ha'amidah:ch. 19; and Siddur Ha-Ari; on this blessing. The Ari's teaching is cited in Or Hachayim on Leviticus 14:9, see there (and also on Numbers 24:17, where he relates this prayer to the next blessing of the Amidah); and see also Even Shelemah, ch. 11, note 6. Cf. Zohar II:120a (and Or Hachamah there), and ibid. III:153b) Available at: chabad.org